

K T M O R R I S O N

HIGH STAKES

DOMINATED BY THEIR LANDLORD



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KT MORRISON

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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Models on cover are meant for illustrative purposes only.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

HIGH STAKES

A LANDLORD Novel

51,000 words

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PART 1

REZA'S GYM occupied a hundred-and-fifty-year-old building on the edge of the city center. The place had been a hardware store when it was built. From photos in the gym's lobby, Jonny could see back in its heyday there was no city out this far yet, and the place looked like it was set in a rural village.

ROY'S HARDWARE, a sign read in bold painted letters out front over a corrugated metal awning. Horses were tied to posts, and Roy (he supposed) posed out front on the porch steps. The proud proprietor stood with men in wool pants, suit vests, rolled-up shirt sleeves, and sporting thick mustaches.

Out front today there were jacked-up pickup trucks, sports cars, and of course, Reza's V12 Mercedes sedan. The tin awning was gone these days, too, and not much remained of the way old Roy kept the place, except for the red brick façade and twin peaked roofs, done now in black steel.

Inside, metal clanked, men grunted, fists beat rhythm on punching bags, sneakers squeaked, heavy rubber Olympic plates bounded off cushioned floors... all under the drone of that same dumb rap song that played the other morning when he and Reza and Charlie all went down to the lawyers office to formalize his company's 5% exposure to Reza.

It was five minutes before 1 P.M., and he'd barely made it in time to the gym for the expressly important meeting with Reza. If it was so important,

the guy could have sent a car for him or something, but Reza would never do something to make things easier for Jonny, despite how sweet his promises may be. Like today's fun sounding proposition sent by text before Charlie headed out for work this morning... there was no way this would be good news for Jonny, no matter how Reza framed it, of that he was sure.

As he walked to the gym's reception desk, he stretched his back and shoulders. It had been an uncomfortable hour-long commute, jumping from subway lines to the M-line bus that brought him out to the edge of the city. Hot out today, so his pits had sweat a ring through his pale blue shirt, and the constant sitting had made the base-ring that circled his genitals and locked the cage in place squishing his privates uncomfortably—if it wasn't impossible, he'd actually believe his penis was shrinking. *What if it wasn't shrinking, but merely retracting—that wasn't impossible, was it?*

A ring of gym members circled around the reception station, leaning on elbows and chatting. While the gym itself seemed rough and masculine, the lobby was sleek and professional. The desk was a crescent with a black marble top and a line of blue LED lighting a beam below it. The receptionist was female and fit, her hangers-on male and large and intimidating. One other girl, a young Latina in tight black braids, hung back from the group and eyed him aggressively, looking from his feet to his face to his feet and back to his face again with a scowl.

The guys hanging by the counter watched over their shoulders and seemed bothered by his presence as if he were intruding, but he couldn't care less these days. He wedged between two of them and sidled up to the counter.

At least the receptionist was pleasant, giving him a grand and glossy smile, sassy ponytail swaying behind a smooth, tanned shoulder. "Hi there, sir," she bubbled. "Are you from the paper?"

"What paper?"

"You're not a reporter?"

“No—why?”

The big guy leaning next to him, eyeing him slyly, said, “Dude came here to get jacked.”

The receptionist said, “For the fight.”

Jonny said, “What fight?”

“Never mind, sorry, what can I help you with?”

“I have an appointment at one. With Reza.”

The buff guy beside him bristled.

“With Reza,” the receptionist repeated, her name tag reading Crystal, “oh, I’m sorry, *please*, hold on.” Her eyes went down to an iPad angled away from Jonny and her finger worked the screen. He waited and nodded, slipping his hands in his pockets to adjust his underwear.

“Sorry, I don’t see anything here,” she said, then looked at him with finality.

“I have a meeting with Reza at one. It’s Jonny Keen. We’re like... business partners.” His voice assumed some disdain, given the truth they were indeed business partners.

Now he was sure he was not called here for business today, but rather Reza’s pleasure. Reza’s most important business these days seemed to center on the world’s hottest commodity: a certain young wife of incredible, sweet and innocent beauty, long pale legs and shining ginger hair.

Fear crept up his back.

Crystal said, “Reza doesn’t take meetings here.”

“He does,” Jonny said, fishing his phone out of his pocket with a ball of dread forming in his guts. “He called me to come here. If he’s in the gym... fucking call him to the front, okay? Tell him Jonny Keen is here...” And now he was waving her off irritably and speed-dialing the library.

Was this some ruse? Get Jonny out of the apartment—and for what? He could picture Reza and Charlie sitting in first class air travel, headed to the

Maldives or somewhere, sipping champagne, the apartment emptied out, his workstation gone...

“Metro Public Library,” the softest, gentlest voice said on the other side of the phone, “How may I help you?”

He sighed with relief. Behind him over the loudspeaker it was announced: “Mr. Khan, can you come to the front desk, please, sir, Jonny Keen is here. Jonny Keen is here now,” she repeated, “he says he has a meeting...”

Jonny rolled his eyes and ran his hand through his hair. He walked with his back to the reception and stood by one of the old hardware store windows that looked out over the fancy cars in the parking lot. Traffic was busy though they were outside the city center and it was bumper-to-bumper out there. He said, “I’m looking for a recommendation on a book.”

“Okay, sir, I’d like to help you...”

He could picture her sitting one leg over the other on the stool at the front desk in the library maybe tapping a pen on the desk or between her front teeth with her hair tied up behind her, dressed in a pretty and slim outfit. He said, “I’m looking for a How-To book...”

“Okay...”

“I want to tell my wife that she’s the most beautiful, freckle-face girl in the world and I just darn tootin’ love her so much—but I’m so-oo shy... I need some help...”

“Jo-nny,” she chided, figuring out it was him.

“Hey, beautiful, how’s your day?” he asked her.

“Pretty good,” she said, all those mean images of her dissipating into a mist in the top of his head somewhere—there was no way his Charlie would run off with Reza, no way she would do that to him. She continued, “it’s almost lunch. Where are you? Are you at home? Do you want to meet me?”

“I’m out, but I’m out at business, Charlie. Work stuff I have to figure out... I’m on the other side of the city. But I was just thinking of you and I

had to call you.”

“Bless your heart,” she sighed.

“Jonny, what the fuck?”

An irritated voice behind him and he knew who it was without looking. It was deep and masculine. And savvy.

He said “I got to go, okay, sweetheart... I’ll see you tonight. I’ll meet you on the couch and we’ll do dinner.”

“Pizza?” she sang.

“Sure thing. You bring it home?”

“I’ll swing by Angelo’s,” she said, and it didn’t even bother him this time.

“I love you.”

“I love you, too,” she said, and they hung up.

When he turned, Demetrius was standing in the archway on the left side of the gym’s reception desk. He looked irritated, but it was that kind of pretend-irritated—Demetrius liked to keep you on your heels—and he couldn’t hide the smirk on his face.

His black skin shone with sweat. He wore a cut off T-shirt and his hands were taped up, a pair of boxing gloves pinched between his elbow and his waist. He swiped at his forehead, said, “Just fucking come in. What the hell is wrong with you, putting that announcement on the loudspeaker?”

“She said I didn’t have an appointment.”

Demetrius said, “Just come in, Reza’s in the back. Jesus.” He waved a hand in circles with irritation, intending Jonny to hurry up.

Jonny did, put his phone in his pocket and shuffled slowly to greet him—partly in rebellion, but partly because it wasn’t exactly comfortable right now between his legs.

The irritation gone now they’re side-by-side, the two of them walked together through the gym between Olympic stands and squat racks and

massive weight machines with huge guys lifting incredible amounts of weight.

Demetrius said, "So, hey man, how's it been going?"

"Busy. You know..."

Demetrius said, "How's that game coming? It was looking good, my man..."

"It's coming along pretty fucking awesome."

"Oh yeah? You gonna let me see it sometime?"

"I'll have a playable sometime soon."

"Invite me over, player. I'll fuckin' put it through its paces, tell you what's up. You know I can play."

"Yeah, maybe. We'll see."

"And, uh, so how's Charlie?" Demetrius asked slyly.

"She's fine," he said coldly.

"She ever ask about me?"

Jonny grunted and gave him a funny look. "What do you mean Ask about you?"

"You know, she ever say What's up with Demetrius?"

"Why would she say that?"

"Hey man, I'm just asking. I think about her a lot."

"Yeah, I know. But why would she think about you?"

"We had some good times, me and her."

"When?"

"Jesus, Jonny. Right in front of you."

"That was it?"

"Oh, ho, ho, ho," Demetrius laughed and slapped at his stomach. "You think she might be seeing me on the side. She might, my man, she might. I hear she gets around. Comes by this gym twice a week and Reza picks a dude name out a hat and your Charlie never backs down. Charlie takes all comers. On her back, on all fours, on her knees..."

“You’re such an asshole.”

“And you’re so easy to push around, your tach got a redline, like, at fifty RPMs, homeboy. You gotta chill out sometime, man, you gonna blow all your gaskets. Ay, Jonny, maybe when you call me over play your game I’ll bring some killer kush. Fuckin’ get Jonny baked. Get him to re-lax.”

“I’m fine,” Jonny said firmly, hands going to fists in his pockets.

“Hey, sure you are,” Demetrius said. “This is me here, man,” he said, collecting the beaten boxing gloves together and stopping in front of a still-swaying punching bag that had seen some abuse. While he stretched his hands into the gloves, he nodded his chin deeper into the gym and said, “The man’s working out in back. You better skedaddle, he say you late.”

“I’m on time,” Jonny said.

“Uh-huh,” Demetrius said, squinting, challenging him. “Five after one, Rip van Winkle. You sleep in this A.M.?”

“I got here at five-to,” Jonny said, shaking his head and waving Demetrius off.

Before he turned his back, Demetrius said, “Say hi to Charlie for me, Jonny,” then exploded in a flurry of body blows that rocked the bag and jangled its chain.

HE STOOD at a crossroads of concrete paths that transected various areas of the huge gym. Punching bags and cardio equipment behind him, ahead there were rubberized square-tile swatches with weight machines, more Olympic lifting platforms, squat racks and bench setups. Deeper, he could see three boxing rings; two empty, and spectators gathered around the third, watching two big men spar.

With his head down, he wove through the heavy weight area avoiding glares from any of the sweaty, grunting, pumped-up animals, then saw one hairy and burly, black-haired beast at the furthest point before the boxing

rings. It was Reza, preparing to lift a well-stacked barbell off the rubber floor.

When he saw Jonny, Reza nodded without saying anything, probably trying to stay focused, but he tapped his bare wrist where he normally wore a Rolex to indicate Jonny was late. Jonny didn't give him the satisfaction of any response and merely gazed at him blankly.

There were two burly attendants hanging around, one with his hands on his hips, the other pacing and clapping his cupped hands, saying, "Let's go, let's go, big man," and "You get that, Reza." His landlord's very own hype men.

Reza tightened the thick double-prong belt around his waist, walked a circle, grabbed a handful of powdered chalk from a bowl sat on a metal stand then whomped his hands together, slapping a cloud of white dust he now marched through with his eyes focused on the weight he intended to lift.

With no hesitation, Reza inhaled and held it, stooped and clasped the bar, thick hands gripping strong, pulling up till his arms were straight and tight, straightened his back, tilted his neck, black-bearded face coming up to look at Jonny. His body strained, muscles bulged, veins rose like hoses; slowly the stacked multicolor weights began to raise off the floor.

"It's all you, baby, it's all you," hype man one shouted and clapped, hype man two choosing "You got this, you got this," as his own mantra.

Reza's breath hissed through clenched teeth, and his head shook as he shakily straightened to stand upright, the barbell bowing with the massive weight it supported. Once fully upright, his goal was complete; the two supporters whooped and hollered, one jumped and punched the air. Reza exhaled fully, let the bar fall where it bounced and boomed mightily through the gym. Reza was pleased, and while the hype men clapped his back and continued to hoot, he walked around in a circle undoing the weight belt, head down and nodding to himself.

Reza wore fancy and expensive looking track pants, black with red stripes, and they showed off his thick, muscular legs, his bulge, too, if you looked; a white undershirt tank top that displayed his hairy muscle and tattoos.

Belt handed to one of the others, he waved Jonny over.

He still breathed heavily, powerful body taxed by the brief but mammoth exertion. Close to him now, Jonny could feel the man's damp body heat. His skin shone with sweat that glittered in his thick, matted body hair.

"Come on, Jonny, hurry up, I have appointments this afternoon."

Jonny said, "I was on time. You're the one still lifting weights. You're taking up *my* time."

"How's the game coming?" Reza asked him, gesturing for Jonny to head toward the sparring man at the back.

"It's perfect. I'll have a demo soon."

"Before my new house is ready, or should I get Charlie to pick out our bedding and draperies?"

"She won't be moving in with you," he said flatly.

"This must be some game, she's going to give up all I give her."

"It is," Jonny said.

"Glad to hear it, Jonny. Hey, you know, things are looking good for me, too."

"Swell."

"Hey, you ain't happy for me?"

Jonny said, "Ecstatic," as they crossed another concrete laneway and entered the sparring area where everyone was gathered.

Reza nudged him with a thick forearm that left Jonny's own arm sweaty, said, "You should be. Good things for me means good things for you. We make a good team, much as you struggle and squirm, try to make shit harder."

“Why’d you call me here?”

“Check this out,” he said, nodding his chin toward the boxing ring. It was elevated about three feet off the floor and bordered off with two bright yellow, but grubby ropes. Under a low hanging rack of lights, two heavyweights faced off, circling, darting toward each other, avoiding, jabbing. One man was black, about two-twenty-five, with a stretchy white long sleeve shirt, red gloves and big red cushioned headgear around his face. The other guy was also large and impressively built, his big arms and massive chest stretching out a black, long sleeve spandex shirt; his headgear and gloves were white. After a moment watching the two men move around, sensing each other out, he realized the one in the black shirt was Tate.

The group gathered around to watch sensed Reza’s presence, looking over their shoulders and giving him space to get up front. Jonny joined Reza at ringside and they watched the two men spar.

Reza nudged him again with an elbow, said, “See, this is another great thing happening. Big fight this weekend.”

“Tate?”

Reza nodded and watched as the black guy shot forward and tried to grab Tate’s waist and pull him down. Tate stepped aside swiftly and his opponent scrambled to gather himself realizing he was open.

“Where?” Jonny asked. “Here?”

“Here?” Reza scoffed. “No. City Center. 15,000 people, Jonny. How we get them all in here?”

“I don’t know shit about it,” Jonny said.

“Good. Keep your nose stuck in your computer, make me some money with this kids game.”

“It’s not for kids. It’s for everybody. And I don’t know shit about the fight because I don’t care about you or Tate, or anything you do. Can you just tell me why I’m here? I should be working.”

Reza still watched Tate, smiling now, elbows resting on the canvas flooring of the ring.

Tate circled, and now his sparring partner lunged for a takedown again and Tate sidestepped, slapped a quick but pulled punch to the guy's kidney. As he turned, reeling, Tate advanced, but the black guy only managed to put up a weak defense before Tate was on him, jabbing high then diving low. It was over quickly.

Tate threw him down, spun around and ended up with the other guy facedown on the mat with one arm twisted behind his back, clutched against Tate's chest.

As the black guy's gloved hand tapped the canvas in surrender, Reza let out a sharp piercing whistle and Tate stood, helping his sparring partner up, Reza jerked his head to the side. Tate nodded.

Reza said, "Come on, Jonny, let's hit the showers."

THE GYM'S locker room bustled with fit men of all sizes and ages, banging lockers, swinging towels and weaving to and fro around the sinks and urinals. Hand dryers bellowed and whined, dudes blowdried their hair in front mirrors with towels around their waists. Some didn't bother with the protocol, walking around with their genitals bared.

Reza steered them to the right, and they walked through a single door that led them to a private changing area. It was well appointed, with gleaming wood walls and halogen lights. There were only two banks of lockers in here and a single bench. It was much quieter now they were out of the public area. Beyond the locker room's bathrooms and sinks he could see a tiled room lined with shower heads. Steam billowed as someone showered in there unseen.

Reza was removing his shirt while walking and said, "We gotta make this quick, Jonny. I have a meeting in forty-five. But like I said, I just couldn't wait to present this to you."

Hands still in his pockets, Jonny grumbled, "I'm sure it's amazing." He looked over his shoulder to see Tate walking grimly behind, and also joining them were the two hype men who'd clapped their hands while Reza deadlifted.

Reza said, "I think you're gonna like what I have to offer, Jonny."

They stopped at the bench and Reza opened a locker.

Jonny said, "I'm sure it's not going to cost me a thing."

"Nothing in life is free, Jonny. You know that more than anybody. At least what you pay isn't dollars."

No, what he paid was his wife's purity.

Reza was shirtless now, smelling the shirt he'd pulled off and not liking it. He bristled with hair and shone with sweat. His muscles were large and swollen from exertion, and the veins rose in his biceps and through his shoulders. He jammed his thumbs in the front of his sweatpants and pulled them down. He wore no underwear, and his big, sweaty member swung freely between his legs as he pulled his feet from them.

The locker next to Jonny opened, and he looked to see Tate now doing the same, pulling off his tight Lycra long sleeve shirt and throwing it in the locker while the other two took up Tate's headgear and gloves and put them in a separate storage bin near the bathroom.

Reza said, "I didn't call you down here for nothing, Jonny. If you think all I care about is making your day suck, you don't know me. Your life has changed. Tell me it hasn't."

He couldn't answer. His life had changed; it was fucking obvious. "Yeah, it's changed," he said finally.

"Damn right it has," Reza said, one of the hype men handing him a clean white towel. He tucked it under his arm and stood now in front of Jonny with his cock out. "I make things better wherever I go."

"I'm sure you think you do," Jonny said. One of the hype men bristled and Tate slammed his locker. Jonny turned now to see him naked as well. One of the hype men stepped forward and handed Tate a towel.

Reza said, "Take your shit off, Jonny, let's hit the showers."

"I didn't work out. I don't need a shower, I showered already."

"I don't give a shit, Jonny. I did. Tate did. We have to shower, and I've got a meeting. You want to hear what I gotta say get your fucking ass in the

shower.”

“Just tell me what it is.”

“Take your shit off, less you wanna come in like that. Comfortable bus ride home, you sitting there with your clothes drenched,” Reza said then turned to walk toward the showers.

Jonny said, “What about?—” *The cage.*

“Everybody knows about it, Jonny. It’s not a surprise.”

The two hype men disrobed as well, doffing their things and throwing them on to the bathroom counter. They eyed him warily then joined Reza and Tate in the shower.

He could do without this. He could do without all of this. But he did want to know what Reza had to offer. It would cost him something but maybe he could afford it. Maybe it would be something he *really* wanted. He had to find out. He didn’t come all this way to turn around now, go home.

He undid the buttons on his shirt and took off his pants. His cock and balls were gripped in a small stainless-cabled bundle. A misshapen, indiscernible brown-flesh ball that looked far too small right now to contain male genitalia. He stuffed his things into an empty open locker.

As he walked through the bathroom, he snatched a towel from the counter and hung it on a hook outside of the shower stalls.

REZA AND TATE were already soaping themselves up, the two hype men were on the opposite side getting their temperatures adjusted, standing with hands on the levers, other hands held out in the stream of water.

The shower’s existing occupant was a large black guy who had his back turned, scrubbing his face as water splashed off his muscle. The two hype men looked between Jonny’s legs with curious lowered brows. Jonny

looked as well, saw his small shriveled genitals constricted by the stainless wires of his cage.

He took the empty shower spigot next to Reza and turned the water on, standing like the hype men did with his hand under the stream waiting for it to get hot.

Reza began, “So listen, Jonny,” scrubbing a bar of soap in his hairy underarms while his dick swung around, “like I said, things are picking up for me, too. A lot of opportunities out there. I hate to see my *current* opportunities go wasted while I take advantage of them—others can share my benefits, too.”

“Oh, yeah?” Jonny said, waiting for the punch line.

Reza said, “I got a lot of travel coming up.”

Jonny said, “You want to take Charlie to the Bahamas.”

“Nope. No tagalongs this trip. Charlie doesn’t like to be ignored. Fuck, she’s so cute when she’s ignored and it makes her *beg* for it, and I love to see her beg, but I can’t be distracted, Jonny. Way too important shit going on. I’m going to be away. Meetings, meetings, meetings. Europe next weekend, weekend after that I’m in Africa. You believe that shit? Africa of all places. Burgeoning markets, Jonny. Maybe you would know about them if you didn’t play games all day.”

“I don’t play games.”

“You’re playing a game every minute you breathe, Jonny.”

Jonny soaped himself, keeping his back to the other side of the shower to hide his bundled shame.

Reza said, “So that’s two weekends I’m away. You get it?”

“I get it,” he said, seeing where this might be going and not liking it.

Reza said, “That’s two weekends where it’s just you and Charlie left all alone. The two of you alone in that apartment, my Charlie unattended.”

“So what do you want to do?” Jonny asked.

“How would you like a gift from me?”

“A gift?” he said with sarcastic flair. “It’s not going to cost me anything?”

“It’s just going to cost you a gift of your own. Not a gift to me, Jonny.”

“To Charlie?”

Reza said, “What would you do if I said I’d be willing for you to have a whole weekend with Charlie and you don’t have to wear that stupid cage on your little dick.”

Jonny rolled his eyes. “I would want that.”

Reza stopped scrubbing for a moment, leaned his shoulder on the tiled wall as water splashed around his hair and he shook his head, sprinkling water. He leaned forward, out of the stream, said, “Wouldn’t you? Doesn’t that sound fantastic? I won’t be there, Jonny. I swear I won’t be there. I’m talking forty-eight—no, wait, *sixty* full hours without me. Sixty full hours just you and Charlie, no phone calls from me, no nothing. I swear. A weekend like I don’t exist.”

His heart began to race. He did want that. He wanted it so bad.

He said, “You know I want that.”

Reza said, “Right? Who wouldn’t want that? Sixty hours alone with that beautiful wife of yours. And she’s always so eager. You can get a lot done in sixty hours. You would fill her up till she’s overflowing in sixty hours, am I right?” He sneered.

Gross.

“I do want that. I really want that, Reza.”

Reza smiled and said over his shoulder to naked Tate, “Jonny wants that. See that? He comes in here all rigid, trying to keep me at bay, how long did it take me before he’s nibbling seed out of my hand? He’s a curious little chipmunk.”

Tate still scrubbed his muscular arms with his back to them, but Jonny could see him chuckle.

Jonny said, “I’m not eating out of your hand.”

“Relax, Jonny. I’m just trying to be funny. Just fucking with you. I’m offering you a *kindness* here. Things got a little rocky between you and me, don’t you see it? And yet I’ve got everything I want. You’ve given it to me. And now here you are, you say you’re almost done your game, and that’s money in my pocket. I got your wife dancing on my dick every night and she never complains. Maybe she complains a little when she’s not getting it, but when I’m around, I’m eager to give it to her. She takes it so well, Jonny. She’s the best fuck I’ve got in the city, and I’m not kidding.”

“It’s amazing we’re at odds,” Jonny said.

Reza was serious now. He said, “You can act the smart ass big shot all you want, Jonny. You’re getting what you want, too. I know you act like you hate it, but deep down you know you don’t. You know you like watching Charlie get what she wants. Stop being so bitter all the time, you’re wrecking it for everyone.”

Jonny said, “I said I wanted it. What’s it going to cost me?”

Reza got under the spray again, let the blast hit his face. Water streamed down his muscular body and ran in a dribble from the end of his big penis.

Jonny turned outward, getting the water on his back. The two hype men were across from them watching, looking at the little cage bundling his genitals. The black guy turned around now, too, getting water on his back and putting the soap on the ledge beside him. He looked between Jonny’s legs and his eyebrows went up and his head jolted. He said to one of the hype man, “What the fuck is that shit?”

Hype man two shrugged his shoulders and said, “Dude’s wife doesn’t trust him or something, I guess. Put him in chastity.”

The black guy snickered, and in a baritone, said, “With that little thing? Shoot, she think she have to lock that up?... That’s a hard sell. Who he gonna cheat with?”

That got the two hype men laughing. Jonny covered up, putting two hands over the cage.

Reza said, “I told you about that fight, Jonny. Fifteen-thousand people coming out to see my man Tate knock out Ivas Ivankiv. Big fucking dude from the Ukraine. Now, I own Tate. He’s in my stable. He’s my fighter. And he’s doing good for me, Jonny. So good. This guy makes money. Knocks out whoever we send him and the ones he don’t knock out he fucking chokes them, leg locks them, snaps their arm... You know what I’m saying? Unbeaten.”

“Yeah?” Jonny said, at least enjoying the warm water on his shoulders.

“So, as any good fight promoter and fighter owner would do, I gotta offer my man a bonus. He wins, he gets thirty-five grand. That’s from the commission. I share another twenty or so with him that we collect from the door because Tate means a lot to me. But I want to give him a *gift*, you know? I want something from my heart. Something money can’t buy.”

Jonny’s testicles rolled in their sack and pulled into his body before snagging on the tight stainless ring.

Reza said, “I think you know what I’m saying. So listen, I just asked him: Tate, what’s going to make you happy? What can I *get* you? I mean, I could lease him a truck, right? That’s easy. What do you want? We’ll go down to the lot set you up with a Hemi. We can make it special—maybe I’ll go get you something vintage. Like an old Camaro or something and we can pretend it has meaning. But does it have meaning? Still just a car... Jonny, Tate’s a good guy. You know he’s a good guy. I asked him what would make him happy... What did he tell me?”

“I don’t know,” Jonny said, but he did know.

“Tate says he wants your wife.”

JONNY REELED, his head going foggy and the steam in the room billowing in white clouds before his vision and blocking it out. Was it steam or was he losing consciousness?

He stumbled a step back and felt the safety of tiled wall against his shoulders.

Reza continued. "Tate tells me if he wins he wants a weekend with your wife. He's got a thing for her. Don't we all? She is the sweetest, sexiest..."

"No way," Jonny croaked.

Reza said, "That's cool. Like I said, everything is negotiable. Maybe this isn't. You don't want Tate, that's fine." He slapped his hands together like it was settled. "Course, then you don't get your weekend with Charlie."

Jonny let his head fall back so the crown bumped the tile. He said, "Tit for tat."

"None of this works pro bono," Reza said. "And you gotta know that about me by now."

"I know," he said.

Reza said, "So whatever. I'm away two weekends. Opportunities missed. Why do I give a fuck, right? I'll be on the other side of the world. You two can mope around your apartment with your little dick locked up, I don't give a shit. I'm just offering opportunities. It's up to you to take them."

"What would it mean?"

"What would what mean?"

"Tate and Charlie. What does that mean?"

"I don't know. That's up to Tate. Up to to Charlie, too. But I think she likes him. They can do whatever they want. They got a whole weekend together. And here's the thing: you have to stay there."

"I *want* to be there."

Reza shrugged. "Then what's the problem?"

"He's going to do things with her?"

"I suppose so. Less he wants to just go hang out with Charlie and she can tell him all about how the library works. You don't want that, do you, Tate?"

Tate shrugged and gave no expression.

“I don’t think Tate wants that, Jonny. I think Tate wants the full girlfriend experience. You know what that is?”

“I’ve heard.”

“Yeah, that’s right. The full girlfriend experience. You can rent a whore for a weekend she’ll act like she loves you. I’m betting that’s what Tate wants.”

Over Reza’s shoulder, Jonny saw Tate scowling.

Jonny said, “I don’t know.”

“I don’t know how to sell this to you anymore, Jonny. What you get in return is everything you want right now. A weekend like before any of us ever met. A weekend where it’s just you and Charlie and you watch your dumb TV shows and prance around your apartment like a couple of college kids. That’s of course right after the weekend big Tate comes in, lays her down and shows her what a man’s like.”

“If he wins his fight.”

“That’s right. If he wins his fight. You’re smart, Jonny.”

“What if he loses?”

“He isn’t gonna lose.”

Tate gave an uneven smile and glowered at Jonny.

Reza said, “Agree to it and you get your weekend no matter what.”

Jonny groaned and rubbed the heels of his hands into his eye sockets. The idea had begun to swell things between his legs and the cage pinched him.

“All right,” he moaned so quietly Reza didn’t hear him.

“I think I heard what I like,” Reza said. “Did I?”

“All right,” Jonny said in a growl and swung his hands down to pound the tile wall at his thighs. His caged penis jiggled. “All right, all right, all right.”

“There we go. Just like that. I wish all meetings were as easy as this one. One I gotta go to now is going to take a lot more fight. But I *will* win. All right, let’s go—I gotta suit up.”

BACK IN THE CHANGE ROOM, Jonny went to his locker left open with his things stuffed in it. Reza closed it and it locked.

“What the fuck are you doing?”

“We need to talk.”

“Reza, open my locker. I have to get back to work.”

“I will in a minute. After we talk.”

“Talk about what?”

“What do you think?”

“I have no idea.”

“How’s your cage?”

“Tight. I hate it. What do you think?”

“Getting work done?”

“I told you how great things are g—”

Reza smiled and Jonny stopped talking.

Reza said, “You see what I’m saying, don’t you?”

He suspected but asked, “What...?”

“You know. Why did we put this cage on your little dick?”

“To torture me?”

“Oh really? That’s why?”

“Why else?”

“Come on, Jonny. Man like me? You think I get off on doing things with other dude’s dicks...”

“You like controlling people.”

“I won’t deny that. I don’t get off on your sex stuff, Jonny. Now again: Why did we put that cage on your little dick?”

“It’s not little.”

Reza chuckled, and the others followed suit. “Why, Jonny?”

Jonny hesitated, hated giving in. “So I would work,” he said, teeth gritted.

“Right. You have Charlie on the brain. Shit, all the guys in this room have Charlie on the brain and not all of them have even fucked her yet.”

“Come on... They’re not going to.”

“Jonny, you got that hot little redhead on the brain and I don’t blame you. You wear that cage for Charlie’s sake. That cage is your chance to get her back. You’re fucking it up.”

“Fucking it up? How you mean?” In his mind’s eye he could picture Charlie in bed last night, her eyes flitting around the room casting suspicious glares in the spots she suspected Reza might have hidden cameras.

Reza said, “Genesis is pretty familiar with your dick. I had her run an errand for me, and she assures me she’s solved your problem.”

“What’s my problem?”

“You’re a horny, young, unfocused dude with a ten for a wife. I don’t blame you for being distracted. You hit the jackpot. I don’t know if you hypnotized that girl or what but you bagged a filly. The two of you together looks like a kidnapping.”

The hype men chuckled, the two of them leaning and watching from the opposite bank of lockers.

Reza continued. “I don’t blame you, but you’re fucking up.”

“How?”

“Trying to work around the cage...”

Jonny felt caught, like denying it would be futile. he showed Reza a blank expression and watched as the mustache of Reza’s beard crept upward on one side as he smiled. Without saying a thing he felt somehow to Reza his suspicion had been confirmed. Either that or the bastard really did have cameras in the apartment.

Reza smiled with a strange affection, black eyes glimmering in the spotlights’ cone of halogen light. “Like I said, I don’t blame you at all, Jonny. This is for your own good. Have a seat there,” he said, gesturing a hand to the bench. When Jonny sat down, head down but looking toward the hype men, Reza told him to straddle the bench.

“Straddle it?”

“One leg on either side. Like you’re riding a horse.” He reached into his locker, looking for something.

Jonny gathered the towel around himself even though all the men had already seen the cage locked on his privates. It was somehow worse in here, the lights bright, no steam to obscure the vision. One leg on either side of the bench as instructed he sat down and bundled the towel between his legs.

Reza had withdrawn something from the locker but hid it in his grip.

“Move the towel, Jonny.”

Jonny sighed and rolled his eyes, moved the towel aside and put it behind him on the bench. For some reason, his penis was pulsing and beginning to strain against its cage.

Reza’s other hand disappeared back into his locker for a second, came back out with the zipping sound of a thin metal chain against aluminum. He showed Jonny what it was: held between thumb and finger was the key to his cage, the long necklace chain dangling down.

“You’re taking it off?”

“Swapping it out, Jonny.”

“Swapping—”

Reza opened his other hand and held it out. In the center of his palm rolled an opaque silicon tube with a flared shape on the end like the head of a cock. There was a black rubber ring with a brass lock on it. The whole thing was small enough to be hidden in Reza's hand.

"This cage is fine," Jonny said, putting his hand between his legs and holding onto his bundled genitals. His balls ached.

"You know it's not, Jonny. It doesn't serve its purpose, and its purpose is to help you."

"Is that one *smaller*?"

Reza held his palm up so he could look at it. "I suppose it is. You'll need help getting it on. Tate, sit across from Jonny, please."

Tate didn't flinch and Jonny suspected the guy knew this was coming—but he did run his hand in a circle over his wet hair and looked to hesitate.

"Tate, hurry," Reza said, "I have to get going."

"Yeah," Tate muttered, put his hands on his hips, head down, came to the bench and put a leg over. His towel opened in a V and Jonny could see his dick hanging down. Reza was also naked, standing beside him, and he could see the two mens' penises compared. Both large, Reza inching Tate out; Reza's was gnarly and wrinkled, heavy folds of reddened foreskin closed over his tip. Tate's was attractive. Circumcised, smooth skinned, the glans healthy and well-formed.

Reza handed Tate the key to Jonny's cage and Tate sat down with his legs open, that big penis (that Charlie was attracted to) flopped to lay out on the bench between his legs.

Tate looked down and muttered something unintelligible to himself.

Reza said, "Swap his cage out, Tate. You don't want your new girlfriend playing with his little dick, do you?"

Tate inhaled in preparation, reached his big hands between Jonny's legs and Jonny's stomach started to flutter. He folded his hands over his chest and put his shoulders up like he was cold.

“She’s not his girlfriend,” he said.

Tate slipped the key in the cage’s lock and jiggled it. The fingers of his other hand pinched at the ring roughly, trying to steady it.

“It’s not coming off,” Tate said.

As Reza said, “Oh no, what if we lost the right key and Jonny has to wear it forever?” the key clicked over and the lock opened.

Tate said, “I got it.”

Reza said, “That’s a relief, huh, Jonny?”

Jonny sighed relief—but there was a new problem: with the lock undone his penis straightened out from his body, the cage gripping him. The ability to have an erection fueled its own fire and even though five well-endowed naked men were standing and watching him, his cock went to full hardness, swelling out the gaps between the cage’s rings.

Tate sighed, shook his head, flexed his jaw. Then, knowing there was no other way, he took hold of Jonny’s cock cage, fingers gripping the wire, and began to tug. His penis looked so small in Tate’s large muscular hand. It was embarrassing, but he’d grow aroused from the idea and from the situation, and he’d pumped out pre-come. Tate was able to sway his cock from side to side and Jonny’s own lubrication got the cage sliding right up and off his shaft. Tate tossed the cage to the floor where it clanged then bounced and skidded on the hard tile. He wiped his hands on the towel and grimaced, eyes down and looking at Jonny’s rock hard cock.

He was free and hard, and as awful as the situation was the feeling was glorious. He closed his eyes to shut them all out and enjoyed the pleasure of an erection.

“Jesus, Jonny,” Reza said, “you have no shame.”

“You don’t know what it’s like having your dick locked up.”

The black guy had been watching, leaning against the counter wearing a towel. He said, “Ay man, this is where I’m out,” and he put up two pale

palms in surrender. “I ain’t gonna watch dude sit here and jack off or some shit.”

Reza laughed and said, “Tate just needs to cover up his snake,” leaned over and tugged Tate’s towel closed. “Jonny keeps checking it out. Jonny’s a cock-watcher. Knows Charlie’s going to love it. Pictures that thing you got going in and out of her and all the sounds that redheaded tiger’s gonna make when you fuck her.”

“I’m not thinking of that,” Jonny said.

Reza laughed. “What then? Five naked duded got you hard?”

The hype men snickered.

The black guy said, “Get this dude some ice. You gotta ice that thing down.”

Reza nodded toward the hype men and they moved away, off to the side and Jonny could hear the sound of a fridge opening and closing.

Tate lay his forearms over his thighs and waited, his brow low, his jaw tense. One of the hype men returned and held out a hand. Tate opened his, and the guy dropped a single ice cube in it. There was great laughter. The other hype man said, “That’s for his little dick,” and it brought another brief wave of laughter, Reza even joining in.

TATE HELD a hand towel filled with ice over Jonny’s crotch. The wet terry fabric froze his cock and balls numb, and he couldn’t tell if he was hard or not anymore.

The hype men put on cotton sweats and the black guy went to his locker and dressed in casual clothes and what had to be size 14 tan leather shoes. He winked and pointed a finger gun at Jonny as he left.

Reza got dressed in a charcoal suit, no underwear, polished dress shoes, clasped his Rolex on his wrist, surmised Jonny.

He said, “You made the right choice, Jonny.”

“I would do anything for a weekend with Charlie.”

“I already know that, Jonny. And this new cage is for your sake. For you and Charlie. There’s a reason you wear it so don’t try to get around the purpose of the cage.”

Jonny watched him as he knotted his tie, standing just over Tate’s shoulder. He said, “Do you have cameras in our apartment?”

Reza’s expression pinched. “Don’t be ridiculous, Jonny.”

They eyed each other but Reza gave nothing away. Soon he put his hand on Tate’s shoulder. “You good?”

“I got it,” Tate said.

“Let’s take a look.”

Tate eased the ice-filled towel away, and they looked at Jonny’s penis. The hype men came close and leaned to see as well.

He’d lost his erection, and his frigid little penis had shriveled.

Reza said to Tate, “All right, get that cage on him. I gotta get to this meeting. I’ll call you later.”

“Yup,” Tate answered without looking.

Reza came around the bench looking at Jonny. “Two weeks from now this is all going to be worth it.” He patted Jonny’s shoulder.

One of the hype men said, “I’d wear one of them cages if you said I could fuck Charlie all weekend.” The other hype man laughed and nodded, nudged his friend with an elbow.

Reza looked to scold them, paused then a slow smile spread his beard.

“I gotta go,” he said and slapped Jonny’s back again. Jonny listened to him walk the hall then leave.

Tate took the new silicon chastity cage and examined how it worked. Jonny said, “The black ring goes around—”

“I’ll figure it out, it’s not a carburetor.”

“Whatever.”

Tate took the small silicon sleeve with its molded cock head shape and eased it over Jonny's cold-shrunk penis. The rubber surface snagged on his skin and instead of his penis sliding into the sleeve, Tate's pushing squashed Jonny's cock against his scrotum. The sleeve was too small. Tate withdrew the sleeve and groaned, rubbed an eye socket with the back of his wrist. He looked at Jonny's penis, shook his head and clamped his lips between his teeth. After a preparatory inhale, he spat in the silicon cage and then wiped the insides with a finger, coating it with his spit.

The two hype men had their arms folded and watched from a few feet away. One of them said, "This guy's dick is like a thumb. You see that?" Opposite of hype men for Jonny, these guys served for his humiliation in Reza's stead.

The other one said, "Tate, seriously, I think your thumb is bigger than his dick. Hold them together."

Tate stopped what he was doing and his head slowly came up to regard them. Jonny could hear one of their mouths clapping closed with a hollow lip-sound.

Tate watched them for a moment and Jonny resisted looking over his shoulder to see their reaction.

Tate said, "Don't you two have better things to do?"

One of them said, "Yeah, sure, Tate. We were just messing around."

"I know," Tate said, "now get the fuck out of here."

Tate watched them leave with a lowered brow and his mouth held in a firm line. When the door closed, he breathed a few calming breaths, his large muscular shoulders rising and falling. Jonny watched the guy's body. Up close like this he could feel the man's presence. His chest was huge, his stomach trim and hard. If Tate won his fight, this weekend Charlie would get in bed with this man and her hands would roam his perfect, masculine form. Charlie liked him; she had a crush on him. She'd admitted to her husband that the man's penis turned her on. And the crazy thing?—despite

the ice held against his dick for almost ten minutes, he was growing again, getting aroused at the thought even though it was dangerous. Reza was an animal, mean and crude despite capricious gentleness; Charlie couldn't fall for him. Reza was brutish; his penis large and grotesque, his manner in bed dominant and atavistic. Charlie accepted it, and though he made her come, it was a reluctant orgasm. Reza forced her orgasms. What if Tate conjured them?

"For fuck's sake, are you getting hard again?"

"Well hurry up and put it on. You're taking for fucking ever."

Tate grunted an exhale, took the small silicon tube and slipped it over the head of Jonny's penis. Turning it clockwise and counter, he screwed it down Jonny's shaft, the inside of it slippery now with Tate's spit. Jonny pinched the base of his cock to help and Tate didn't stop him.

Jonny said, "Then you just put the black part right around the—"

"I know," Tate interrupted him.

Jonny watched the fighter's large masculine hands work the rubberized ring underneath his balls and around his cock. Tate's knuckles were large and the first two were callused and swollen.

"It's so small," Jonny said, but didn't know why. Maybe he sought sympathy but should know by now Tate was not the type.

Tate closed it, tugged the lock, jiggling Jonny's new, smaller cage. It was tight and constrictive and he had a sudden shiver of claustrophobia; feeling as trapped as his penis was. The inside was smooth at least, and with Tate's spit his cock was swelling against the cage's interior but it was only uncomfortable, not painful.

Jonny cleared his throat as Tate dried his hands on the towel. Jonny could see his large penis laying on the bench alongside the inside of his thigh. He said, "What's Reza got on you?"

"Don't talk to me." Tate wouldn't even meet his gaze, kept drying his hands.

Jonny scoffed. “Why do you want to spend the weekend with my wife? Can’t you get your own girlfriend?”

Tate groaned, covered his face with his hands and rubbed his eyes. He laughed into the cups of his palms. When he set his hands down on his thighs he was looking directly at Jonny. He said, “How long does it take to make a fucking game?”

Speaking with measured defiance, he replied, “I’m working as fast as I can.”

Tate said, “It’s your wife working. That perfect woman deserves a man, you fucking baby.”

WHEN CHARLIE GOT home from work Jonny was on the couch. She brought home Angelo's, and he wondered how she got it home.

She was in a good mood, coming in the apartment walking on her toes lightly and disappearing into the kitchen to set the pizza box on the counter, and in a bright singsong calling out, "Hi, Jonny."

Jonny stood up, adjusted his pant leg, but that didn't help the unease between his legs. He had to push the nose of the cage down to find comfort. After a few steps, the discomfort waned. He joined her in the kitchen.

"You're in a good mood."

She spun, a long skirt twirling around her knees. She shot him a wide smile, sunlight sparkled in her eyes.

She said, "I am," and shot her hip out.

His own smile faltered. He imagined Reza had told her that if Tate won his fight, she would spend the weekend with the big man. His brow lowered as he considered his wife was happy because she looked forward to it.

He said "Is there good news?"

She said, "Good news? I just brought home Angelo's. We've got a couple of hours we can watch some Twilight Zone, eat about maybe five or six slices of pizza. The sun is shining, it was beautiful out—"

He said, "How did you get home? Did Tate drive you?"

“Nope. It was so nice out I took the bus. Why?”

“You carried the pizza all the way home?”

“It’s not that far.”

“Are you serious?”

She said, “Geez, Jonny. What’s your problem? You called me today, and you got me all happy. Now I get home and you’re mad at me for having a smile on my face.” She came to him, still smiling but he could see that she was hurt by his meanness.

He put his arms around her, said, “Sorry. You’re right. The sun was shining today...”

“Right?” she said into his chest as she hugged him. “It’s not too hot out anymore, the leaves are still on trees, why wouldn’t I walk home?”

“I’m just glad you’re here,” he said and rested his chin on the top of her head.

“Oh Jonny, something happened today?” She darted her head back but still held his arms. She looked in his eyes.

He shrugged.

“Did you not have a good day?”

“It was fine...” He couldn’t stop a low groan in his chest.

“Oh no... Did something happen with your game? Did something go wrong?” Her eyes look frightened.

He pulled her back to hold her. “No way. Not at all, Charlie. Don’t worry, baby. I’m on top of that. That’s my domain.” When she’d looked frightened, she showed doubt in him and he’d never seen that in her before. Her fear frightened him more than she could understand and he didn’t want her to know that.

“I know, Jonny. I know, I trust you. Then what’s wrong?” Her arms went around his waist and she laid her ear over his chest again.

In a quiet voice near her ear, he said, “Remember when you said you thought there were cameras?”

“I *told* you. Why?”

“Maybe you’re right.”

“I think I am. It’s not hard to believe.”

“Would you come out into the hall with me?”

She didn’t answer, but stepped back from him and looked in his eyes, her hand scratching at his forearms and holding his hands. She nodded.

Jonny took her by the hand, went out their apartment door and into the hall. He turned right and opened the door into the stairwell. Their feet were squeaky on its painted concrete surface and the heavy metal door boomed behind them. But now he felt alone. Really alone.

She said, “What is it? What’s going on?”

Jonny told her to hold on, undid his belt, opened his pants and pushed them down. He thrusts his hips out and his smaller cage jiggled between his legs.

Charlie’s eyes went wide and her mouth fell open. Her hand came up, and she touched her lower lip with the tips of her fingers. She said, “Your penis is in that?”

“It wasn’t easy, but they got it in there,” he told her.

“Oh my God, Jonny. It’s so small.” The hand left her face and came down to hold the outside of his cage. The old one had wire rungs that let his skin be touched. But this silicone was impermeable. He could tell that Charlie was touching it, but he couldn’t feel the delicate touch of her fingers, couldn’t feel the warmth of her skin. It was dull and muted. He was surprisingly un-aroused by her touching of the cage.

She said, “We can’t mess around if you’re wearing this.” She jiggled it, and he looked to see her thumb and finger holding the cock head shape and moving the cage up and down.

“I know. Reza made me put it on. He said that if I try to get around the purpose of the cage I’m letting you down.”

“You’re not, Jonny...”

“Maybe I am.”

“We had fun...” She cupped his cheek with a hand and rubbed his nostril with her thumb.

“Maybe that was the point. I don’t know if he’s right or not. But he wanted me to meet him...”

“That was your meeting today?”

He nodded. “Yeah. He had a proposition to do with the business. And then when we were done he made me put this on.”

“Jonny. I’m not kidding, you *have* to finish your game.”

“It’s all coming together, Charlie. It’s just odds and ends now. I swear it won’t be long.”

“Can you stand it?”

He nodded. He wanted to tell her about the proposition. His heart raced with the excitement. He couldn’t wait to tell her about the weekend they would spend together. But he’d offered her up like she was common goods. And that part he didn’t know how to explain yet. The first part of the revelation would be great. Two weeks from now, no matter what, the two of them would have a weekend alone together. It would be like a staycation. Just the two of them. They’d lock the door and only open it up to receive the food they ordered. Then the rest of the time they would be naked... But then he’d have to tell her what it was going to cost her. Not him. *Her*.

And there was a greater fear: she might be looking forward to it more than the weekend with him...

THEY SAT TOGETHER on the couch and watched TV while they ate pizza. They were quiet and dinner was tasteless; not just because it was Angelo’s. Jonny had a lot on his mind.

What would Charlie think of this proposition? When he told her about it would he catch a glimmer in her eye? He’d offered up his wife services and

felt guilty, but deep down he was sure that she would have offered. And now it was beginning to work on him. Twisting and turning deep down below his belly.

When an episode ended, he turned, ready to tell her. She faced him at the same time and her mouth opened as if she were going to speak. She saw he was as well and closed her mouth.

He said, "No, you first."

She said, "You think that if we... If we were to..." She got a little closer now, and whispered to him, "If I were to put your balls in my mouth do you think that would be enough?..."

"Shit, Charlie," he said and grimaced. Just the idea of her doing that thing for him again got him surging. This cage was tighter. And while it didn't have rings that pinched, it had silicon rubber that tightened around his testicles. When he began to get hard they began to pull, the sleeve began to squeeze...

"Sorry," she said. "I don't mean... You know what I mean. Isn't there a way we can still be happy?"

"There is," he said and paused again.

She said, "I know you won't feel my hand on your penis, but doesn't my mouth feel good on your... *balls*?"

He nodded. "It really does, Charlie. We can figure something out..."

She said, "You don't think Reza was right...? Am I distracting you? Am I the reason your game isn't done?"

"You're not." He scratched his head and looked at his empty plate on the coffee table. "I just mean that maybe there's some truth in this cage providing some focus. Reza's giving me the money to pay people to do the things I need to do. He uses you like a carrot to get me to work harder. And I hate those things he does with you. That motivates me. The more I see him with you the more I want to be finished." Now he put his hand over,

collected hers and gripped her thumb. “But I love seeing *you*. You know? With him? As terrible as it is, you’re beautiful...”

“Geez, Jonny,” she sighed.

“But if there’s ways around the cage, that’s what I think about doing. That’s what I think about instead of working. I think about ways to beat his system. But if I just stayed—”

“But, Jonny, I love you. We need to be together. And the way we did it last time? With Genesis? I don’t want that...”

Now he smiled. And with perfect timing a cloud passed by the house and let the sun blossom through the window and shine golden light on her face. He said, “Well, I have some great news for you, sunshine...”

She said, “Really? What’s the good news?”

Someone knocked at the door.

“For Christ’s sake,” he muttered.

“Hold on. I’ll get rid of them.”

He sighed, shook his head. There was something arousing about what he wanted to tell her. It was good news, for sure, and he couldn’t wait for two weeks when they could be together fully. But he also wanted to see the look in her eyes when he told her about what it would cost...

Charlie trotted the three steps up to the kitchen, went to the door and unlocked it. She opened it, stepped back and said, “Oh hi, Tate.”

JONNY WENT TO THE KITCHEN. Charlie was closing the door and Tate was taking a seat at the kitchen table.

Tate was wearing what he’d dressed in at the club. Jeans and boots, flannel shirt with the sleeves rolled up that showed the big muscles of his forearms. He rested one of them now on the kitchen table.

“Can I get you some pizza?” Charlie asked.

Tate said, "No thanks, Charlie. I got the fight coming up, I gotta watch what I eat these days."

"Oh yeah? When's the fight?"

Tate looked to Jonny. "You didn't tell her yet?"

Jonny rolled his eyes.

Charlie said, "Tell me what?"

Tate rested his elbows on his knees and ran his hands through his hair a few times.

Jonny said, "I was just about to tell you, Charlie."

"The good news?"

Tate brightened. He sat upright and rested his big hands on his knees. With a wary smile, he said, "You think it's good news?"

Finger pointing toward Jonny, she shook her head no. "Jonny told me it was good news."

Tate slumped. "Oh, right."

Jonny said, "I was just about to tell her. Why are you here?"

"I'm here to talk."

"About what?" Charlie asked.

Tate looked to Jonny and said, "Would you just tell her?"

"Like I said, I was just about to. Then you showed up uninvited."

Tate grumbled and put both hands up, looking away from them. He leaned back in his chair, put an elbow on the table and scowled.

Jonny cleared his throat. "Charlie..."

"Is this the good news?"

"Yeah. I went to meet Reza today..."

She looked down between his legs.

"It wasn't even about that," he said and fidgeted with his cage. "He had something else he wanted to talk about."

"Oh no." She began to gnaw on her lower lip with a canine.

Jonny said, “Hold on. It wasn’t terrible. He’s going to be away for two weekends this month...”

“Okay,” she said, still gnawing.

“Yeah, so he’s going to be away. He offered me a chance to be with you.”

“Be with me?”

“He did. Not this weekend, but the next. No matter what happens, Charlie, you and I are going to be left alone all weekend. No interruptions, no cage, sixty hours of just you and me.”

She watched him speculatively, waiting for the bad news to temper it. Her eyes twinkled with hope. A smile slowly crept up, pulling the corners of her mouth into her cheeks and forming dimples. She made a funny croaking sound and then giggled. “Two weekends from now?”

He stepped forward, put out his hands, and she put hers inside his. Their thighs touched, and he looked into her eyes. “Two weekends from now you and I will have the whole weekend to ourselves. No Reza, no nobody. Just the Keens. And we’re mighty *keen*.”

She gave up another bashful giggle. “I’m so keen for you.” He kissed her forehead.

Tate said, “There’s more.”

Charlie stepped back and her tooth worked nervous lines into her lower lip again. Her brow came down.

Jonny said, “There always is.”

“What do you have to do?” she asked him.

Jonny said, “It’s not me...”

Charlie moaned. “Oh no, what do I have to do?”

Tate stood up. Jonny said, “On the first weekend...”

Tate nudged Jonny out of the way. He stood now in front of Charlie.

Charlie said, “Oh no. What do I have to do?” She looked up pleadingly at Tate, almost unaware that he had taken the place of her husband. She

looked at him with the same sort of trust and affection. Jonny's stomach tightened, and he sat down heavily in the seat Tate had occupied.

Tate said, "The only way you get to have that weekend was for Jonny to agree to something else."

"Something I have to do?"

Tate said, "That's why I'm here. Jonny had to agree to it. But I'm not doing it unless you agree to it as well."

"Agree to what?"

"In order for this to work... in order for you to get the weekend with Jonny, you spend a weekend with me." Tate looked at her with hopeful eyes under a low and mean looking brow. His mouth hung open tentatively. Charlie's eyes darted over his. Her hands came together and clasped over her chest. She made that croaking sound again.

"Weekend with you? What does that mean?"

"I get the same thing Jonny gets. Sixty hours. Sixty hours where I'm here instead of Reza."

"Oh." Her eyes flitted towards Jonny.

"I asked for it, Charlie. I wanted it. It's for my fight."

"What fight?"

"Remember I told you I had to fight this season. Remember I told you in the car?"

She nodded.

"It's this weekend, Charlie."

"Okay. I knew it was coming up. I did."

"It's this weekend," he said again. "Reza wanted me to have something. Anything I could ask for within reason. He would give me a gift if I win. I asked him for you. I just want to spend one weekend with you."

"Why?"

"Why? Why wouldn't I?"

Her eyes made a funny roll, and she smirked a half-smile. She said, “I have to spend the weekend with you?”

“That’s why I’m here. I asked for it because I wanted it. But I don’t want it if you don’t. The only way I’ll do it is if you tell me it’s okay. If you tell me it’s okay, we’ll spend the weekend together.”

“And if I don’t agree?”

“I’m sorry. Reza won’t let you spend the weekend with Jonny.”

“I want to spend the weekend with Jonny.”

“I don’t want to put you in this position. He asked me what I wanted and I want you. But if you don’t want to, I’ll give it up. But listen... I’ll be good to you. I want to be with you. I want the whole experience. You’re amazing. I think about you all the time...”

Jonny said, “Okay, that’s enough.

Tate ignored him. “If you don’t want to, I’ll understand.”

She began to speak, but he stopped her, put a finger on her lip. Charlie waited.

He said, “Don’t answer me now. I want you to think about it. I want this to be for real. You don’t decide tonight. You decide tomorrow. I’m going to go now. I promise I’ll be good to you. And as much as I hate the situation, it means you get a weekend with your husband. Don’t do it for him. Do it for me.”

Jonny said, “Thanks, Tate. You can get going now.”

Charlie said, “Wait...” and stood with her two men watching her. Her mouth worked in small movements and her eyes stared wildly, darting from side to side but not looking at them. For a second Jonny feared she was going into some sort of fit and she might collapse on the floor. She was processing too much information.

Tate held her arm to steady her. “Don’t decide now. Don’t say a thing. Jonny’s right. I’m going to go. You call me tomorrow and I hope to God you’ll say you’ll be with me.”

He took her by both arms, pulled her close. She was frail and thin against his hard muscle. His hands dwarfed her upper arms, and he was much taller than her. He kissed the top of her head, let her go and walked to the apartment door.

“Call me tomorrow.”

He opened the door and left.

JONNY PARSED through the data Shulamit sent him.

“See what I’m saying?” she said from her apartment in Italy or wherever she actually was.

“Uh-huh,” he said, still scrolling. “How big a problem do you think it is?”

“You tell me.”

He shrugged. “Just fix it. I want it right.”

“Take me a day...”

“I want it fixed.”

“It’ll still work without the fix.”

“I want it right.”

“I do, too,” she said. “It’s good, this game.”

“I know it is.”

Shulamit smiled. “Okay, Mister Jonny, consider it fixed. I start now. Time me, see if I can get it done in twenty-four hours.”

Jonny picked up the leather beanbag stress ball sitting on the desk. “You’re going to work straight?”

“Try to stop me.”

Now he smiled, squeezing the stress ball. “God, I love you, Shulamit,” he laughed, but kind of meant it.

Shulamit came nearer the screen as she reached to turn off the webcam. “Don’t let that wife hear you, she seemed feisty.”

The screen went black.

He said, “She’s a sweetheart, Shulamit.”

Now he passed the stress ball from hand to hand and watched the bathroom door. That sweetheart of his had closed herself in there a long time now. He checked his watch. Forty minutes.

Once Tate had left, Jonny stayed silent and cleaned. He put the uneaten pizza away in the fridge, closed in Tupperware. He cleaned the plates, took the empty pizza box down the hall and dumped it in the recycling chute. Charlie tidied as well, sweeping the floor with a broom. Her face was pinched in concentration and he wondered what her decision would be. Not true; he wondered when she would tell him she would spend the weekend with Tate.

Stress ball set down on the desk, he eased himself out of his work chair and hooped his headphones over his head, lay them on the desk. He crept to the bathroom door and listened. What he worried he’d hear was the sound of her crying. The thought of hearing her soft sobs beyond the door wrenched on his heart.

There *were* soft Charlie sounds from inside the bathroom. The way his brain had been working he thought at first they were the sounds of crying. But while he listened it dawned on him: it wasn’t crying, it was panting. Breathy gasps, coming in regular syncopation, a soft moaning sound trickling underneath. Not the moans of sadness, but moans of pleasure. Ear pressed to the door, he also attuned to a quieter sound but one that came in the same syncopation, just a little off the melody. A wet clicking. Soft feminine suction.

His hand went between his legs and squeezed on his cage. Stomach muscles tightened till they cramped. Charlie was masturbating.

He listened harder. Click-pant-gasp... click-pant-gasp...

“Charlie?”

The sounds stopped.

He waited, but she said nothing.

“Hey, Charlie?”

A long silence, then: “What?”

“Are you okay?”

Silence again.

“Charlie?”

“I’m okay.”

Another long silence, and even he didn’t know what to say now. “You want a snack?”

“No.”

He rested his hand on the door knob and it made a metallic clack.

“Don’t come in here,” Charlie said, her voice rushed.

“I’m not,” he said. “I’ll leave you alone.”

No answer.

He stepped away from the door but hesitated. He heard her putting things away, heard zippers on cosmetic bags, shampoo bottles being set back on the shower shelf.

Back at his work desk, he got his fingers typing but couldn’t stop thinking of his wife masturbating in the bathroom by herself, in secret. He adjusted his cage.

The door to the bathroom opened, and Charlie came out, walking past him without looking. She left a trail of wet bathroom heat and the smell of soap and shampoo.

Over his shoulder he said, “Did you have a nice bath?”

“Yes. Did you need in there or something?”

“Yeah,” he said, thinking how irritated her voice sounded. Charlie liked her alone time in the bathroom. Even though he didn’t need to pee, he left his chair and closed himself in the bathroom.

The mirror was hazed with humid fog, one side touched with the clear marks of her fingerprints where she'd opened the cabinet. He did now too, looking through their things on white metal shelves. Nothing out of the ordinary. He squatted down and opened the cupboard doors. There were a lot more nice things these days since Reza was staying here. Bottles of mouth wash, shampoos and conditioners; ultrasonic toothbrushes, whiteners, hair gels, mousse, different kinds of deodorants—men's and ladies... Their storage was now a bric-à-brac of expensive toiletries. While Charlie didn't wear make-up, he knew she'd been buying it anyway. Maybe some feminine curiosity. She'd bought shoes she'd not worn yet, too.

Some of the things she had were tucked in toiletry bags. He quietly unzipped a few and poked his fingers inside, eventually turning up a small baggie the size of a match book with white powder in it and another one with half a joint. It was in the expensive alligator bag tucked away and hidden at the very back he found Charlie's dildo.

It was a big, lifelike one with molded veins and a plump, flared cock head.

"Ah fuck, Charlie," he sighed as he examined it. His temples began a steady throb, and his cock began to swell in his tiny rubber cage. There was no room to grow, and it felt like his cock was pushing back inside his body. Thoughts came again of his penis shrinking because he wore the cage.

The dildo wasn't as large as Reza's or Tate's members, but it was a lot bigger than her husband's. He flexed it, wagged it, tried picturing Charlie bent over the sink and running this thing in and out of herself, trying to enjoy it but keeping her gasps of pleasure quiet so her husband wouldn't hear. His cock pushed into his body so uncomfortably he squeezed his thighs together as he hustled the big dildo back into the leather bag.

Hand squeezing his rubber-clad genitals, he flushed the toilet and waited a few heartbeats before leaving the bathroom.

Charlie sat on the bed in her pajamas now, rubbing lotion on her arms. She looked over her shoulder at him but didn't smile. Back at rubbing lotion she said, "What?"

Jonny sighed, got on the bed and walked across to kneel behind her.

After a moment where he lurked behind her without saying anything, she paused, rested her hands on her knees. "What is it?"

He licked his lips. "Charlie, were you masturbating in there?"

She made a quick scoffing sound, reached over and clapped the lid closed on her lotion, tossed it in the nightstand drawer and shoved it closed with a bang.

He said, "It's okay if you were..."

"I wasn't, Jonny," she hissed with determined punctuation through clenched teeth.

"If you ever need me to do something for you..."

She scoffed again, plopped herself into her spot on the bed, sitting up still, but shoving her long pale legs under the covers. Her cheeks had blushed. "I wasn't doing *anything*," she said.

"Charlie... I know you were."

She scowled at him, thin lines creasing her smooth brow above the bridge of her nose. Her mouth had gone thin and firm. "Mind your business, Jonny."

Now *he* made a scoffing sound. He said, "Are you masturbating thinking about Tate?"

"No! Why would you even say that?" Her hands formed fists around bunched up bedsheets.

"I saw your face when he took that big dick out and you asked him if you could suck it."

"This again? For crying out loud, Jonny, we had this argument..."

"Remember you told me how you liked it when you jerked him off? Now he's going to spend the weekend with you and you're trying to pretend

you have to think *so-oo* carefully about it, but you go in the can and start jabbing yourself with some big dildo?...”

Scowling meaner, she said, “Maybe I wouldn’t have to if you didn’t let Reza put that tiny cage on your dick, maybe if you were a man...”

He flinched. “I *am* a man.”

Charlie fixed him with that furious scowl, brow low, mouth turned down now in the corners.

Everything in him slumped. His shoulders fell, and a weakness worked up his back. In a soft request, he said, “Don’t spend the weekend with Tate.”

“Then I don’t spend the next one with you.”

“That’s fine.”

“Well thanks a lot, Jonny. You’re so jealous you’d keep me away from my husband—you!—just to prove your manhood... When did you get so spiteful?”

“It’s not spite.”

She laughed. “It’s not?”

“No. I don’t like you with Tate.”

Smiling now, she said, “Oh? Do you like me with Reza then?”

“That’s not it.”

“Sure it is. You’re afraid I’m going to like it with Tate. *Now* you’ll put a stop to it. You think I *don’t* like it with Reza and you don’t say a peep.” She watched him, smiling mean, waiting for him to catch up with her logic. “You let Reza fuck me and you watch. The whole time thinking poor Charlie under that big hairy man, poor Charlie having to let that horse cock go inside her, I hope she’s okay... A guy might come and spend a weekend and he says he’ll be nice, says he’ll be gentle...? Now you put your foot down? This is where you say enough is enough? And to prove your point you’re going to deny me a weekend with the man I love?—you, Jonny!—maybe it’s you should spend some time in that bathroom. There’s a big old

mirror in there and you should probably take a long, hard look at yourself. Oh sorry, did I say long and hard? Is your little dick straining against its cage?”

He shook his head, lips trembling.

She said, “Funny how I’m the one who worries about your comfort. I worry about you all day long. You’re selfish, Jonny, and I never thought you were before.”

Her hands raked through her long ginger mane stirring up the oily coconut smell of the expensive shampoo their landlord bought for her. She made a growling sound, kicked her legs out of bed, and went around to the closet.

She was going to leave again.

He said, “Wait, Charlie, please, don’t go...”

“I have to get out of here, Jonny, I *have* to...”

In a timid voice, he said, “I just wanted to say I would help you masturbate...”

“No, Jonny, stop,” she said from inside the sweater she pulled on. Tugging her long hair out the neck hole, she said, “That’s not all you wanted to say. You said what you wanted to say. I mean it: sit and think.”

She pulled on jeans and grabbed her purse.

“I can think while you’re here.”

She shook her head in admonishment. “I’m not going to leave here and see Reza, I’m not going to see Tate, if that’s what you’re worried about. I want to be alone. So sit here and think about how mean you are to me. Don’t spend it worrying and grabbing at that cage trying to wonder if I’m with another man. I’m not. I’m going to go and sit alone somewhere. I *need* to be alone.”

She walked around the bed and he turned to watch her go. She paused at the bottom of the steps. Without looking back she spoke down toward the

floor. “You want to worry I’m with someone, worry I’m with Genesis. Tonight’s the night I think I’ve officially had enough of men forever.”

Up the stairs she trotted; he heard the jingle of keys plucked from the hook, then the sound of the door closing behind her.

IT WAS A GRAY, lifeless dawn when she returned and he’d hardly slept. Once she’d gone, he’d done as she instructed: sat on the bed and thought about her. Thought about the things he’d done and saw some truths about himself he didn’t want to see. At some point he’d slipped under the covers and put his head on the pillow. Sure, he was supposed to be working, but it was all for Charlie; what was the point if he didn’t have her?—or worse, had been hurting her...

She came down from the kitchen in light steps, careful to be quiet because she cared about him. They met each other’s gaze, and he saw the wet gleam of her eyes in the low light.

At the side of the bed, standing right next to him, she gave him a weak smile, and he returned it, his heart in his throat.

When she sat next to him, she lay her hand on the covers over his heart. She gave him a few scratches; her smile getting more confident. She cupped his cheek. His smile grew, too. Now she came to him and kissed his lips. It was soft and slow and gentle. Her lips were cool, and damp, and so soft. She tasted like whisky. Marijuana was in her hair, pungent smell chasing away the light tropical. It was possible she’d gone to see Genesis. He didn’t care as long as she was here.

Their kiss broke with a small smack. She still smiled. Looking in his eyes now, she said, “You *are* a man, Jonny. You’re my man, and I love you.”

“I love you, too,” he said with no hesitation, “and I’m sorry.”

She turned away, nodding, her hand going into her pocket and withdrawing her phone. Three swipes and it was ringing. She put it to her ear.

“Hi, good morning... It is... I know... thank you... I did... I did, all night... I’ll spend the weekend with you if you win your fight... I’m sure... I *am* sure, Tate. I *want* to do it.”

PART 2

THE DRESS CHARLIE wore made him furious, but he'd kept his mouth shut so far. A Bardot dress, she called it, skin-tight in Royal blue; floral lace over a liner. The liner had cut-outs though—a diamond over her tummy, baring it behind the lace, and a diamond on the small of her back. It was off the shoulder, showing her creamy freckled skin, but had long sleeves that came to below her wrist. She looked stunning in it, especially standing. The skirt was short, above mid-thigh, her long, elegant legs bare, feet pointed in silver-white lacy heels with a thin ankle strap and small gold bells hanging from the buckles.

Now she had her legs crossed sitting in the back of the limousine Reza sent, and the bells jingled with the swaying of the ride. Jonny sat beside her, dressed nowhere near as elegantly, just in jeans and a sweatshirt. The jeans were black, the sweatshirt black, and he hoped he might pass as some rich and successful game designer (which he intended to be in the near future).

In the future when he was rich and successful, he would also be without a cage on his penis. He fidgeted in his seat, slumped low with his hands thrust in the pouch of the sweatshirt. Charlie watched out the window, and he was bothered by the pleasant smile on her face. She held a crystal tumbler in one hand, amber fluid dancing in its cup as the limo took a right turn on Houston.

He asked her, “Are you wearing makeup?”

“No.” She tilted her head, then amended it: “Just a little eyeshadow.”

“Lip gloss?”

“Yes. And some lip gloss.”

“So you *are* wearing make-up...”

“If you call that make-up...”

“I call that make-up. What do you call make-up?”

“I don’t know, Jonny. Foundation. Blush. Drawing on your eyebrows...”

“You don’t do that.”

“No, I don’t.”

He reached over and took her hand. “You don’t have to.”

“Aw, that’s sweet. I don’t have to, but maybe I should...”

“You couldn’t be more beautiful.”

He put his hand up her bare back, felt the smoothness of her skin, felt how *vibrant* she felt. She’d been cleaned and massaged with scented oil and her silky hair brushed over the back of his hand as he swept it up to hold the back of her neck. He could feel the chain of a necklace against his palm. A necklace Reza had probably bought for her.

He said, “There’s a chance Tate won’t win.”

“I know.”

“Are you going to be upset?”

“Do you want to start this now?”

“I’m not trying to start anything. I’m serious. Are you looking forward to spending the weekend with Tate?”

“He’s going to win.”

“But if he doesn’t?”

“Will you and I still get our weekend together?”

He watched her face, she was studying him. Her eyes were narrowed, and he noticed she’d also used black on her lashes. Charlie was fucking

unbelievably beautiful. A dimple had formed in her cheek as she smirked, and he loved that she didn't wear foundation because there was nothing more Charlie than the spread of those beautiful freckles. He said, "That's the deal. We still get our weekend together."

"Then why on earth would I be disappointed?"

He let it drop. This was as good as her saying *Yes, I would be disappointed, I was looking forward to getting into our bed and rolling around with that muscular hunk who's been turning me on, I've been dying to feel what that perfect penis of his would feel like sliding up inside my body. Do you think I would come? Because I think I would. I think Tate would make me come really hard. So yeah, I guess I am disappointed....*

"Are you sure you don't want one?" Charlie lifted the crystal decanter with expensive bourbon.

He shook his head no.

"Are you sure? It really is good."

"Can I have a sip of yours?"

"Sure," she said with happy charm. She squeaked the lid off the decanter and poured an inch worth of whiskey into the bottom of the heavy crystal glass.

He said, "It's so weird to see you drink."

"I know," she said, "my mother would kill me. Absolutely kill me."

"You're grown-up now."

"Aren't I?" she said and seemed pleased with the prospect that maybe she was. She was a married woman now. She'd come to the city wide-eyed and in love with books. She married the first guy that asked for her hand, and while she loved him she was being exposed to the depths and darkness of the city. She wasn't wilting. She hated that she liked it but there was stuff about the city that turned her on... Women like Genesis who lived in the shadows. Tough men like Tate. Streetwise cons like Demetrius. Dark, soulless men like Reza. All of them villains in any movie she'd ever seen

but here they were embracing her. And God, could they do things to her body. Things her dip-shit husband could never do. And yet she lived in this perfect purgatory. A happy, married woman who had her dream job working at a library, and by night she was the sexual servant of a dark bearded master with a cock that belonged on a horse. Her master made her come. He made her do dirty things. Things her mother had told her she should never do. Things her mother had wanted to prevent her from going to the city for. God, Charlie's mother didn't even want her to be with Jonny. Jonny was the sweetest thing in her life. If her mother and father could see her now, they would be devastated.

She scooted closer on the bench seat of the limousine to sit next to him. He put an arm around her back and cupped her opposite side. She brought the whiskey to his mouth and nose and he sniffed.

"It smells awful."

"At first," she said.

She tilted the glass up to his lips watching him and smiling. He didn't want whiskey, but he wasn't going to say no. He loved the look on her face right now; he wanted it more than anything. The whiskey was terrible. Cool and clean on the tongue until it got underneath and then it burned. When he swallowed, he swore it was paint thinner.

His face contorted, and she giggled. "That's what I must've looked like the first time, too."

He knew she meant whiskey, but all he could think of was her first time with Reza. The first time she'd seen the thing between his legs that was probably what her face had done. The thought made him tug at his pants between his legs.

She noticed, said, "How is it doing down there?"

"It's fine," he said.

Charlie set her glass down with a thunk as the limousine stopped at a red light.

She pressed her lips against his neck, her lips soft and damp with alcohol. She suckled on him, and he would do anything to get a hickey from her right now. Her hand crept his knee and slid up the inside of his thigh and he almost shook himself right out of his seat.

“Holy, oh, easy...”

“Is it hurting your cage?”

“It’s okay,” he sighed. He had to close his eyes and squint them. Charlie’s hand settled between his legs, closed her grip around the small silicone bulge. This cage was more restrictive than the last because it was smaller. And while it provided comfort in different ways because it wasn’t steel, it also provided *discomfort* in new and startling ways. Arousal was almost impossible. Whatever way this one held him, when he got hard it didn’t push the whole apparatus away from his body; this thing had a grip on him, the silicon rubber had *bite*. Instead, when he got hard now, his penis pushed *into* his body. It was *so* uncomfortable his erections dwindled. He could get aroused, could feel the surge and the swell, but it wouldn’t last. The discomfort extinguished his arousal.

Charlie squeezed and played with it, using her thumb and forefinger. He wondered how many drinks she’d had.

He said, “You haven’t been playing with it.”

“I thought you didn’t want me to.”

“It helps me to be focused.”

“I want you to be. But I want to be your wife, and I want to do *wife* things with you...”

“You’re the best thing in my life,” he said with complete honesty. His hand swept down to hold her narrow waist, and he kissed the top of her head.

The limousine turned left when the light flashed green, and here they were pulling past the front of the City Center arena. There were hundreds of people gathered around the doors underneath the awning light. Written in

black sliding letters in the grooves of the marquee awning were the names of tonight's fighters. There was one that stood out.

TATE ARMSTRONG

Yes, the heavyweight. The man Jonny feared could deliver a knockout punch to his marriage.

COMING in the private entrance in the City Center's gated access sub-basement, they ran into the naked black man from the gym's private shower room, the one with the tan size 14s.

"Hey, baby girl," he said in his deep voice and Charlie went right to him.

"Hi, Marco," she said and hugged his waist. Marco stooped to kiss her cheek.

Tonight Marco wore a glen plaid suit, high-waisted, showing off his long legs and his bulge. His tie was shimmering purple, and he had a blue flower on his lapel. Size 14s on his feet again, these ones gleaming patent black. His hands on Charlie's upper arm were enormous, and against her bright white skin they looked jet black.

Marco said, "I know why you here." He smiled wide and knowing then winked.

"You do?" Charlie said with a look of timid worry.

"You here to see our man Tate knock out some Ukrainian homeboy, send his body back to Kiev wrapped in the American flag."

"Oh yeah. I am." She gave a small smirk.

Charlie was worried that her friend Marco might know of the arrangements. Marco didn't let on that he did, but Jonny was fully aware that Marco knew Tate would win more than a fight tonight. Marco knew that if Tate beat the Ukrainian, he would be lucky enough to get his turn between Charlie's legs.

Marco said, “Hey. Where you at? You up with us?”

“In the VIP? We are,” she said and motioned to Jonny. “Have you met my husband?”

Marco smiled, raised his eyebrows and nodded to Jonny. “Oh hey man, I know you—how’s it hanging?”

“I’m fine. How’ve you been?” *Don’t mention my cage.*

“I’m good,” he said with a wide white smile, big black hand rubbing up and down his shiny tie, “I’m good, man. Real good.”

Charlie said, “Jonny doesn’t follow the fights.”

Jonny said, “Not really my thing.”

“More of a thinker,” Marco said with a smirk.

“More of a thinker,” Jonny agreed in deadpan.

“Well hey, here’s the boss man coming now.” Marco pointed with one of those long fingers over Charlie’s shoulder and they both turned to see Reza coming down the hall.

He wore a black suit, and tonight sported a white shirt and tie. Walking with him was Genesis, and they held hands. Genesis wore something black and slinky showing off her curvy muscle and her tattoos. She strutted in tall clicking heels, their sound bright and loud over top of the murmur in the hallways.

Reza’s limousine had parked in the underground next to Jonny and Charlie’s, just beyond the metal doors where Reza had walked through. There was security at the entrance, four black guys in neon yellow sweatshirts, and inside the checkpoint were more men in suits and guys in khaki pants and blazers; paunchy fellows with thinning hair holding glasses of scotch. This was definitely the VIP section, that was for sure.

Everyone had a lanyard with their name on it. Somehow they let Charlie off, clipping it on her purse instead. And Jonny saw they did the same favor for Genesis. All the security guards were big men, and it was possible none

of them wanted any of the hot ladies here to have their outfits marred by dumb identification they probably didn't care about, anyway.

Reza waved to them, but didn't smile. Then he flipped his hand over and wagged his fingers in a come hither gesture meant for Marco.

Marco said, "I'll catch you two later," adjusted his suit jacket and walked around them to join Reza.

"Bye, Marco," Charlie said.

Jonny asked, "How do you know him?"

"Marco? He's around sometimes. You know him?"

"Yeah. He was in the shower the other day at the club when I met with Reza."

"Oh yeah?" she said in the husky conspiratorial way a woman might say to her woman friend indicating: *Lucky you!—you got to see him naked? ... Tell me what he looked like...*

Before he could chastise her, she was already talking about something else, as though wondering what big Marco might look like naked was a small blip in her day—meanwhile it was all Jonny would be thinking about for the next few hours.

While Marco and Reza got close to talk, Genesis spotted Charlie and trotted over to them in a short-stride quick-step that made her calf muscles bulge and flex. Charlie moved toward her, too, and they collided in a hug. Genesis kicked one heel up, and Charlie did the same. The hug went on longer than Jonny expected, and the girls began to rock each other. Genesis's eyes closed, and she shone a beatific smile, her cheek nestled in Charlie's ginger hair.

Jonny joined them, standing behind Charlie with his hands in the sweatshirt's pouch.

Genesis spotted him. "There he is—hey, Jonny."

"How're you?" he said in a somber tone.

“Oh,” she moaned and pouted, sensing his mood and letting Charlie go, “somebody’s grouchy.”

“I’m not,” he said as Genesis put her arms around him for a hug and he gave her one arm in return, patting the small of her back.

“It’s a little small, isn’t it, boo-boo?” she said, eyes lowered between his legs.

“It’s fine.”

Charlie said, “It’s really small,” and crinkled her nose.

Genesis said, “I heard you two were naughty.”

“No-oo,” Charlie said, face pinching in a pout.

“S’okay,” Genesis purred and touched Charlie’s cheek, “my angel has needs...”

Charlie smiled and cocked her hip, nudged Jonny with her shoulder like Genesis was talking crazy.

Genesis sucked her teeth and made her own pouting face at Charlie. “Angel, you got needs, you know who to call.”

“It’s my Jonny has needs.”

“It’s this little bad boy’s needs,” Genesis said, eyeing him slyly, “got you in this mess in the first place.”

“No...” Charlie said.

“Don’t worry, sexy,” Genesis said, and touched Charlie’s cheek again, “ain’t it a beautiful mess?”

REZA WAS DONE with Marco and they broke apart. While Marco was all smiles, Reza was all business, staring Jonny down now, indicating with a head nod he wanted to talk to him next.

Charlie said, “Oh, here comes Reza,” and fixed her posture to stand straighter and adjusted her skirt.

“There’s my beautiful Charlie,” he said and took both her hands and pulled her to him, kissing her mouth. When they stepped apart again, Charlie pressed her lips between her teeth and adjusted her skirt.

He said to her: “You miss me?”

“You haven’t been home in five days,” she said.

“That little pussy must be *dying* for it,” he said.

Genesis laughed and Charlie frowned, touched her stomach below her navel. “Don’t be so vulgar,” she whispered.

“I want that thing hungry. I want it starving.”

Charlie hooked her arm through Jonny’s and he felt protective now. “Watch what you say.”

“Tate’s going to feed it, Charlie,” Reza said, “so don’t you worry.”

Jonny said, “He has to win the fight.”

“Trust me, Jonny, Tate’s going to *feed* it. Going to make all Charlie’s hunger *slide* away.”

Though his words were crude, he had Charlie's attention, and she watched him with disgust.

Marco was on the move, weaving between clutches of out-of-shape white executives and motioning to Genesis, putting one long finger up to tap at the side of his nose as he paused at the men's room door.

"Hey, come on," Genesis said and took Charlie's hand, pulling her to walk.

Charlie saw Marco still motioning to his nose, hand on the bathroom door. The two women went into that quick high-heeled walk, Charlie looking left and right with nervousness.

Jonny said, "Where you going?"

"I'll be right back," she called. Men watched lecherously as two hot women trotted past in heels, dressed like they wanted to get *fucked*.

"So listen, Jonny," Reza said, "I'm glad to hear you're abstaining."

"Who told you that?"

Genesis and Charlie joined Marco at the men's room door and he held it open for them. They went in ahead. Marco looked up and down the busy hall then slipped inside and let the door close behind him.

"Is it true?" Reza asked.

"I've been abstaining," Jonny admitted. Reza had to have cameras in the apartment—unless Charlie had been telling Reza... Or could she have told Genesis, who then told Reza?...

"And isn't it better?"

Two white guys came out of the men's, lanyards swinging, drying their hands on paper towel and looking back over their shoulder. When the door swung closed again, they looked at each other and guffawed.

"I'm getting a lot of work done."

"Jonny—that wife of yours would drive any man to distraction. You're only human."

"I know..."

“But I’ll tell you—she’s having the *opposite* effect on Tate. Distraction?... He’s got *wolf* eyes. He wants your Charlie so bad,” Reza clasped his shoulder, “I’m afraid for this Ukrainian dude. Tate’s going to fuck him up. Like letting a gorilla loose in the ring, you know?”

“Uh-huh,” Jonny said, at once picturing Tate doing push-ups in the dark, growling like an animal while his eyes burned hot as coals, and simultaneously he could see Marco, Genesis, and his wife closed in a toilet stall, the big man with his fly down, Genesis cradling his long, black, flaccid cock while Charlie snorted a line off it.

“You okay, Jonny?”

“Yeah,” he said, pinching his brow and flexing his thighs to ease the growing discomfort between his legs. Sex with other men was one thing, but he had a worry his wife might be turning *bad*.

“You’re one week closer, Jonny. Hang in there. I hope Tate leaves you a little. I heard he fucks like a champ...”

Jonny ignored the taunts and Reza asked him how the game was coming. He kept his responses positive but reined in some of the enthusiasm, kept some of the success hidden. For a guy that was good at designing games, he was terrible at playing them. At least in real life. He gave everything Reza asked and had been so forthcoming that Reza knew exactly what it was that he *could* ask...

THE GIRLS STUMBLED from the men’s room laughing, Marco coming out behind them with a smile.

Reza said, “There’s my girls, get over here, Jonny is boring my balls off.”

Genesis cackled, plucked at her nose and came to hold Reza’s hand while he kissed her neck. Charlie tottered in her heels to come to Jonny’s side and lean against him.

Marco joined the group, extending an arm on either side to encircle both women. He said, “Ay, you show the man yet?”

Charlie gave a shocked expression and looked to Genesis who mouthed: “*Oh no.*”

“No,” Charlie laughed and covered her mouth. Her cheeks had blushed.

Together, Reza and Jonny both said, “Show me what?”

Charlie looked to Jonny sheepishly, hand still over her mouth.

Marco said, “Show them, baby girl,” and curled his big fingers under the dress’s hem at the back of Charlie’s thighs. She yelped and swatted at his hands, stepping away.

“What is it?” Jonny said, a cold fear creeping up his back.

“Nothing,” Charlie said.

“Show me,” Reza laughed.

“No,” Charlie said, holding the hem of her short dress down with both hands.

Genesis smoothed her body up against Charlie and said, “Go on and show them, you sexy bitch.”

Charlie laughed and shielded her eyes with a hand. “Fine,” she sighed.

Now Genesis took the hem of Charlie’s skirt and this time she didn’t protest. She said to Marco, “Cover us.” Then looking to Jonny, she mouthed, “*Sorry,*” and bit her lip.

As Genesis lifted the skirt up, Marco got close to block anyone else seeing, and Charlie turned and stuck her rump up, standing on her tiptoes, the points of her high heels coming up off the polished concrete floor.

Jonny watched as the stretchy blue fabric scrolled up his wife’s pale flesh. Slowly the cheeks of her ass were revealed. And her crack. Charlie wore no underwear and allowed herself to be revealed in public.

Reza watched and chuckled, holding his chin. “What did you do, Charlie?”

“You’ll see-ee,” Genesis sang.

The dress came higher, Charlie's bare ass completely revealed. Jonny could see the dusker flesh of her vulva, and the curl of a folded labium. "Ho fuck," he sighed, and pinched at the front of his jeans. "Oh, Charlie..."

Then he saw what she was reluctant to show.

At the top of her ass cheek, just where it curved to meet the small of her back was a black tattoo—a star, small enough to be covered by a dime, yet its existence was enormous.

"Holy fuck, Charlie," Jonny said, "you got a tattoo?"

She gave him a surly pout, then looked to Reza hopefully.

"Shit," Reza said, "I fucking *love* it."

"Ain't it hot?" Marco asked, still covering but taking a peek for himself.

Jonny was still flabbergasted. "Charlie, you got a tattoo..."

"It's just a tiny one, Jonny..."

"It's tiny, but it'll be there forever," he said as he laid a hand across his forehead.

Reza grabbed her waist as she began to pull the skirt back down, brow lowered with concern because the love of her tattoo wasn't universal. Reza pretend-humped her behind and said, "God, I just want to fuck you so bad right now..."

"Don't" Charlie said and slapped his hands away from her waist.

Jonny said, "Charlie, I can't believe you did that..."

She said, "It's just a little star..."

Reza said, "One star for every guy you fuck's not Jonny..."—he nudged Jonny with an elbow—"...pretty soon your wife's gonna have a fucking constellation on her back."

"Charlie, when did you get this?" he asked, and got close to her, smoothing the skirt down and trying not to think how she wore no underwear beneath the skimpy dress.

"The night, you know... When I stayed out," she said, looking at him with submissive eyes and pursed mouth.

Jonny looked to Genesis. “Did you do it?”

Genesis shrugged. “She come by. I let her in. We hung out.”

“And you talked her into a tattoo?”

Reza laughed. “Oh no, Charlie’s been naughty. She’s in trouble.”

“I asked for the tattoo, Jonny.”

“Was up to me,” Genesis said, “Charlie would have my angel wings.”

She drew sweeps on Charlie’s back and she shivered.

“Jonny,” Charlie said, “it’s just a little star. And I *wanted* it.”

“Why?”

“Well, why not?”

“You don’t ask me?”

“She don’t need to ask you,” Reza said.

“Unh-unh,” Marco agreed. “No, she don’t.”

Jonny changed tack. Hands outstretched in exasperation, he said, “You don’t *tell* me?”

“I knew you’d be like this,” she said.

“Like what?”

Genesis hugged Charlie from behind, watching Jonny over his wife’s shoulder. “A party pooper.”

An overhead crackle from the hidden sound system preceded the announcement that the exhibition matches were beginning.

Reza put a hand on Jonny’s chest, saying, “All right, Jonny, cool it. Don’t wreck the night. Everybody—let’s head up to the box.”

Genesis took Reza’s arm, and they walked off smiling. Marco tugged at his the jacket’s lapels, eyeing Jonny and shaking his head in comical admonishment before walking around Charlie and following behind Reza.

Charlie said, “Please, Jonny, can we go up now?”

“And not talk about this?”

“Why? I already told you—”

“Don’t shut me out, Charlie.”

“I’m just...”

“You don’t tell me before... You don’t tell me after...”

“You can get one too, if you want.”

“I don’t want a tattoo, Charlie. But if I did, I’d *tell* you.”

“Sorry,” she said, meeting his gaze, cute mouth quirked to one side.

“It’s fine,” he sighed, “it’s just a little star.”

“I’m sorry I didn’t tell you. I was just putting it off.”

“Hey—you showed Marco in there?” He pointed toward the men’s room.

“Genesis did that,” Charlie said and put her arm under his, held his hand.

“But he would have seen your bare ass.”

“He wasn’t looking there, he was looking at the tattoo.”

“Sure he was. What were you doing in there, anyway?”

“Nothing,” she grumbled.

“Were you snorting coke?”

She sighed. “We were just talking.”

REZA'S BOX at the City Center was on the first floor after the concourse, above the last row of the stadium seating. It was luxury, of course, with an attendant at the door. A full-service bar ran along the back, and three big screens covered all the walls that weren't the window view. A leather couch faced the glass that looked down over the seating and the ring, and there were flowers on the tables in the corners and behind the couch. Two waitresses in black skirts and white shirts served the guests.

Arm in arm with Charlie, they came in behind Reza and Genesis; Reza already greeting men in business suits, Genesis moving past to get to the bar.

Charlie said, "Hey, there's Demetrius."

For some reason, Jonny was glad to see the guy.

Demetrius was leaning back in the leather couch with his sneakers up on a low, steel table. He sipped from a cocktail glass with juice in it. When he saw Charlie he smiled wide and stood up. He came to join them, saying, "Hey, there's my favorite people. Shit, Charlie, I ain't seen you in a minute. How you been?"

They hugged and kissed cheeks, Demetrius still holding his cocktail.

Charlie said, "I'm good, really good."

“I hear. I saw my man Jonny the other day, said you was doing good. He tell you that?”

“No,” Charlie said.

Demetrius sucked his teeth and shook his head at Jonny. “Some friend you are, my man.”

“Slipped my mind,” Jonny said.

Charlie said, “Hey, you two look the same.” She wagged a finger, pointing at each of them. “Black on black,” she said.

Demetrius said, “Black on black, baby.”

Demetrius wore the same outfit as Jonny, and it bolstered him. Black sweatshirt over black skinny jeans though Demetrius’s sneakers were much nicer than his.

“Yeah, we the same,” Demetrius said. “My shit come from Jugernaut, Jonny’s come from Target.” He laughed at his own joke.

Jonny said, “Who can tell the difference?”

Demetrius said, “I can. Other people, too. Don’t slouch.” He threw a light, fake jab at Jonny and Jonny didn’t flinch.

Demetrius said, “My man. Whyn’t you two come sit with me, I got the best seat in the house...”

Charlie said, “You’re not fighting tonight?”

“I’m up next month,” he said. “Title fight.”

“Is it going to be a big show like this one?” Charlie said, clicking along in her heels.

He put his arm through hers as if to walk her and Jonny fell behind them. Demetrius said, “It’ll be a bigger show than this one. No offense to my man Tate, he holding up, and he packs seats, but I’m in a different organization.”

“Are you going to be professional?”

“I win my fight I will. But Tate’s almost pro, too. He’ll be a star in a year...”

Demetrius let Charlie sit, holding her hand. She eased back in the couch and crossed her long legs. Demetrius took the spot right next to her and Jonny sat down on the other side.

Behind them Reza boasted and laughed, and he shook hands with guys in suits that he must've invited to impress. Drinks were served, there were hors d'oeuvres. Demetrius ordered them a plate of nachos and they shared.

When the exhibition matches were over, the first fight began. Now Demetrius leaned forward, and he kept Charlie informed of what was happening. He told her who each fighter was, what their strengths were what their weaknesses were and what to look for. And as the fight progressed, he would say what the strategy would be, and he was almost always right. Charlie was impressed, watching along and nodding, even leaning forward as well and resting her elbows on her knees.

"Isn't this exciting, Jonny?" she asked him. Her eyes were wide and happy.

He scooted forward on the couch as well and held her hand. "I guess it is," he said.

He didn't know what to expect tonight but so far this wasn't too bad. Comfy seating, free drinks, free food. And while he wasn't into the fights, he did find it entertaining. He didn't know who anybody was, what the point of any of this was, but at least those guys were out there putting on a show. He felt simpatico with that. That's all he was doing. Putting on a show for everybody. Being the entertainer, designing games for them to go through, and ultimately he was the player in another man's arcade.

After the third fight of the evening, Reza loomed behind them, standing at the back of the couch next to the table. He put his hand on Charlie's back, his head over her shoulder. He said, "There's better seats, you know..."

"Better seats?" Charlie asked.

He said, "There's an usher here, gonna take you down. I want you two sitting ringside."

Charlie said, “Ringside? You mean all the way down there... All the way down by the fighters?”

Reza said, “Tate’s fight is coming up. When he walks in that ring, I want him seeing your face. I want him to know what he’s fighting for. I want him to be reminded.”

Charlie’s happiness waned, and she looked frightful for a second.

Reza said, “So go down there and smile for him. He sees that pretty face, and he’s gonna turn into a tiger.”

THE USHER ESCORTED them down the aisle, Jonny and Charlie arms hooked together. From rowdy roughnecks seated at the rear, they emerged in the relative calm of the well-heeled ringside seating.

“Right here, Mr. Keen,” the usher said, stopping at the edge of the ring and gesturing to the front row.

“Thank you,” Charlie said, giving Jonny a shoulder-shrugging squee and dipping at the knees. Before walking ahead of him she whispered in his ear, “Ooh, he called you *Mister Keen*.”

Faces watched them coming, glancing from Charlie to him. Young guy in sweatshirt and jeans walking a supermodel in a tight dress and high heels to their assuredly expensive seating. He smiled and nodded to a few, but generally kept his expression cool. The others must wonder what this guy did for a living—*how does this guy make money? You see that girl he’s with?* For the first time since this began, the sun seemed to peek out from behind its cloud and shine on him. *This! This was what he fucking wanted!* It was just a glimmer, a mirage—this was still all conjured by Reza, but this was what he wanted. For Charlie. And, shit, for him too.

Now he was smiling and there was nothing he could do to stop it. His beautiful and sexy wife walked a step ahead, getting the majority of stares—drooling men, baleful looks from other hot women...

Charlie half-turned and held her clutch up to cover her mouth. “That’s the governor, Jonny—the governor’s here.”

He laughed because the place was so loud no one could hear her—maybe she’d read the governor was a lip reader. “Which one?” he shouted near her ear.

She jittered her head, flicked her eyes toward a handsome guy in his sixties, black hair combed back, silver at his temples. The governor nodded to him, half-smirking, then eyes drifting back to get a load of the beautiful redhead he was with. *Tell me about it.*

Before they sat, Jonny stopped Charlie.

“What is it?”

He kissed her, and she giggled into his mouth. When they sat, he held her hand.

“Isn’t this exciting?” she asked, looking around and up.

“It is, Charlie,” he agreed, squeezing her hand.

The ring was empty. The girl with the booty shorts who strutted between rounds with a numbered placard hung around on the opposite side with two commentators in suits and headphones around their necks. A young Latino guy scurried off the ring backwards under the bottom rope with his bucket and sponge. Done cleaning blood off the mat. Spectators talked and laughed, the guys next to him in the slick business casual yammered about mutual funds. Overhead, two American flags as big as driveways hung from the steel rafters; the center-hung scoreboard box over the ring displayed highlights from the night’s earlier fights.

He took a deep breath and imagined a future where it was him providing a night out like this for Charlie. *It was close, he knew it was...*

The lights dimmed, and the crowd went quiet.

A chunky, threatening guitar lick boomed from the sound system—a repetitive one note rift in A. The fighter’s entrance ramp lit up in purple,

dry-ice smoke rolling over the gangway. A pounding drum started, and the lights pulsed with their whomp. Metallica. The lyrics began...

All right...

A darker purple silhouette emerged in the entrance archway. A big man in a satin robe, hands thick with grappling gloves.

We're scanning the scene...

Tate strode the walkway, shoulders hunched, head lowered, hood of his robe up covering his head. Cannons fired along the sides of the metal planking as he passed, flashes of blinding phosphorous; confetti whirled in the air. Jonny watched Charlie. Face lit up by the light show, she smiled open-mouthed and wondrous, eyes wide and sparkling.

Searching... Seek and destroy!...

Charlie applauded with the crowd and gave a timid whoop. Without realizing it, Jonny's hands had taken up clapping, and he whisked them down to rest in his lap and scowled.

Tate strode to the ring with his entourage hanging back—Jonny saw the hype men from the club in his pack—and he darted under the ropes; agile for such a big guy.

Lights flashed and popped and wisps of the purple smoke wafted over the canvas and around Tate's feet as he walked circles around the ring with one fist raised to the cheers of the crowd. Charlie cupped both hands on either side of her mouth and hollered.

Jonny nudged her side, and she flinched.

"What did you do that for?" she asked, frowning. That was her tattoo side, and he wondered if it was still sore—it had only been a few days ago.

He got close and shouted, "What are you doing?"

"I'm cheering," she said, still frowning.

He waved her off, and she went back to watching.

Up in the ring, Tate still circled, then came to a stop in his corner, his back to them. One of the hype men passed a stool through the ropes though

Tate didn't sit. The other hype man stood on the lowest rope, reached over and helped Tate's robe off. Tate stood and ignored the crowd's cheers, off in his own world. He kicked each leg out in succession, looking down, shaking his hands, flexing his arms.

A new song groaned from the speakers now, something inverse and funereal compared to Tate's energetic metal number. Cellos, big brass, a drum; it sounded like a national anthem. Tate's opponent appeared in the archway, lit up in white and blue. He was a monster. Bigger than Tate but lacking the definition and symmetry. This guy was a monolithic block with a five dollar haircut and a low brow that suggested lineage going back to the Gravettians. Instead of a robe he had a swatch of satiny fabric over his shoulders like a cape—when he stepped in the ring, Jonny saw it was the Ukrainian flag.

Charlie raised out of her seat and she wagged both hands, her thumbs turned down. She booed with the rest of the crowd.

Jonny tugged at the waist of her dress and she sat back down. He shouted, "You're rooting for him?"

Charlie said, "You want him to lose?"

Jonny nodded. "Yeah, I do."

Charlie's expression softened, and she said, "I don't want to see him get hurt."

The Ukrainian took his spot in the corner opposite Tate and ignored the crowd's boos. Tate turned his back to the center and grabbed the ropes, head bowed, as the announcer stepped into the ring holding a sheaf of paper and wearing a tuxedo.

As he read from the paper, hailing Tate from Illinois, weighing in at two-forty-five and wearing the black and white trunks, the man who might win Jonny's wife tonight raised his eyes and saw Charlie. She made sure her hunky handsome-penis saw her cheering, raising her hands to clap over

her head. Jonny saw past her ginger mane that the governor was watching her with a raised eyebrow.

Tate chuckled, gave her a casual two-finger salute and a smile. In Jonny's periphery he could see spectators on the other sides of the ring trying to get a look at who Tate waved to. Someone took a picture with a flash. He looked to see Charlie making eye contact with Tate. She showed no expression, but the corner of her mouth tugged upward slightly.

The Ukrainian was announced at two-fifty, Ivas Ivankiv from Kiev, in the blue and yellow shorts—the crowd thundered boos, the announcer ducked between ropes and the bell rang.

The two fighters skipped out to the center and touched gloves. For nearly a minute the two big men felt each other out. Circling, charging but backing off, throwing feints, kicking legs out to create distance. The crowd began a rumble of dissatisfaction. Jonny caught Tate throwing glances their way, trying to get a look at Charlie.

The action opened just as the crowd began its boos. They shut up.

Tate charged the Ukrainian, throwing a jab, getting the guy's hands up, then jacking a hard knee up that made the guy's beefy body shake. He tumbled back and Tate swung a left cross that tapped his opponent's cheek. Tate tried to take him down but Ivas got his hands up and the two grappled while standing for half a minute. Tate kneed his thighs and Ivas stomped on Tate's feet and whacked clumsy hooks into Tate's midsection. Charlie grimaced.

With thirty seconds in the round, Tate managed to hook a leg around the Ukrainian's knee and lean into him enough they both toppled to the mat. The two of them scrambled for position and Tate got a hold of Ivas's arm and reefed it between his legs but the Ukrainian wouldn't submit. The bell rang to end the round.

Jonny's hands had sweated themselves slick. His upper lip too. He smiled at Charlie. Her cheeks were flush, and she breathed with her mouth

open.

Tate sat on the stool in his corner, hunched over. Hype Man One rubbed his neck and back, and another guy rolled a piece of stainless steel over his forehead.

“Come on, Tate,” Charlie hollered, and gave three loud slaps overhead.

“What are you doing?” Jonny hissed, getting mad again and showing it in his expression.

Charlie frowned mean back at him. “I can’t believe you want him to get hurt, Jonny. That’s not nice.”

“You want him to win?”

“I don’t want to see him get hurt,” she said with precise pronunciation.

The bell rang for the next round and the two men strode out to touch gloves. Charlie turned away to watch, and Jonny stroked a hand up her back.

It was the same thing again: the two fighters feeling each other out, darting and feinting, circling. But twenty seconds into the second round Tate charged and Ivas was ready. The Ukrainian faltered, stumbling back, but it was a trap. At the ropes, he put one leg out behind him and swung a lightning strike cross that snapped Tate’s head around.

Tate collapsed straight down like someone turned his brain off. He heaped on the canvas like a load of laundry and the ref began his count.

The crowd gasped and shrieked.

Jonny smiled.

IT WAS a quiet ride back to the apartment in the limo, Jonny with his arms folded and his scowl hidden under his pulled up hood. He sat facing the direction of travel, opposing Charlie who sat with her back to the driver. Tate was next to her, slouched on the leather bench, tilted toward Charlie. A thick white bandage crossed his nose though the doctor said he didn't break it.

Jonny had a can of Coke on his thigh, held in his grip. He took it to his mouth and drew on the straw—the cold and the sweet helped his headache.

Charlie watched him, soft eyes darting up and down his body, then following his hand as he took his drink. She whispered, “I thought we weren't using straws anymore?”

He shrugged, drained the can with loud straw suction and tossed the empty can—straw and all—into the garbage.

Tate looked at his hands again. Jonny was pretty sure the guy wasn't all there. He held them out to look at the palms, then flipped them around to look at the back. His hands had been wrapped across the knuckles with thick tensor bandage. After the fight, recuperating in the locker room with an IV in his arm, Tate's hands had looked broken and swollen. Charlie had moaned and hugged herself to Jonny when she saw them.

The limo pulled up to the front door of their apartment. It was almost two in the morning now and the lobby was dark and empty.

“This is it,” Jonny sighed.

“This is it, Tate,” Charlie said, and she rubbed his shoulder.

Tate looked at them groggily and nodded.

Jonny opened the door and stepped out first, turning to hold Charlie’s hand. They stepped out onto the driveway and Charlie shivered, folded her arms around her slinky dress.

“Should have brought a coat,” Jonny said.

She said, “Are you going to help me?”

He shook his head no and Charlie didn’t like it, gave him a tight, firm mouth.

She leaned back into the car and said, “We’re here, Tate. Can you get up?”

Tate grunted.

“Come on now,” she said, and Jonny watched her back muscles flex under the tight dress as she must have been pulling on Tate’s arm. He sighed and grumbled, put his hand on her lower back. “Move, Charlie, let me do it.”

“I’m fine, Jonny,” she said, head still in the limo.

“Let me get it,” he said.

The limo driver was out now, and Jonny saw him coming, black cap on, walking from front to back on the other side of the limo. He told the limo driver: “We got it. We got it.”

“You sure?”

Jonny waved him off.

“Charlie, please,” Jonny said, and now he was caressing the small of her pretty back.

Charlie stood up, mouth twisted, rubbed her forehead. “He’s so big and heavy.”

From inside the limo: "I'm okay. I don't need help."

Charlie scooted down, hands on her knees. "Can you get out okay?"

Now Jonny saw Tate's face in the limo's door opening, smiling at Charlie, eyes a little foggy and swollen. Both bandaged hands curled the door frame, and he pulled himself out with ease. They both stepped back to give him space.

"Feeling better by the minute," Tate said, standing tall before them now, adjusting his sweatshirt.

"Can you walk okay?" Charlie asked.

Tate chuckled. "Charlie, I'm absolutely fine. Don't you worry about me."

To be on the safe side, Charlie sidled up next to him and hooked her arm around his, practically hugging the guy's thick muscular arm. Tate didn't mind that though she did it to help; he smiled.

They walked under the awning of their apartment's covered entrance and Jonny used his keycard to get both the doors for them; his thin, leggy wife strutting on the arm of this huge, muscular man.

At the elevators they waited, eyes up and watching the lit numbers above the bank.

Charlie laughed to herself and shook her head. "It was just so amazing. I can't believe it."

Jonny harrumphed, said, "I know, Charlie. You keep saying it."

"Well wasn't it? I mean the way he popped back up, shook his head, you know—shook it off, then he came right back at him...? That big guy went back on his heels and he didn't know what was happening. He looked scared like they'd just let a grizzly bear in the ring."

Tate said, "They did."

Charlie sighed, "Yeah, I guess they did..."

"I thought I was gonna lose for a second there and there was no way that was going to happen."

“You sure came back on fire.”

“No way I was missing out on you.”

Tate kissed the top of her head and she hugged his arm tighter.

IN THE APARTMENT, Charlie trotted down the three steps from the kitchen to the living room and held out her hands to receive Tate.

“I can make it down three steps, Charlie,” Tate laughed, but gripped the handrail.

Hands in his pockets and yawning, Jonny said, “She’s worried about our insurance. Slip and fall and all that.”

“I’m worried about *Tate*, Jonny,” she said, wagging her fingers to the big man for him to step down.

“I been hit harder than that, Charlie. You don’t have to worry. In fact, I demand you don’t...”

He walked down to the living room without taking her hand. “I worry about you with those heels. You’re practically as tall as me.”

“Not quite,” she laughed, turned and flexed her legs. “Do you like them?”

“One look at you in that dress and I knew that Uke couldn’t do anything to stop me.”

Charlie made a pained face. In a quiet voice, she said, “You think he’s going to be okay?”

“What did you hear?” Tate said.

“They took him to the hospital,” Jonny said.

Tate nodded and frowned. “He’ll be fine. He’s tough.”

They were all silent a moment, then Charlie said, “You want to come sit on the couch? We can watch a movie...”

Jonny said, “It’s two in the morning, Charlie.”

“I’m not even tired,” she said under her breath.

Tate said, "Jonny's right. It's late, Charlie."

"And he got his bell rung, Charlie," Jonny said. Then to Tate: "Doctor said we're supposed to keep an eye on you."

"I'm fine," Tate said, "how many times I gotta say it?"

"I'd feel real bad if you went to sleep and never woke up again," Jonny said and laid a hand over his own heart.

Tate leveled his eyes at him and, drowsy as they were, Jonny backed off.

"Can I get you anything?" Charlie asked, "You want a drink? Some whiskey?..."

"Not with all these painkillers. Good night sleep is all, Charlie."

Now he held her elbows and Charlie sucked her lower lip under her teeth.

She said, "You want to go to bed?"

Tate nodded and gave a grunt.

Jonny flinched, hearing her timid voice, soft and hopeful, the look in her eyes as she watched up at big Tate. Now his penis was swelling against its tight sleeve and he got that squirmy, claustrophobic feeling again that made his skin crawl. He pressed his thighs together and squeezed his butt muscles.

"Yeah, we can do that," Charlie whispered, and it got Jonny's cage even tighter.

Tate said, "A good night sleep, Charlie. It's late. We'll sleep in, then tomorrow we got all day. Just the two of us."

"Reza said Jonny has to be here," Charlie said.

"Just the three of us," Tate said, hands coming from her elbows to caress the bare, creamy skin of her exposed shoulders. He looked only at Charlie and she nodded.

"Okay, let's go to bed," Charlie said, took Tate's huge hand in both of hers and walked backward in her heels, eyes on Tate's. At the bed, she

paused, looked at her closet where she kept her PJs.

Tate said, "I might need help."

"Help?"

"Getting my shirt off," he said, voice thick with reluctance, not wanting to ask for help.

"I can do that," she said, "oh no, are you sore?"

"I don't know about getting my arms over my head."

"Don't worry," she laughed and ran her hands over his chest, "I'll help you."

JONNY FIDGETED WITH HIS CAGE, watching them, then went to the couch and kicked his sneakers off. He nudged pillows up to the armrest where he would lay his head, unfolded the blanket draped over the back.

When he looked to the bed, Tate was hunched over, Charlie pulling his sweatshirt over his head. Tate groaned from behind the cotton. Charlie still wore her tight dress and high heels, long legs scissoring while she stepped backward to pull Tate's shirt and sweater off. The guy groaned again as he stood upright. The doctor had taped his ribs after the fight, and Tate ran his hands over the bandages.

"You sore?" Charlie asked and tossed his tops away.

"No," he said, "not at all. Let's get this shit off." He scratched at the bandages.

"Are you sure?"

"I'm sure," he said.

Charlie said, "Jonny, can you get me the scissors?"

"Uh-huh," he said and headed up to the kitchen, dragging his feet. He brought the scissors to Charlie, and she was pulling a loose end of a bandage with her fingernails. He went and stood by the couch again. Tate was shirtless before her, his broad chest bare, his thick, muscular arms on display.

Charlie took one blade of the scissors and slid it under his bandages. “Is it too cold?”

“You’re doing great, Charlie.”

Now she cut a straight trail through the swath of bandages that went around Tate’s middle like a cummerbund. The sound of adhesive tape being scissored was loud in the quiet apartment and for some reason Jonny thought it was sensual; Charlie was revealing her lover’s body.

Once the band around his middle was cut, she began tugging it away and Tate helped her, also pulling off the stripe across his nose. She said, “Are you sure we should be doing this?”

Tate said, “I’ve been hit way harder. No way my ribs are broke. I’ve had em broken before so I know what I’m talking about.”

They removed all the tape and let it fall around their feet. Tate stood in only his sweatpants now and watched Charlie. Her hands picked at stray bits of bandage that still clung to his stomach muscles then caressed his chest; palms laying flat and stroking, fingertips grazing along his raised ridges, exploring how hard his muscular body felt.

Charlie said, “Can I get your pants off?”

Tate nodded.

Charlie’s hands came together at Tate’s waist, and even from this distance Jonny could see they were shaking. Tate wore draping cotton sweatpants cinched with a tied string. Charlie’s hands worked the knot apart, slipped one finger behind the wound strings and pulled toward herself until they came apart and dangled, untied.

Jonny’s heart raced. Tate didn’t seem like the kind to wear underwear. Charlie would pull his pants down and he would be naked.

Charlie ran index fingers under the waistband from his hipbones to the untied front then back out halfway between, just at the point where his stomach muscles met his hips. She pushed downward, her eyes lowered to see what would be revealed. Jonny’s penis struggled inside the cage and he

grimaced. The thing was tight, the rubber sticky; his penis twisted and squirmed but the rubber had a good grip on his gummy skin.

Charlie pulled the front of the sweatpants down, Tate with his chin to his chest watching as well...

Only Tate wore underwear. Some sexy briefs in royal blue like Charlie's dress. Charlie sped up now, and Jonny wondered if she had been drawing out the moment his penis would be revealed—now she saw the guy wore underwear, she just wanted his pants off.

She pulled them downward, to mid-thigh, stepped a little closer, head turned down, hands pushing along the sides of his thighs until the sweatpants felt around his ankles.

Tate said, "Hold on a second," his voice a low and quiet grumble.

Charlie looked up at him and he rested big, bandaged hands over the curl of her bare shoulders. Charlie's calf muscles flexed as she braced her toes inside her high heels—Tate was leaning on her. The big man stepped on one sweatpants leg and pulled his foot out. Stepped on the other side and pulled that foot free as well. He smoothed his hands down Charlie's arms, over the sleeves of her dress and grazed across her bare hands. Charlie still looked up at him. Here he was, this huge, muscular fighter, standing there in just sexy bikini briefs, Jonny's wife dressed in her clinging royal blue dress, long, bare legs tapered to points in her stiletto heels.

Now Charlie's hands came up to his muscular stomach again, and she ran her nails in circles over his ribs. It got Tate's stomach jumping and twitching, and Charlie never took her eyes off his. Her hands came down and rested at the top of the waistband to his briefs. She chewed on her lower lip, curled the first two fingers of both hands inside the waistband and pulled his briefs outward. She said, "Do you like to sleep naked?"

TATE DIDN'T ANSWER, just stared back at her. Charlie stepped away to make some distance and looked down. She was looking inside his underwear. The bulge was large, his big genitals sagging out the front of the cotton pouch. He was big even when he wasn't aroused. Charlie stared, looked what was between his legs, and Jonny wondered what she saw in there. How did it arouse her? Curious Charlie was curious. She liked what Tate had, and she'd admitted it to him. Now she was taking a good look and didn't care that her husband was there.

Tate said, "Tomorrow. I'll sleep naked tomorrow."

Charlie couldn't hide disappointment, and she looked up at Tate again with her brow furrowed.

She said, "I don't mind."

Tate said, "Let's take our time, Charlie. You're not here with me because of Reza. Okay? He's not pimping you out. You don't have to do anything."

Her head twitched on her neck and Jonny saw her eyes flick toward Jonny. Her husband. *She didn't have to do anything.* Tate said it. But he knew in his heart some point this weekend she would.

Tate said, "Climb into bed with me. It's been a long night. It's late. This isn't how I want things to happen. Do you?"

She shook her head no.

"Come into bed with me. Wear whatever you want to wear. Just lay with me."

Now she nodded. "Okay."

Her hand smoothed over Tate's body again, Charlie stepping back with finality. Nothing would happen tonight. Charlie knew that now and accepted it. She slid her hands down his stomach muscles, around his waist. Couldn't help herself. With her hands around and against his lower back she hugged herself to him and rested her cheek on his chest.

Tate hugged her, his huge bulge pressing into her stomach. Jonny squirmed again, and even though it didn't seem like anything would happen, his penis still wormed around against its restraints. His hand came up and he bit the knuckle of his index finger.

He sat down heavily on the couch. This was where he would sleep. His wife would be sleeping with the man who won her for the weekend. This chivalrous piece of shit, this good-looking guy with his big good-looking dick was going to climb into bed with his wife. He wouldn't make her do anything she didn't want. But Jonny knew she would. He could see her in his mind's eye like that night she begged for it from Reza. Didn't want it, but had to have it. She'd pulled down Reza's pants using her toes. Had trouble using her words, but made it very apparent what she needed. *Needed.*

He thumped his pillow, making a hollow to lay his head. Charlie sat Tate down on the side of the bed, Tate saying again how he didn't need help. Now she trotted on her toes, long legs flexing, coming to Jonny on the couch.

"What is it?" he said hopefully, waiting to hear her voice, waiting to hear her connect with him, address him, remind him that he was her life.

She said, "You going to be okay here?"

"This is where I sleep. This is where I always sleep these days."

She said, "I want you to be okay, Jonny." She wasn't smiling, she was serious.

"Okay," he said. "We talked about it."

She squatted next to the couch, rested her hand on his stomach then took the blanket and pulled it up over his chest. She said, "Jonny, I'm going to be good to Tate. Can you take it?"

"Whatever."

"Don't be like that, Jonny."

"Tate said you don't have to do anything."

“You think that’s true?”

He actually did. He shrugged.

“It’s going to happen. It’s just the way it is.”

The way she said it left the unsaid lingering: Jonny, you set up these pins and now we play the game.

She reminded him: “I love you. I love you more than anything.”

It was what he needed. He felt himself sinking into the couch, his joints melting. “Okay,” he said.

She gave another look over to Tate who lay in the bed looking up at the ceiling. She darted back and shot Jonny a quick kiss on his lips.

He grabbed her arm, but now she was standing. She gripped his hand and shook it then let go.

Now he watched as she trotted across the room again with impossibly long legs, passing the foot of the bed, Tate watching every move she made. She went to the closet and pulled out pajamas.

With her shorty PJs tossed on the bed, Charlie turned her back to the room, stepped out of her high heels, suddenly half a foot shorter now. Her hands curled the hem of her dress at the back of her thighs and she sawed her hips as she scrolled it up her body.

First her bare ass was revealed, Tate and Jonny both watching with heart-pounding interest. There was the small black star above her butt cheek, near the divot by her tailbone. She pulled the dress a little higher, showing off her tiny waist, breathed in and began to pull the dress up over her head. Her ribs pressed against her pale skin, the dress turned inside out, up over her head, then off, her apricot mane in thick curls slowly settling and swaying over her beautiful back. She tossed it away.

She half-turned now; she wore no bra. She gave Tate a timid smile and Jonny saw that she covered the breast that Tate might see with a cupped hand. She grabbed her sleeping T-shirt and pulled it over her head. These days the one she wore was tighter, and it fell short of her sexy, bare bottom.

She snagged the shorts, turned her back completely to them and put her legs through the holes, tugged them up to her waist then slapped her thigh and turned around. She was smiling.

“Fuck, you’re sexy,” Tate said. He lay with his head on the pillows, sheets pulled up to his sternum, the large humps of his chest muscles bared, his shoulder muscles twitching as he tugged the sheet down for Charlie to join him. She walked on her hands and knees, eyes on Tate’s.

“Thank you,” she said.

She sat down, pushed her long legs under the sheets, scooted downward and lay her head on the pillow, her face turned up to watch Tate. He smiled now, too. His arm went around over the top of her head, and she lifted it. He scooted down, she scooted up. She lay her head over the big man’s shoulder and he pulled the sheet up to cover her. She drummed her fingers on his chest, said, “Good night.”

“Good night, Charlie. See you in the morning. We’re going to have a great day.”

She nodded, lips pursed, eyes on his.

“I’m going to take you tomorrow,” he said and smiled. “And you’ll never forget it.”

Her eyes widened. “Yeah,” she whispered, then without thinking, kissed him just above his nipple. She squirmed now, writhed herself up against Tate’s hard muscular body and closed her eyes.

Jonny groaned, bringing his knees up protectively. The discomfort between his legs was profound. Arousal was impossible as badly as his brain provoked it. He bit on his lower lip and pressed his thighs together. There was still a chance... there was still a chance Tate’s concussed brain would turn itself off, and in the morning Charlie would wake with a corpse.

TATE WAS alive the next morning.

Jonny lay on his side with a pillow under his head and faced the bed. Charlie and Tate still lay together the way they'd fallen asleep; Tate on his back with his arm around Charlie, her curled up against him with a hand on his chest, cheek in his shoulder. They hadn't moved all night.

The apartment was bright, the sun high in the sky. He knew they slept in. He reached to his phone laying on the coffee table, checked it. It was almost five after ten in the morning.

Despite the dread he felt knowing what would happen this weekend—and getting a glimpse last night—he'd slept well. The events of the previous evening had run the gamut of human emotions. At times he'd been happy, at times he'd been upset. He'd been mad, he'd enjoyed good food, he was entertained; he soared to the height of victory thinking Tate would stay down, and crashed to the hollows of despair when the big man jumped up and ended the fight. His phone buzzed in his hand.

A text from Reza.

Reza: how is she this morning? Can my sexy girl still walk?

Jonny: fuck off

Reza: sounds like she might have liked it. You mad?

Now he regretted ever picking up his phone. He texted back.

Jonny: nothing happened

Reza: find that hard to believe

Jonny rolled on to his back, flexed his neck side to side and texted a response.

Jonny: it's true. They went to sleep

It took almost a minute for the response; the room filled with Tate's heavy breathing.

Reza: now you're in trouble. Tate gets a solid eight hours, he will be looking for action

Jonny: I'm sure he will be

A few minutes went by, and Jonny wanted to throw his phone away.

Reza: Norway is nice. You ever been?

Jonny: no

Reza: everybody here is tall and blonde. Charlie would love it, I saw a few redheads too

Jonny: that's nice

Reza: you finish that game maybe you can take her here sometime

Jonny: I have no interest in Norway

Reza: take her wherever what do I give a fuck. Are you working yet?

Jonny: I just got up. How are you even in Norway?

Reza: flight right from the fight after the show last night. Slept on the plane. First class they let you lay down. I'm in the airport

Jonny: Great. bye I have to get to work

Reza: ttyl Have fun today Jonny. You might want to do some stretches because once Tate starts doing his thing that tight cage is going to have you folded in two

Jonny tossed the phone to the coffee table. With his hands back under his cheek he watched the two sleeping lovers laying in bed. His wife and the man who fought hard to win this opportunity to be with her. But it was going to work out. There was a lot Jonny was going to get. Next weekend was all he would think about. Thinking of next weekend would get him through this one. But the cage was a real problem. The steel one had give. The steel one they'd been able to work around. He didn't like this one. That weird uncomfortable feeling it gave him when he grew aroused was almost

sickening. When his penis hardened, it felt like it was pushing back inside his body.

Tate stirred.

Charlie's eyes fluttered, sensing the enormous chest she lay on moving under her cheek. Jonny watched her eyelashes flutter, slowly he could see the bright of her eyes. She inhaled, and the sound was hoarse as air whisked through her nostrils across the skin of Tate's chest. She made a moaning sound, and Jonny watched Tate's hand curl around the point of her shoulder and rub at her collar with his thumb.

Charlie made a funny laughing sound, winced and lifted her face off of Tate. Her cheek had stuck to him, both of them warm and sticky and hadn't moved in more than seven hours. Her cheek pulled away from her face and she smiled. Tate laughed too. He said, "We didn't move all night."

Charlie said, "I had a great sleep, I wasn't even tired but boy..."

Tate said, "I was out cold."

Charlie watched him and neither of them said anything, their eyes flitting over each other's. Charlie scratched his chest, said, "How do you feel this morning?"

"Right as rain."

"You're a liar," she laughed.

Tate laughed too. "No, I'm not. I feel great. A little stiff. My face is sore..."

He turned to her, eyes on her, showing her both cheeks. He said, "Am I still handsome?"

Charlie held his wide chin and pretended to examine his face. "All your features are still there, present and accounted for. You're a little puffy, but I'd say you're still handsome."

"That's all that matters." He smiled and winked at her.

She nestled her cheek onto his chest again, an arm went around to hold his ribs and hug him. She said, "You sure your ribs are okay?"

“Totally sure.”

Charlie squeezed a little, Jonny could see the muscles of her thin white arm flexing, and she laughed and lifted a foot up under the covers, poking up a tent. “Are you sure you’re sure?”

“You got a good squeeze, Charlie, you hear me complaining?”

Her foot dropped down and she lifted her head and rested the point of her chin above his nipple looking in his eyes. She said, “I’m glad you’re not hurting.”

“I didn’t say I wasn’t sore. Just said I feel good.”

“Good. I hated to see you fight, but I loved it too. I can watch you punch him, but I didn’t want to see it happen to you...” Her elbow dipped under the cover and she moved her hand. “Oh,” she said.

“Oh is right,” Tate said with a smile.

“Somebody woke up with a big hard-on.”

“And you were worried about me.”

Charlie said, “Feels like you’re doing okay to me.”

“All’s well in my world.”

“I’ll say,” she said...

JONNY WATCHED her hand move under the covers, could see now the hump of Tate’s erection under the bedding. Charlie had her hand on him.

“You’re so big. Gosh, and so hard,” she laughed. She bit her lip, hand still moving. Her chin was still resting on Tate’s chest, watching him. She said, “Did you want to do something?”

“Let’s get some breakfast.”

“You don’t want me to do anything? I don’t mind.”

“I told you it’s not like that.”

“I know. But I don’t mind...” Her hand was still moving, stroking him under the covers.

He said, "It's not how I want to do it. Let's go out and do something. Let's get something to eat..."

Charlie said, "I can use my mouth..."

Tate touched her cheek now. He said, "I told you it's not like that. I don't want you to do things *for* me. I want to do things *together*."

Charlie's hand stopped moving. She said, "I like that."

"Good."

She said, "What do you need today?"

"Uh, food, water, rest... It would be really good to walk around. What do you want to do today?"

"Me?" She shrugged and looked to the side. Jonny could see her hand still moved under the covers.

Tate said, "Yeah, what kind of things do you like to do?"

"Wow, uh, I like the museum..."

"I'd love to go. And I need to walk around..."

"Really? Yeah, okay..." Now, more to herself, she said, "The art gallery, the big library on the west side, the aquarium..."

"Anything you want, Charlie. I want to spend the day with you, you know, not just doing *those* things..."

She giggled whipped her hand up from under the covers and rested them under her chin, laying on his chest.

"You don't want me to do anything?"

"Later. Not now. Later, Charlie..."

"I can use my hand or something..."

"That's sweet. It's not like that with me."

"It's not?"

"You know it's not."

She smiled, thumped her chin on his chest, smoothed her palms over his muscle. "I can rub your back."

He touched her lip. "You want to do that?"

“You’re sore.”

“Yeah, I’m pretty beat up.”

Charlie scooted to a sitting position. “Make a muscle for me.”

Tate was more than willing. Grinning wide he cocked an arm and flexed an impressive bicep for her and she raised her brows. She fell onto his arm with both hands clutched around his humped muscle and squeezed.

She said, “My Daddy is strong, too. No one gives him trouble.”

Tate made a fist. “You think he could have knocked a bull out with one punch?”

Charlie laughed and clasped both her small white hands around Tate’s massive clenched fist now. “I bet he could have when he was young.” She shook Tate’s fist, then tried to push his arm back over his head. He resisted. Charlie laughed and tried harder, hunching her shoulders up and trying to use her bodyweight to push his arm back down. “Golly, you really are strong,” she said, “I bet you could—”

Whoop! she hollered, as Tate let his hand thrust back and Charlie fell forward on top of him, head in his collar. Tate grabbed her in both arms then flipped over in one hard buck. Now he was over top of her on all fours, Charlie submissive on her back, giggling.

The sheets tangled around Tate’s waist, but they slipped free. Charlie squirmed underneath him, Jonny watched her knees rising up under the covers. At least Tate was wearing briefs. She hadn’t touched his bare cock under the covers.

But then, Charlie said, “Somebody needs bigger underwear.”

Tate still over her on all fours, looked down between them, sucking his stomach in. Jonny saw what Charlie was talking about.

Tate’s morning wood extended a fist’s length above the waistband of his bikini briefs. They were humped out, stretched by the belly of his big, hard cock.

Charlie's hands stroked along Tate's sides, coming near his hips, and Jonny kicked his legs under the blanket as the discomfort jumped out at him between his legs. Then as Reza predicted, he folded up in two, drawing his knees to his chest.

Charlie's hands moved slowly. Her fingertips grazed his sucked-in stomach, her hand went around the end of Tate's cock. She said, "This thing doesn't look like it wants to go down by itself."

He said, "Weren't you going to rub my back?"

"Sure," she said and smirked. Now she traced her fingertips along his waistband's trim. She pulled it downward, taking a peek inside his underwear, then tugged it upward and tried to cover his whole erection.

Tate laughed, said, "You're giving me a wedgie."

Charlie giggled, then covered her mouth. Jonny saw her cheeks red. With both hands again, she tried to cover his erection, said, "Like I said, you need bigger underwear."

He said, "It won't go back in?"

"I have an offer on the table," Charlie said and smiled, still holding Tate's underwear outward, looking in now and admiring the guy's throbbing morning wood.

TATE SAID, "Let's start with the back rub."

Charlie looked at him, bit her lower lip and smiled, pulled downward again on his waistband and let it snap up. Tate's erection bounced and tapped his own hard belly and he made a groaning sound.

"Okay," she said, "back rub it is."

She scooted upward until she was sitting on the pillow where her head had just lay. She brought her knees up and pushed Tate aside. He went with it, flopping onto his back, laying prostrate now on top of the sheets, his blue underwear bowed out, the end of his cock clearly visible.

Jonny squeezed his thighs together and pressed a clenched fist against the point underneath his nose and over his lips. This was something he shouldn't be watching. This was something that was going to hurt him. And this was why Reza made the deal so Jonny had to be here. Tate had agreed to it. He had agreed to it. Charlie had as well. And there was the unsaid threat that Reza's cameras watched them all...

So they would obey the rules, they would do what Reza wanted and find what pleasure they could find for themselves in the bad the landlord commanded.

Charlie said, "Are you going to roll over for me?"

Tate adjusted his underwear, rolled over and lay in the spot next to Charlie on the bed, pulled a pillow underneath his head to rest his cheek on it. His hips squirmed as he tried to find a comfortable position laying on that hard monster.

Charlie watched his round, tight butt flex underneath the blue cotton briefs. That hurt. He flexed his thighs again.

Tate's muscular back glimmered in the light from the apartment window. Humps and bumps, squirming muscle under tanned skin. His traps were bunched up around his thick neck, his sandy blonde hair in its nice haircut resting on the pillow.

Charlie said, "You've got so much muscle. I think my hands are going to hurt."

She sat upright, scooted so her hip touched his, laying one hand on the mattress, the other one swooping dry circles over Tate's body.

She looked over her shoulder and caught Jonny's eye. She made eye contact, looked to say something, her mouth working around. Her eyes were sad, despondent. He knew what it was. She was enjoying this but didn't want to enjoy it. She was right about Jonny not minding her with Reza because he thought that she didn't like it. Her body responded to the man's size, power, and ability, but she was just an object underneath him.

And he allowed it. This was the same situation, but this one he wanted to deny. And that was selfish. Charlie had to do this, and she hated that she liked it, but both husband and wife knew that she did indeed like it. He shrugged his shoulders. She mouthed Sorry.

He shrugged his shoulders again, gave her a half-smile.

She cleared her throat, asked him, “Jonny, can you get us some oil?”

“Oil?”

“To rub his back.”

“We don’t have any.”

“It doesn’t have to be massage oil, Jonny. Olive oil, coconut oil...”

It bugged him. How did she know so much about rubbing men’s bodies she knew what oil was good?

“Yeah,” he said, his voice dry and flaky.

He eased himself off the couch, knees first, feet touching the floor, getting off and staying in a crouch. Slowly he stood, easing out the tightness of his sleepy joints, stood then, pushing down on his cage to make it comfortable. His cock wanted so badly to be hard, and Lord, it was trying. It was straining against the silicon but there was nowhere for it to go. It wanted to lengthen, but the resistance was too strong, the rubber’s grip too tight. It pushed his penis backward into his body; the kind of discomfort that made him want to shout out.

He limped his way to the kitchen, went to the cupboards. They only had vegetable oil, and he was going to tell her, shooting a glance out the kitchen pass-through to see Charlie and Tate on the bed together in the family room below, his wife straddling Tate’s narrow waist, her long pale legs out on either side of his muscular body, her hands spread wide on his back and digging her thumbs into the muscle. His mouth open to ask her where she thought they might have better oil, he remembered Reza used coconut oil in his coffee that he mixed in the morning sometimes.

He went to the coffee cupboard, found a jar of coconut oil. He had to stop one more time before descending the stairs to the family room to adjust himself. Then he was down, coming to the side of the bed.

“Coconut oil,” he said, holding the jar with the tips of his fingers held in a claw and wiggling it for her.

Charlie straddled Tate wearing her skimpy shorts and her clinging tank top, the points of her nipples pushed out against the fabric. Her pussy was pressing against the small of Tate’s back. She looked happy, excited. He pushed his hips backward, trying to ease the tightening discomfort.

She flicked her head to the side, encouraging him to get close. He bent over, pressed his fist between his thighs and pushed down on the cage, easing his head closer to her. She hooked a hand over the back of his neck and whispered in his ear. “Do you need to get out of here? You know? Go to the bathroom or something?”

“No,” he whispered to her, “you’re just gonna rub his back.”

“I think so.”

He whispered, “I have to stay here. I’ll go to the bathroom if I can’t take it.”

“I’m sorry,” she whispered. “I have to do it.”

“You want to do it.”

Instead of whispering, this time she met his gaze and ran her tongue over her lower lip, watching him. She shrugged.

He shrugged back. “It’s okay,” he said. But wasn’t sure that it was.

“Okay, Mr. Armstrong,” Charlie said now, loosening the lid on the jar of coconut oil, “where does it hurt?”

“All over my back,” Tate said into the pillow.

Charlie scooped out hunks of white paste, pushed them onto Tate’s back, closed the jar and laid it up on the pillows. She spread her hands on him and turned the paste into clear oil with the warmth of her hands as they spread over the man’s muscle.

Jonny stood by the side of the bed, knowing if he was smart he would be in the bathroom already. But he wasn't. He was a bad person. He was a bad husband who enjoyed this. Enjoyed it and hated it, loved his wife, and was crushed by her, everything all at once.

Charlie's thumbs worked in circles over the muscle, her fingernails dragged across his skin. Jonny took a few steps back.

Charlie said, "Your body is like steel under the skin."

"Your fingers feel good. You're working that steel into rubber..."

"Like this?" she asked, and she made fists and dug them in circles like a mortar and pestle into the humps of his back.

Tate groaned.

Jonny stepped back far enough he could sit now on the couch.

Charlie said, "How about this?" And now she began a comical Swedish massage, giving quick karate chops over his back.

It made Tate laugh, the sound undulating with Charlie's chopping. That got Charlie giggling too.

Now she scooted forward, and Jonny knew Charlie was rubbing her pussy on him. She worked herself a little higher, practically hugged herself over his back, dug her elbows into him.

"Oh God, oh my God, that feels so good..."

"You like it?..."

"Oh Fuck, keep doing that..."

Charlie's smile widened, liking to hear that she was pleasing him. She worked the points of her elbows around in circles, digging into him, working up and down sideways and around. Tate continued to groan. Jonny drew his knees up until his heels were on the couch seat. He clasped his hands between his legs and over his jeans. He lay his head back on the couch.

But he still watched.

CHARLIE WORKED Tate's back for a half an hour until she was practically panting. Her arms glistened with oil, and so did Tate's back.

Her movements slowed as she became exhausted, and Tate sensed it. He said, "That was good, Charlie. That was so good... God, your hands are amazing."

Charlie sat more upright, her hips rolling forward and backward, squirming her sex against his hard body. She dug thumbs into him now, then ran her nails in light circles. "It was good?"

"So good," he moaned.

"Do you want to go get some breakfast?"

"Uh-huh," Tate sighed and rubbed his cheeks.

Charlie rolled back, got her feet on the mattress, her butt squashing on his butt with her hands on the bed behind her. She admired her fighter's shimmering oil-glistened body for a moment longer then rolled off him.

Tate turned on his side and Charlie watched between his legs. His enormous erection still pushed out his underwear and the end showed above the waistband.

Charlie said, "Well this is crazy..."

Tate laughed, groaned, watching Charlie through narrowed, sleepy eyes. His hand came down to tug on the waistband of his underwear to inch it a

little higher. The end of his cock could not be covered.

Charlie still watched it. She said, "You can't go out like that."

"It'll go down."

"Doesn't look like it's going to."

Tate lay on his back now, letting her take a good look at it. Let her take a look at his huge, hard manhood.

Charlie said, "You can't go out in public with that big thing sticking out of your pants like that."

"I thought it would go down."

"I can make it go down for you."

"I told you I don't want you to do things because you feel like you have to."

"I don't have to, I want to," she said. "And I'm apparently pretty good at it now."

Jonny fell onto his side, head thumping the pillow over the couch's arm rest. He drew his knees up again. This was one-hundred percent the point where he had to leave. This was where he should scramble to the bathroom. But he was curious to see how much discomfort he could take. He wondered if at some point his penis would grow so hard it would split the silicon rubber.

Charlie rolled forward to lay next to Tate. She said, "Let me do it."

"It's up to you."

"I want to hear you *want* it," she whispered.

"Why don't you show me what you can do. I have a feeling once you start there's no way I would ever stop you."

Charlie watched his eyes for a few seconds, kissed him above his nipple and worked her way down the bed. She eyed the end of his cock where it stuck out past the waistband. Her fingers went over and back along the curved waistband, feeling where it pressed out over his cock. Then changing from horizontal to vertical, the pads of her fingers began to stroke

on the underside of his exposed erection. Fingertips swirling around the shape of his glans, she watched herself work. With the point of a finger she collected some of his clear excitement and tickled the chin of his penis. Tate's thighs flexed, and his body bucked.

Charlie smiled, got over top of Tate now on all fours, just as he had done. She kissed the muscles of his stomach, the bulbous end of his erection pressing on the underside of her chin. She kissed lower, the slippery tip of his penis sliding along her jaw until it folded-over her earlobe. Her hand squeezed the base, slipped lower and clutched his balls through the blue fabric.

Tate groaned. Jonny flexed every muscle in his body to brace against the pressure between his legs.

The quivering pink point of Charlie's tongue ran over the coronal edges of Tate's huge glans. She pried his cock upward like a lever, and Tate's underwear scrolled down his shaft to pinch across his scrotum. She sunk the glans fully in her mouth and bobbed her head lightly.

"Oh, mm, fuck," Tate said, his hand cupping her cheek. Charlie worked her head around in circles, going nice and gentle. Tate's size pushed out her plump lips to a thin ring. She worked her head up and down, taking him as deep as she could—which wasn't very. Tate's erection was long and thick.

Her hand squeezed at his balls, then stroked the shaft. She worked him like that for a few minutes, then her fingernails went under the waistband to pull the briefs further down until his balls were freed. She ran her thumb over their shape while she continued to pleasure him with her mouth.

She had Tate groaning and squirming. Charlie was good at giving head now, she wasn't kidding. She'd been taught by other men. Men with large organs who showed her how to take them. How to give them pleasure when she couldn't get them deep. Showed her all the parts of the penis that they responded to. Charlie knew how to please a man. Charlie knew penises. Knew what parts felt good, knew how to get Tate's stomach fluttering.

It went on for a long time, maybe almost twenty minutes, Tate watching, sometimes thrusting his head back in the pillows. He would cup her cheek, he would palm the back of her head.

His legs rose on the bed on either side of her, his heels stroking up and down the mattress. His breath came quick. The muscles of his stomach flexing in and out, his chest rising and falling, his shoulders jumping and twitching. His left hand grabbed bedsheets and held them in a tight fist. Charlie stroked faster, using two hands and her mouth, both hands twisting, her head bobbing.

“Oh fuck, mm, fuck, I’m going to come...”

Charlie nodded while she sucked. Breath snorted through her nostrils, and she bobbed faster.

“Ah fuck, Charlie, oh fuck, oh shit...”

Tate’s knees came up, then his thighs slammed back on the bed and it bounced. He pounded a fist into the mattress, pressed his other fist into his forehead and turned his face away so they couldn’t see him. He arched his back, his stomach billowed out then sucked in, showing off all the muscles underneath. He snorted once, then bellowed. His legs shook and his fist pounded the mattress. He was coming. He was coming and Charlie was taking it all. Stroking and bobbing, snorting through her nose; her cheeks had gone red, her neck, too. Spit ran down over her hands, already glistening with oil, and as Tate’s reaction abated, she held him in her mouth and tight in the grip of two fists. Tate hissed breath through clenched teeth, a long draggy exhale.

Charlie held him still, her two hands squeezing tight and stroking upward, getting every last bit into her mouth. Slowly her mouth came off, her lips forming a pout at the tip when it was free; she kissed the underside of the head of his penis and smiled. She stroked him with both hands a little, and he kicked his legs and squirmed. Charlie giggled.

She asked him, “How was that?”

“Fucking incredible,” he sighed.

“See,” she said, gripping the base of his penis with a thumb and two fingers and slapping it up onto his hard stomach over and over. “Now you might be able to go out.”

“Maybe.”

“We can do it again if we have to.”

“You won’t be hungry for breakfast.”

Charlie made a snarly funny face, scrunched her nose and laughed. She covered her mouth with both hands and rolled back to sit on his thighs.

She had something to say to Tate, but spied Jonny in her periphery and made an uncomfortable face. Rolling forward to lay on him, she whispered in Tate’s ear behind the cover of her hand.

Tate smirked, looking doubtful. “I do not.”

She nodded.

“Isn’t it all the same?”

“Not yours,” Charlie said.

“I think that’s a compliment.”

Charlie shrugged, laughed, then covered her face with a lock of her hair.

Tate said, “Maybe it’s my diet. I eat pretty clean.”

Charlie shot Jonny a sheepish look, still trying to hide behind her hair.

PART 3

WHILE THEY WERE in the shower Jonny went to his workstation. It would be difficult to get anything done this weekend and he would have to take every opportunity he could get.

Behind the bathroom door he heard a low voice talking, could hear Charlie titter. They were both naked in there. It was probably better he couldn't see them. It was bad enough laying on the couch and watching the two of them cross the room, Tate with his underwear around his hips and his long, hard dick out and wagging. Now Tate would be in there with Charlie, both of them naked. Both of them getting in the shower together.

He read the message from Shulamit. She'd tried to get him on Skype last night even though he told her he would be out all evening. Message said to call him, it was important.

He opened Skype and got a connection with Shulamit.

Screen came on, showing her sitting at her desk, eating her dinner from a bowl, twirling pasta on a fork. He wondered if she really was in Italy. If she was trying to convince him by using pasta as a prop it made him more dubious. He said, "What's up?"

Shulamit said, "Your data sheets are stretched," her mouth sideways, a ball of pasta in the opposite cheek.

"Stretched?"

“Your code is covering too much.”

“It’s clean. You always say how clean it is.”

“The code is great. I’m talking about the data sheets.”

“Javed did the data sheets.”

Shulamit chewed, swallowed. “Javed’s code is stretched.”

“What does *stretched* mean?” he grumbled and rubbed at his temples.

Shulamit said, “Calm down, Jonny. What’s got into you?”

“Nothing,” he said more calmly.

Shulamit studied him through the camera for a long moment. “You want me to talk to him?”

“Who?” He pictured Shulamit talking to Reza.

“Javed.”

“Would you? Really?” He had so much shit to deal with, and Shulamit was his savior these days.

Shulamit raised her feet up to rest on the edge of her leather chair. She cradled the pasta bowl to her chest and eyed him carefully. “Yeah, I’ll deal with it. How are you doing?”

“I’m fine. Overworked. Excited, too. You know what I mean?”

“I know what you mean.”

“Excited,” he repeated. “I just want this thing to be done, I want it out there and I want it making *money*.” He growled, raked fingers through his hair. “Argh, I just fucking need money...”

“It will, you know... It will make money.”

“I know it will,” he said but even he didn’t sound convincing. Even though they were at the end of their initial development, it felt like making this thing would go on *forever* and it just wouldn’t ever see the light of day.

Water in the shower had been turned on. More tittering from Charlie. More low rumbling from Tate and it got her laughing again harder. Naked, big, strong, Tate holding the shower curtain open for his wife. Charlie

giving his awesome body a sideways glance. Or would it even be sideways anymore? This week she'd been so different, so confident.

Now he pictured her, standing in the shower with Tate, the hot water blasting his wet muscles, Charlie's hands going over his body, feeling that granite slab of a chest, moving over the bulging humps of his hard stomach muscles, Charlie smiling and laughing while she did it. No Jonny to make her feel nervous in there, and she was more confident these days, too, she'd get down and play with that big thing between Tate's legs, cup his testicles, maybe go down on him again...

"You okay?" Shulamit bringing him out of it.

He tugged between his legs, the discomfort growing, him grimacing, canine biting on his lower lip, scowling. "I'm fine. There's a lot going on..."

"I've sensed it," she said.

"Yeah, I give it away, don't I?"

"I'm gonna be honest. I give a shit about no one on this planet. Not even you. But you're close. A good guy. I think you're smart. Your game is going to win, but you got a problem with your wife... But I definitely don't want to be involved."

"My wife," he sighed, offering no more information.

"She worth it? All this trouble?"

"Is she worth it? You don't even understand, Shulamit. There wouldn't be a point in doing this game if I didn't have her."

"You're doing it for her?"

"She's doing it for me."

"Doing what?"

"Everything. She's making this possible."

"Funding you?"

He groaned. "Yeah. She's funding me." *In a way.*

“All right, Jonny. Let me call Javed. I’ll work it out. I’ll call you back. You going to be around?”

He sighed, slumped almost to his desk. “Where’m I going to go?”

WHEN THEY FINALLY EMERGED FROM the bathroom, Jonny told her he wasn’t going. Charlie said, “What do you mean?”

“You guys go without me.”

Tate said nothing, chuckled a little, went to the closet. He had a towel around his waist, his chest was bare, showing off the muscle.

Charlie sat on the end of the bed. She wore a towel as well, her hair was wet and hung in heavy ringlets around her shoulders. The towel was tucked under her armpits. She said, “Don’t...” She pouted. It was an honest reaction. It softened his heart. She really did want him to come along. But there was a part of it that made him feel like he was ruining her fun. That she would feel guilty if he stayed at home. And her guilt would wreck her time with Tate. But he was firm...

“I have work to do. You know that...”

“We’re just going to go have some breakfast.”

Tate was in the closet. He said, “Let him stay here.”

Charlie said, “You’re just gonna stay here? All by yourself?”

He said, “You know I have things to do. Go, don’t let me wreck your time with Tate.”

She frowned at him and tilted her head.

Tate was moving around in the closet, zipping open a bag of Reza’s. Jonny pushed himself out of his work chair, pivoted and sat down next to Charlie and put his hand on her knee. He said, “Don’t pout, Charlie. Just go and do whatever. I know, I know what it’s like for you. Don’t let me get in your way. Go have breakfast with Tate. Go out and go see a movie or something. You were gonna go to the museum...”

She nodded.

He said, "So go to the museum. Go have fun."

She said, "It won't be the same without you." Her chin tucked down, and she was sullen.

He couldn't help hugging her. Put his arms around her shoulders and squeezed himself to her. It wasn't even sexual. It was just love. He held her, felt the heat from her hot shower, felt the damp clinging of her clean skin. He said, "I love you. Don't worry about me. Go have fun and don't feel guilty."

"Why would I feel guilty?"

He shrugged and smiled. "See? Then what's the problem?"

She rolled her eyes and smiled, darted a peck to his cheek. Tate was out of the closet now, coming to the bed with an athletic bag. Tossed it onto the mattress and it bounced. He said, "Reza left some of my things here for me."

Charlie smiled at him over her shoulder. Jonny returned to his workstation chair. She said, "He was pretty sure you were going to win."

"I knew I was going to win, too. I packed the bag."

Charlie laughed.

STANDING AT THE OPEN CLOSET, Charlie asked Tate, "What should I wear?"

"I'm a jeans and a T-shirt kind of guy."

"Me too."

"You *were*," Jonny said.

Charlie frowned at him. "What do you mean?"

"Don't you like your shoes and your dresses now?"

"Yeah."

"Wear what you want to wear," Tate said. "Want to wear your heels?"

“No, I want to dress like you.”

Jonny said, “Your boots.”

“What boots?”

“Didn’t you buy really nice cowboy boots?”

Her face brightened. “I did... that’s right...” Her eyes went wide and happy. “I didn’t even wear them yet...”

Tate said, “Wear them with some jeans. You’ll look beautiful.”

Jonny said, “You will.”

Charlie put on a pair of skintight jeans and both men watched her. Her legs were impossibly long. She sat on the edge of the bed with her cowboy boots and set them on the floor. She only wore a bra for a top. Her tight middle bunched up in lines above the pants button and she looked sexier than ever; like an ad for Stetson cologne or something.

She pointed each bare foot and slipped them into the boots, shoved her feet down to stomp her heels in them then pulled the denim over. She stood now, looking taller, looking sexier, and she got a shirt from the closet.

Tate stood watching dumbly still with his clothes in his hand. Charlie was a knockout. It was frightening that she was beginning to learn it and recognize it herself. Her greatest gift, he’d always thought, was her hidden beauty. He was the one who got to see it when she got undressed at night and climbed into bed with him. She was sharing it more and more and other men were peeling back her petals.

Tate let his towel drop, pulled on his underwear, big flaccid cock slapping around. Charlie watched him as she pulled her head through the neck hole of her shirt. Then Tate got his jeans on and a flannel shirt, rolling up the sleeves to his elbow, showing off the forearms.

“You ready?” she asked him.

“I’m going to eat about two pounds of bacon. You going to watch me?”

Charlie said, “Watch you? I’ve been known to eat quite a lot of bacon myself.”

“Sounds like you want a competition,” Tate said and held out his arm so she could hoop hers through it.

They walked together across the apartment but stopped at the bottom of the stairs. Jonny’s thumbs ran over the inside of his fingers as he watched them.

“Hold on,” Charlie said, pivoted and skipped across the apartment, cowboy boots clicking on their hardwood floor. She beelined directly to him, and his heart soared. She fell against him, putting her hands on his thighs and kissed his lips.

She said, “You want me to bring you something back?”

He said, “I’ll just eat here. There’s lots of food...”

“We’ll be a couple hours, okay?”

“Okay,” he said. “I want you to have fun.”

“Thank you,” she said. “We will.”

She kissed him again and left. He watched her sexy long legs returning her to Tate, him holding his hand out for her. She took it, and he guided her up the steps, then the apartment door closed and he was alone.

He’d been strong, but now his heart ached. He folded his forearms over his chest in an X and grimaced, groaned. Swiveled his chair with his toes, faced his workstation, and waited for his call from Shulamit.

IT WAS HALF an hour later mid-sentence with Shulamit when he stopped.

“What’s wrong now?” she asked him.

He said, “I’m making a mistake...”

“The data sheets? I told you Javed said—”

“I have to go.”

“Go where?” she said, getting closer to the camera, her face looming on his monitor.

He said, "I just have to go. I made a huge mistake," his speech was rushed, and he was racing with sudden frantic agitation.

Shulamit was saying something, but he didn't hear her. He disconnected, shut down his monitor, jumped up. Now he was scrambling, trying to figure out what to do. No time for a shower, no time to brush his teeth, he ran up the stairs to the kitchen and grabbed his keys. Then he was out, slamming the door behind him and racing down the hall in the same clothes he'd worn last night to watch a man beat another man to earn a chance to fuck his wife. Jamming through the heavy metal stairwell door in the same clothes he slept in, bypassing the elevators because there was no way he could stand still right now.

He ran down the concrete steps taking two at a time, racing to the lobby. He had to find them. He couldn't be without her...

THE THIRD FLOOR of the Metropolitan Museum of Antiquities was where he caught up with Charlie. He was sweating. Black rings ran around the neck of his sweatshirt, under his armpits. Probably down his back, too. It wasn't even hot out, but he'd been running the whole time.

First, he got to the diner, but they weren't there. There were a dozen other joints they could've had their breakfast in, but he figured they'd done eating by that time, anyway. So he went to the art gallery first, it was the closest. They weren't there. Took a bus that passed by the library where she worked. Ran in there, waved to one of her friends at the counter, asked if she'd seen Charlie. Was told that Charlie didn't work today, and he said, I know, she has a guest from out of town, I thought she might want to show them where she worked.

Then he was at the Antiquities Museum, paying \$18.95 to get inside and poke around, see if she was here.

Sure, he could've texted her, found out exactly where she was. As much as he needed to be with her there was a part of him that wanted to see what she looked like *without* him. What would she do on a date? What would she do on the arm of a big, handsome man, a local celebrity, a fighter, six-four, two-twenty-five of chiseled muscle and a cock down to his knees? Would she strut around with him? Would she show him off?...

He was glad that she hadn't gone to the library. It would've been nice to catch up with her, but what would it mean to find her there with Tate? Bringing her new boyfriend around to show her coworkers what she could pull. Show them the kind of man her second husband would look like. It had made him grit his teeth and settle his resolve to find her without calling. He had to know...

Well there you are, Jonny, Charlie's with Tate, and it's just as bad as you thought...

Charlie and Tate were standing next to the carved wooden coffin lid of some lady priestess who sang for some king, and Charlie was telling her new boyfriend all about limestone sarcophagi; how grave robbing was a problem in ancient Egypt even when it wasn't ancient and how they used limestone cause it was too heavy for some thieves. The same spiel she had given Jonny on one of their early dates. One of those early dates where he'd fallen in love with her, listening to her timid little voice as she wanted to share with him something that interested her, wanted to share with this cute guy that picked her up at the university library how smart she was. Those days she'd been a timid little flower whose voice hardly raised above a whisper. Now here she was standing tall in her cowboy boots, elbowing her huge muscular boyfriend and laughing loudly. He could overhear her explaining to Tate: "The limestone coffins were more expensive, so only the wealthiest could afford the added security..."

Jonny spied from under the archway where Rome met Egypt. Gladiators, emperors, Caesars behind him, sarcophagi, sphinxes, pyramids, and mummies ahead. Between two worlds he leaned against a Corinthian column and watched his wife being playful with another man.

It was so terrible he considered strolling out with his hands in his pockets, catching up with them and saying *Oh hey, guys, changed my mind. Got a lot done—he didn't—and didn't want to miss out on the fun.* But a dark and dirty part of him wanted to see more.

Would she grab Tate by his big hand, her two hands pulling them into the ladies room so they can finally get this over with?... Let this big, sexy guy put that big, sexy dick inside her and make her sing her songs. What would she sound like?—what would her voice sound like outside that bathroom door? Could he stand it? Could he stand to listen to his wife being pounded in a public bathroom? And what would passersby overhear?... And when they saw this man lingering outside the door would they know that he was a cuckold? Would they know those sounds they all heard were the sounds of this poor man's wife getting it like she'd never got it before?

Charlie and Tate were moving, holding hands, heading now through an archway into the next room, a quiet cavernous cathedral containing a recreation of a gold sphinx at about a tenth to scale. Jonny adjusted his cage. The awfulness of this moment making itself aware with the swelling discomfort between his legs...

JONNY FOLLOWED, keeping a safe distance. As his wife and her suitor passed into the huge warehouse of antiquities, the room's only other sole occupants were leaving. An elderly couple maybe in their sixties, holding hands, smiling at these two young people coming in.

Tate and Charlie looked like young lovers. Both of them beautiful. Handsome Tate with his beautiful girlfriend. Charlie was tall and thin and had wild, beautiful hair. She would smile at those two old people because she was polite. And what would they think of the man who held her hand? The man who made her look *feminine*. The man who made her look like a happy woman...

They passed, and Jonny watched the older couple squeeze their hands together and smile at each other. Then they got to pass the weird dude in the stinky sweatshirt that he sweated through, lurking behind that attractive

couple and spying on them. He gave them a smile as well, but it was probably a grimace. His hair was unkempt, he was sure he had dark circles under his eyes. And he could force a smile as much as he wanted, but there was discomfort between his legs and hurting in his heart, a dichotomy of lustful pounding—they would see it on his face. They gave him uneasy smiles and continued walking.

Now Jonny situated himself by a tall glass cabinet to watch his wife with another man. They still held hands, and the sounds of Charlie's clicking boots echoed under the high rafter ceiling. They were watching the Sphinx and Charlie was talking close to Tate, probably telling him everything she knew about ancient Egypt. She was smiling, Tate was alternately looking up at the Sphinx, tilting his head to hear what she said, looking in her eyes...

Next to Jonny, inside the glass cabinet, was a diorama of a mummification. The poor unfortunate dead man lay prostrate on a wooden table. His stomach had been opened, entrails lay on his belly, an attendant prepared to stuff him with salt and sawdust. Jonny wished for that kind of relief. All his stuff—heart and lungs and hopes and dreams—stored in separate canopic jars, topped with the heads of the sons of Horus. The things he would need in the afterlife, but weren't his right now. Just like his cock. Bundled away until it was needed. When he became a man; when he earned his wife back. He longed to have his suffering removed from his body—just take every hurting bit out of him, put it in clay jars on a shelf. He could walk around a dull, empty husk and he would be happy...

Or would he? The only reason it hurt was because he loved Charlie. Without love there was no hurt.

He would embrace the hurt.

He moved from glass cabinet to glass cabinet, making sure his sneakers didn't squeak and give himself away. Charlie and Tate walked a circle around the large Sphinx that had to be thirty feet tall. He moved around

display cases, dioramas; wound his way counter-clockwise. Then he lost them.

It was momentary; he found them again. Sneaking along the edge of the Sphinx, he poked his head around to find them sequestered in a dim vestibule between a colonnade of display cases showing ancient Egyptian antiquities. They were lit by the soft lamps inside the display cases. Their figures dim, their edges highlighted; the curls of Charlie's hair lit up in amber.

Tate had backed her against a display case and she tilted her head. They said nothing. Looked into each other's eyes. Tate grew closer and Charlie rested her hands on his chest, her lips parted. Tate lay a hand on her hip and circled another behind her. She fell into it and braced herself against the frame of the display unit.

Tate's mouth came closer and Charlie tilted her chin up. They kissed.

It was soft, tender, and long-lasting. They didn't tumble with passion; they didn't fall to the floor and yank off their shirts. But they might as well have. At least that would make sense to him. What transpired between them when their mouths were embraced was powerful. Lust would make sense. Pure physical need would make sense. Biological imperatives: Charlie's pussy wanting large input. That made sense. But a long-lasting kiss twisted at his heart.

When they broke apart, their eyes stay connected. Tate was the first to smile, then Charlie did as well. She raised a hand to cup his cheek and patted his neck.

Their hands intertwined again, and they strode toward Jonny. He darted out of the way and pressed his back to the base of the Sphinx sculpture. He listened to their footsteps, relieved they weren't coming his way. He slipped along the back of the Sphinx to peek around the other side. They were moving on, onto the next era.

Jonny followed them, watched them as they toured the Greeks, the Macedonians, down the next floor and through the Mesozoic era. Charlie wasn't into dinosaurs, so they just strolled straight through, but Tate looked up in wonder at the replicas of dinosaur skeletons.

Then they were leaving, out into the sunlight.

Still inside the building, Jonny lingered in the vestibule behind the glass doors. If they were to look back they would only see their own bright reflections as they approached a vending truck parked by the curbside. Tate bought them both ice cream cones, two scoops, Charlie smiling.

As they headed down the sidewalk, Jonny emerged into the fresh air and followed behind...

THEY STROLLED through the park following the gravel pathways, pausing to watch swans on the lake. They shared their ice cream cones, offering samples of their own flavors to the other, running tongues and looking in each other's eyes.

They stopped at the gazebo by the waterpark and used the bathrooms. It was a relief, thinking back to the Antiquities Museum, imagining them going in together and what he would hear. But they just washed their hands and threw away their napkins from the ice cream cones and joined each other outside again in a few minutes.

Instead of holding hands, Tate stood by a park bench waiting for Charlie, and she stepped up onto the seat as Tate bent over. She climbed on his back and he carried her up on his shoulders. They walked like that together, Charlie reaching up to tap at branches as Tate passed underneath. He set her down again when they emerged at the iron archway entrance to the park and back onto the busy city sidewalk.

They paused there, facing each other, and Tate took both her hands. He whispered in her ear and she nodded. He kissed her neck, and she smiled.

Then their mouths locked on each other's again and they stood in the middle of the sidewalk making out while pedestrians merged around them on either side.

Tate stepped away, took her hand and walked to the curb. He snapped his fingers and waved his hand, and a passing taxi chirped its tires to dart to the curbside to pick them up.

Shit, fuck, shit...

Tate held the door for her and Charlie scooted into the taxi. He slammed the door behind him and the cab merged with traffic as Jonny raced to follow them. He stopped on the sidewalk and watched the yellow taxi grow distant in the traffic.

Where were they going? What would they do?

It was fucking obvious, wasn't it?

They were ready to fuck.

He darted in the reverse direction the taxi headed, aiming for the stairway into the subway. He threw money at the attendant, banged through the turnstile, ran the steps, and jumped on a waiting car as the doors closed. Then he sat there a bundle of nerves.

Tate and Charlie were in the taxi now. They were making out; he was sure of it. Tate would have her pinned to the corner and his hands would be up her shirt. Her hands would be running his thigh. Was she squeezing his cock through his pants? She was. He knew she was...

But the greatest fear was that they wouldn't do what he expected. The romantic interplay between them was foreplay. Everything he watched was propelling those two attractive humans toward the event where Charlie would open her legs and finally receive the man she had a crush on. But what if they didn't go home? They needed a bed to continue what they wanted to do. But what if they didn't use the bed in the apartment? What if they didn't return to the apartment? What if they got a hotel room and shut Jonny out? He was supposed to be there. Would they go against Reza?...

By the time he jumped off the subway and was running up the steps and darting across the street, weaving through traffic to get to the apartment he was bewildered and mindless.

He couldn't run up the stairwell to the apartment because he was exhausted now. So he stood in the lobby and jabbed the elevator button twenty times before it came. Then he was in, riding in excruciating slowness up to his floor, hunched over, fists beating at his knees.

When the cab dinged, and the doors opened, he rushed through so fast he banged his shoulder and collided against the leather chairs outside the elevator bank. He was rubbing his shoulder and hissing as he made it to the apartment door, keys fumbling in his hand, shaking so wildly he couldn't get it in the lock.

But then it was open, he was inside, closing the door behind him. He inched down the steps, going slow.

They were here.

Tate was on top of Charlie, laying in bed. He was fully clothed, and the sounds of the kissing was loud and wet. Charlie lay underneath him, her knees up on either side, her cowboy boots rubbing at Tate's thighs. Tate's hands roamed her, touching her over her clothes. Charlie was making soft panting sounds.

She caught him, eyes opening and seeing him standing by the side of the bed. She smiled. Her eyes were glassy and distant, she was being lured into the world of ecstasy by her hung and muscular lover.

She said, "Hi Jonny, where were you?"

"I had to run errands. How was breakfast?"

Tate bit at her neck and she made a soft snarling face.

"He's going to take me now, Jonny."

"I know."

"Are you going to be able to watch?"

"I have to."

“Okay,” she sighed, grabbed Tate’s shoulders and kissed his mouth hungrily...

JONNY WALKED BACKWARD to sit on the couch.

Charlie lay her head on the pillow while Tate was overtop of her. The big man took both her hands, and she let him. They intertwined fingers.

Charlie's denim legs worked up and down Tate's waist, the cowboy boots curved to cup at his bottom as he humped his hardness between her legs. Tate bit at her shirt lapel and tugged away the top snap button. Charlie giggled. He did it again, unsnapping the next button, tugging with teeth clenched on the cotton, working his way down until he'd opened her shirt to her navel.

Then he pushed her hands into the bed and humped his hips hard, rolling against her, and Charlie kicked her legs feeling his stone erection pressing through both of their denim pants. She laughed, liking it. Now he worked lower, hooking one arm around the small of her back and curving her waist toward him, kissing her stomach in the bared line between her shirt and her pants.

Up on his knees now, Tate was eager to take his shirt off. Charlie raised on her elbows and set the soles of her boots on the bedding. Tate pulled his shirt off, and Charlie admired his body. His big hands stroked her denim thighs. They kissed again, Tate putting his hands on the bed on either side of her waist and Charlie closing her eyes and opening her mouth for him.

She bit at his lower lip, and he said, “You’re so fucking sexy it’s killing me.”

Charlie smiled. “You are too.”

Tate pulled her head back by a handful of her hair; they collapsed on the bed again and he bit her neck while Charlie raised her knees and kicked at his bottom.

This was real. This was going to happen, and it was nothing like he’d seen before. Charlie *wanted* this. For the first time he was seeing his wife without reluctance; she *desired* to feel Tate. Charlie wanted this man to take her. And while it was somehow a duty she performed—done for the same reason she’d been with Reza—he was profoundly aware that his wife was eager. Lusty. Horny.

He sank off the couch, hands clutched over his squirming half-hard bundle being gulped back inside his body. On his knees, he watched his wife and her lover on the bed, and he began an internal mantra: “If it’s okay with Reza, it’s okay with Tate... If it’s okay with Reza, it’s okay with Tate... If it’s okay with Reza, it’s okay with Tate...”

If you don’t let her do this with Tate, you’ve been hurting her this whole time, using her, and that’s impossible because you love her more than anything...

Tate undid her shirt, and Charlie watched his eyes to see what he would think of her body. She pulled the shirt away, still watching him, only wearing a pale pink bra. They kissed again, Tate stroking his big hands on her hips, Charlie’s neck flexing and working as their mouths sucked on each other’s.

Tate unclasped her bra and Charlie helped him take it off.

“You are so beautiful,” he said as Charlie laid back turning her face away and smiling.

As Tate suckled on her nipples, Charlie brought her knees up to his armpits. He took turns, the left one, the right one; kissing on her ribs,

kissing her sternum. Charlie watched the top of his head as he suckled on her, her head writhing on the pillow. The worst thing was the smile on her face. It was killing him.

Jonny reached behind him without looking, gripped his blanket and pulled it over his shoulder. Blanket clutched in a loose ball, he pressed it down hard between his legs.

Tate worked his mouth lower, kissing his way to her navel, and down to her pants button. He tugged with his teeth again, but had to use his fingers to get the button undone. The zipper was drawn down, revealing Charlie's pink underwear in the open V of her fly.

Charlie was eager, digging her heels into the mattress and raising her butt right up off the bed, pushing her shoulders into the pillow and looking down her body. Her nipples were like hard cherry pits sitting on her soft creamy breasts as Tate pulled her tight jeans down her legs.

He scooped them over her knees and she had to help, pushing them with her hands; Tate tugged on her boots and she had to kick her legs, laughing and joking as they had fun with each other. He got them off, throwing a boot on either side of the bed and kissing the inside of her calf as she rested her ankle over his shoulder. He stroked the inside of her thigh, his hand grazing lightly over her pussy; touching her over top of the cotton panties.

Then his tongue was licking from her waistband up to her neck and they kissed again, Tate over her. He ran his tongue down her body to between her legs and Charlie put a hand over her mouth, formed a fist and bit her first knuckle as he kissed her pussy over top of her panties. He pushed his mouth against her and Charlie made soft moaning sounds; Tate tugged down her panties, and she lifted her butt again. They were pulled free and tossed toward Jonny.

Charlie pressed the point of her knee against the huge bowed bulge pressing out the front of Tate's jeans. He arched his back, humped his hips against her pressing.

“We should get some lube,” Charlie whispered.

“You want lube?”

Charlie’s smile faltered, and she said, “Is that okay?”

“You know it is,” he said and stroked her cheek.

“You’re big.”

Jonny grunted. She’d taken Reza, and he was probably bigger. More proof she wanted this to be pleasure over duty.

If it’s okay with Reza, it’s okay with Tate... If it’s okay with Reza, it’s okay with Tate... If it’s okay with Reza, it’s okay with Tate...

Tate said, “We can take our time, Charlie.”

She nodded a slow and careful up and down line, her eyes on Tate’s. “I’d like that,” she said.

“If you need lube, we’ll use it. But I don’t think you do.”

She smiled and pressed her knee into his large erection again. “I don’t know...”

Tate lowered, his lips kissing her knee, then running along the inside of her thigh. Charlie began a high, quavering sound of intense anticipation; she was excited, breathless and bewildered. Tate wanted to please her with his mouth...

TATE LOWERED his face between her thighs, Charlie raised her knees for him making funny, nervous titters. But when he kissed her bare pussy, she arched her back and moaned.

Tate said, “You got such a beautiful pussy,” then smoothed the back of her thighs, gripped behind her knees and pushed her legs up. She rested her bare feet on his shoulders as he kissed her between her legs. Charlie moaned and groaned, and made strained grunting sounds, being driven out of her mind. Her hands clenched the cotton sheets. Tate caressed her thighs while he ate her out, his round denim butt sticking up in the air. He worked

her over, kissing and suckling, licking his finger and probing her, teasing her.

As he fingered her, he watched her reaction, smiling and enjoying it. Charlie writhed and bucked, grabbed handfuls of her own hair as she arched her back into a tight bow.

Then he was sucking on *two* fingers and teasing her, sliding them in, Charlie gasping and moaning, Tate chuckling as he watched her reactions, Charlie knowing he was laughing, and joining in, covering her face as this man *controlled* her with his hand and his mouth. Sometimes she would moan, close her eyes; other times she would stare, bug eyed but unseeing. She came finally.

Watching his wife come did Jonny in. Tate jacked his hand between her legs, sloppy sucking sounds, his muscles bulging. Charlie bucked and jumped and squeaked. Jonny's cock squashed between his legs, fighting the rubber, pushing into his body but now the arousal so intense the cage's outer ring pried upward, strangling his balls. Now he had that squirming feeling and a hurt in his stomach and balls. The arousal was denied.

As Charlie panted and moaned and Tate chuckled, Jonny opened out the blanket and put it over his head and shoulders, watched out at his wife and Tate on the bed from under its cowl.

Tate still stroked her, stroking his fingers inside her but getting up to kiss her face. Charlie hooked a forearm around his neck and hugged and kissed him in return.

Charlie's orgasm didn't sate her. It energized her.

Now she was sitting up, pushing Tate's hand away from between her legs, both of them on their butts and kissing. She rolled him back so he lay with his head at the foot of the bed, her hands working at his button and undoing his zipper. Together, they pulled his pants off and he kicked his shoes away. Charlie ran her hand over his cotton bulge, squeezing his balls and tracing the shape of his huge cock beneath the underwear.

But she was too eager to play around, and she hooked her fingers into the waistband and pulled them down to expose his bare hard cock. He scurried them down his thighs, caressing her arm.

His underwear wasn't even off and Charlie was kissing his balls, running her tongue up his length. She gripped him by the base and got her mouth over it. Tate closed his eyes and let her, laying back with his muscular body prostrate as Charlie stroked and sucked. There was something about Tate's big dick that she *loved*. She couldn't keep her mouth off it. She loved what he had between his legs. And it was a big beautiful thing, too, Jonny couldn't deny it. Huge but not garish, symmetrical and smooth and masculine. Charlie sucked until his whole shaft gleamed with wet.

"You going to fuck me?" she asked him, smiling and darting her tongue over his cock head. Her hand stroked up and squeezed.

"You're so fucking hot," Tate moaned.

"I want it so bad," she whispered, jerking him. "I want this big dick inside me."

Tate got up, and Charlie knew how she wanted it, rolling to her back, lifting her knees and opening her legs. Tate got over her, and she admired his muscle as he got hands on either side of her, his face over hers, big cock wagging between them. She stroked the inside of her knees against his hard, muscular sides.

She said, "I've waited for this a long time."

"Me too. I wanted this from the first second I saw you."

"Me too," she said.

They settled themselves in the bed, Tate raised up, hooking his forearms under her knees and straightening her body underneath him. He lined his cock up and Charlie brought her knees higher, the backs of her calves resting on his hard, muscular shoulders.

Again, there was that big smile on her face. She wanted this and there was no doubt in her mind. No trepidation. She'd been used a lot. She'd taken Reza many times. She was used to having sex with men who weren't her husband. And this time she was with somebody she liked it. Somebody she wanted to have inside her.

Tate pushed down with his middle fingers on the top side of his huge cock and nestled it in her folds. He said, "I'll be careful."

"Go slow," she said.

"You want it slow?"

"I want to make it last. Just when you put it in..."

Tate laughed; his laugh turned to a groan as he slid himself slowly inside her. He watched her face, her eyes locked on his. He did take his time, putting his thing into her as they both looked into each other's eyes. Charlie's mouth was held open in a gasp. Each time he sunk deeper she would huff breath.

He asked, "It's okay?"

She said, "It feels so good. Nice and slow..."

"You're so wet," he said.

"I am. You feel so good..."

"We don't need lube," Tate said.

She shook her head no. "We don't need lube..."

"I told you," he said.

She nodded now and bit her lower lip as he sunk his big thing even deeper.

Charlie closed her calves around either side of his neck as Tate now started to fuck her. Drawing his cock back out, pushing it in. Her hands scratched and grabbed at his thighs as he picked up the pace.

"Still okay?"

"Okay," she gasped. "Okay... Harder..."

"You want it harder?"

“Yeah, oh, mm-harder...”

Her hands gripped his waist and her nails scribbled over the small of Tate’s back as his big, round, muscular rump rose and fell, his huge cock fully inside Charlie, her bare feet intertwined over Tate’s head. She squeaked and gasped as he fucked her. Jonny could see his bouncing balls in a big round bunch underneath his asshole. Tate rolled and rocked, and Charlie drew lines all over his back. Soon he had her crying. Making her sex sounds that Jonny loved. Yes’s and O’s and That’s its. She loved it with Tate. This man who rolled and wrestled with two-hundred-and-fifty pound giants had this hundred-ten pound beauty folded in two like a gymnast, her knees up to her ears as he fucked her hard and steady...

TATE DREW HIMSELF OUT, kneeled before her, torso upright so he could watch his cock moving in and out as his thumb stroked her clit. He said, “You’re so tight. This pussy is so perfect...”

“Your *cock* is so perfect,” she said, and stroked over top of his thumb, helping him please her clitoris.

Tate held her other hand and rocked himself against her, looking like he was riding a bull, big huge cock running in and out of Charlie. Her small breasts jostled on her chest, her hard nipples rolling around in circles as the bed rocked and the headboard banged against the wall.

They held hands and both of them teased her clit as he fucked her. Charlie moaned and groaned, made little squeaking sounds. Then he was overtop of her again, both her hands held in his and pinned above her head, hips driving hard. Charlie locked her legs around him, ankles twisted at the small of his back.

“It’s so big... It’s so big and perfect...”

“You’re so tight and hot, and you’re fucking beautiful,” he said, rump rising and rolling, driving his huge thing in and out of her.

She gasped, “I’m going to come... I’m going to come, Tate...”

“Do it, come for me,” he said and pounded her harder.

Jonny watched as one foot hooked over the other, her ankles locked, toes flexing, her feet curling. She panted and gasped, her breath coming quicker and quicker, Tate’s rump driving like a piston. She cried out when she came, and Tate kissed her neck.

While she was still in the throes of her orgasm, panting heavily, Tate withdrew and rolled her over onto her tummy. She laughed, looked over her shoulder at him, raised her rump up, her little black star showing.

She said, “You want to fuck me from behind?...”

He straddled her, his thighs on either side of hers, took that huge thing, pushed into her from behind as she lay flat on the bed. Her legs kicked and she squealed with discomfort.

“You okay?”

“You’re so big,” she reminded him.

“You can take it. You’re tight, but you can take it.”

“I like taking it,” she said, and he picked up the pace, pounding her until he had the bed bouncing again, her creamy buttocks slapping and jiggling as he fucked her. His two big hands pressed over her narrow back and he pushed her into the bed so he could pound her even harder.

Charlie made great sounds of discomfort but also pleasure. Loving every bit of it, but Jonny knew it was hurting her. Tate was big and powerful, and as much as it hurt her, Charlie *wanted* it. Jonny knew the feeling. His cock was gripped in a rubber vise and there was nothing he could do about it—but he didn’t want it any other way.

Charlie crossed her ankles over, bringing her knees together, making her opening even tighter, giving more resistance to Tate’s penetration. Charlie getting off on being taken by a man so large and powerful.

When it was too much for her, she dug her hands into the mattress then and pushed herself up so that she was on all fours with her knees out wide.

Tate took her from behind still, his hands on her ass, rolling her into his thrusts, his hands palming the round curve of her ass cheeks.

Charlie came again. Gasping, “You’re so big, you’re so big,” and then, “Harder, oh, harder, harder...”

Tate appeased her, driving hard and fast and slapping her ass now. Then he stopped while she was coming. Held himself steady, his huge cock outright and buried inside her but he let Charlie do all the work, let her get what she needed. Riding out an orgasm and swiveling her hips with her large lover fully planted inside her. She shone with sweat and her hair tangled on her face. She said, “I need you to come. Can you come for me?...”

TATE POUNDED HER, showing the strain on his face. “Oh fuck, I’m so close...”

Charlie on her back now, Tate overtop, said, “Do it, come for me.”

Tate groaned and arched his back, baring his teeth. “Oh fuck, it’s coming...”

“Give it to me...”

“You’re not on the pill.”

“No,” she gasped. The headboard beat against the wall.

He grunted, “Is it okay?”

“I-I think so...”

From the floor, underneath the blanket’s cowl, Jonny said, “You *think* so?...”

But it was too late, Tate had both her hands pinned on the pillows above her head and Charlie was wild in ecstasy. He pounded her faster and faster; the veins raced through his biceps and forearms, his skin shone wet and then he was ejaculating inside her. Bellowing and thrusting, bucking, holding himself inside, withdrawing and thrusting again; each time roaring like an animal and Charlie wailed underneath him, twisting and writhing with her hands pinned above her, loving every drop he was putting inside her.

Charlie's ankles, locked over his back, clung and climbed as Tate continued to spurt his seed inside her; she mewled, eyes closed, chin upturned.

The room went quiet without their squeals and roars—their rushing, heavy breaths seeming timid in the absence of their shouted ecstasy.

Tate panted, “Holy... holy shit...”

“I know...”

“Oh, wow...”

“Tell me about it,” Charlie whispered and ran the back of a hand over her sweaty brow.

It got them both laughing, their tummies bouncing.

“Ooh, oh,” Charlie protested, hand going down to where Tate speared her. “Don’t laugh, don’t laugh... oh, ha, I’m so sensitive. Take it out.”

As Tate withdrew, Charlie's sleepy eyes fluttered and her mouth hung open. There was a wet smacking sound, then Tate plopped his big wet cock over her mound. Charlie looked down her body and smiled, swaying her hips, knees up at Tate's sides still.

Jonny groaned and pinched his thighs together. His mind was reeling, feeling airy and floating yet heavy and leaden all at once. His vision was dim and set with sparkling stars. The sight of Tate's big cock on his wife's belly, a plump trail of pearly semen snaking from the slit proved too much. He eased forward, hunched over, fell to the floor and thumped his forehead against the hardwood. He kept himself upright, hands shoved in the sweatshirt pouch, forehead rolling side to side over the floor, appreciating its cool hardness.

From the bed, Charlie's voice: “Oh, hoo,” she sighed, “that was so-oo amazing...”

“You can fu-uck,” Tate said. Charlie giggled at that.

The whole display—Charlie engaged in a hybrid of fucking and lovemaking—was profoundly worse than watching her with Reza. With

Reza it was animal lust and domination... This was... this was...

Charlie's voice again: "You all right?"

...It was dangerous.

"Jonny, you okay?"

"Yeah," he grunted into the floor, eyes closed. Body tucked into a ball, he rolled to a shoulder then onto his back, knees pulled up to his chest. Charlie peered over the edge of the bed with a look of concern. Her hair tumbled around her face and he could see the slope of one bare breast but not her nipples.

Her lips wriggled, and she frowned. "You sure you're all right? Is it your cage?"

"You think it's okay?"

"Is it too tight?"

"Not that. Not my cage. What he did... *inside* you... You *think* it's okay?"

"Yeah..."

It took some work, but he made it to his knees, hands still shoved in the front of his sweatshirt pouch and turned around to face the bed again. "You think?"

"It's okay, Jonny."

"Is it?"

She rolled her eyes, flopped back to the bed, perfect little breasts shaking. She stared at the ceiling. There was irritation in her voice: "I think so."

"Charlie, come on..."

"It's fine, Jonny, it's fine..." she said, exasperated.

"Charlie, this is serious—"

"It's fine, Jonny. I can count days. It's just, is it *ever* fine?" She turned her palms up.

He grimaced, sank his butt back on his heels and squeezed his thighs. His prostate throbbed, pulsing like a live wire. His balls ached as though they were squeezed. His penis was inside his body, he was sure of it, pushed up into his belly or something. He shook his head, then hung it.

“I hope you’re okay,” Charlie whispered.

“I’ll live.”

He squinted to see her, and she smiled. Tate loomed over her shoulder, turning his head now on the pillow to regard Jonny. He’d stayed out of it, always preferring to pretend Charlie’s husband didn’t exist.

Charlie rolled her head to Tate. “They made him put on a smaller cage.”

Tate showed no expression.

Jonny said, “He knows. He was there.”

Tate scowled.

“Oh?”

Jonny smiled, said, “He was the one who put it on me.”

Charlie’s expression pinched; he watched it sag, look unsure, move toward concern, then break with humor. She chuckled, looked over her shoulder at Tate again. “*You* put it on him?”

Tate’s expression stayed blank, and he shrugged one round, bulging shoulder.

“You actually put it on him with your hands?”

Tate’s eyes moved to the side to meet hers.

Charlie smiled wider as she comprehended this. “Did you touch his penis?”

“No,” Tate said, scowling.

“How’d you put it in a cage?”

“He didn’t touch my penis,” Jonny said.

“You slipped it over?”

Tate shrugged and shook his head: *obviously*.

“You locked my husband’s penis up?”

Tate averted his eyes and smirked.

Jonny said, "Reza made him."

Charlie looked to Jonny, registered the menace on his face. "Oh."

They were all quiet a moment, then Charlie smiled again. Over her shoulder to Tate: "Did you lock up my husband's dick and then have sex with me in front of him?"

Tate smirked, eyes up to the ceiling. "I guess..."

Jonny groaned, "What's Reza got on you, anyway?"

Charlie whispered to Tate, "That is so *crazy* bad."

Tate's eyes met hers. "You like it?"

"I don't know what to think." She chuckled now, and her breasts shook. Jonny saw her nipples had hardened again. "You used your hands to lock his cage?"

Smirk tugging to one side, Tate looked up to the ceiling again.

"What a bad boy you are," Charlie whispered, and poked an index finger into the muscle of his shoulder, "locking up my husband and then doing what you just did to me."

Tate's smile widened, and he chuckled too.

"You locked him up to have your way with me?" Now she pounded a light and loose fist on his chest. He grabbed her wrist.

"You're a monster," Charlie mouthed, then smiled.

Tate pulled her on top of him, hugged her, rolled away and got over her. She sunk into the bed under him, eyes on his, knees raising.

Their breaths came heavy again; Tate reached between their legs, rolled his hips up.

Charlie gasped, her nails gripped into his lower back as he fixed his huge cock in her opening. Then they were kissing, Tate's hips humping into her again, Charlie's hands stroking his muscle. The wet mucous sounds of their joined sexes were loud in the apartment. Charlie's passage accommodated her lover with the lubrication from his first ejaculation.

As she panted and gasped—Tate stroking deeper—Jonny’s teeth and knees ached. The urge to orgasm was triggered but his arousal was impossible. His body curled up again like a potato bug but he couldn’t protect himself from hearing their sex sounds.

With great effort he pushed himself to kneel, then stand. In his periphery he saw Tate’s wide back, muscular arms supporting him over Charlie; her thin white legs were up and open, knees in Tate’s armpits. The steady syncopated suction as her canal was stroked by her lover’s large organ accompanied him as he stumbled across the foot of the bed, banging off the washroom door frame. He closed the door with his knee, tumbled to sit heavily on the lip of the tub.

It was quieter, but he could still hear his wife’s gasps. He turned, levered the water and let it rush in the tub, pulled his hood tighter around his face and put his hands over his ears.

HE GAVE THEM FIFTEEN MINUTES.

With careful slowness he let the hood peel from his head and he heard nothing. Bathtub lever closed with an elbow he listened. No sex sounds.

It had taken fifteen minutes of meditation, wasting water down the drain, but his throbbing arousal had subsided. The ache remained, and he was sure his testicles had been destroyed by the pressure.

At the sink he washed his face, didn’t look in the mirror. teeth brushed, hair combed, he cracked the door and looked out.

His wife lay naked over the covers, satisfied, exhausted, the pink line of her sex gleamed wet. His stomach flipped over. Door opened further, he saw Tate sitting at the edge of the bed with his feet on the floor.

With his back to Charlie, Tate stretched and said, “Well, we could go out. You want to do that?”

Charlie said, “Unh-unh,” her hand tracing between her legs and feeling where this man had punished her with large pleasure.

“You don’t want to go out?” Tate asked, looking over his shoulder at her.

“I want to stay naked till tomorrow,” she said. Now she caught Jonny watching from the bathroom. She smiled and twinkled her fingers at him in a playful wave.

Tate said, “Let’s order in.”

Charlie sat up cross-legged, made a sad face at Jonny, mouthed: “You okay?”

He nodded, opened the door wider.

Tate said to Charlie, “What do you like to eat?”

Eyes still on Jonny, she tried to hold back a smile but couldn’t. She giggled and covered her mouth. “Umm... Pizza?...” She winked at Jonny.

Jonny’s heart lifted and he couldn’t help it. He smiled too.

Tate said, “I would *de*-molish a pizza. Angelo’s?...”

Charlie gasped. “I *love* Angelo’s.”

Jonny grunted, shook his head, heart feeling squeezed, belly feeling hard and hurting, testicles feeling ruined. He turned and dropped his butt into his workstation chair.

Arm up on the ledge of his desk, he scooted fingers at the mouse to bring his workstation to life. Both monitors glowed to vibrant light, one with code, the other with a playing demo and a window showing unopened messages from Javed and Shulamit. The one from Javed was marked urgent with an exclamation mark, but he was not in the mood to deal with it just yet.

Tate rose to stand, still half-hard and shining, stretching arms above his head. Their eyes met, and Tate looked away, disgruntled. Arms down, swinging, making that penis dance, he came around the foot of the bed, grabbed his jeans from the floor where they’d been tossed. Phone retrieved

from a pocket, he made his way to the couch and dropped himself on it, put his bare feet up on the coffee table and dialed. His genitals hung under his thighs, resting against the couch's welt.

While Tate dialed, Charlie got up from the bed, gathered sheets around herself like a toga and came to him. He rolled his chair to face his workstation, and she put her arms around him and stood at his side, resting a knee up on the arm. The movement of her legs stirred up a humid sex smell from between her thighs.

"I know it's hard, Jonny," she said and hugged his shoulders, kissed him above his ear.

He scoffed, and she realized what she said.

"Not like that."

"I know."

"Is it really uncomfortable?"

"It's nothing like the other cage. Nothing at all. It's impossible."

"I'm so sorry, Jonny. I wish there was something I could do."

"It hurts my stomach so bad. My knees, my jaw, my temples. I have such a fucking headache."

She kissed the top of his ear.

He said, "Would you check it for me?"

"Sure," she whispered.

"I'm afraid to look," he told her, pulling down the front of his sweatpants.

Charlie scooted forward enough she could peer down the front of his pants. She put a warm hand over his and guided him to open his pants further. He looked up at the ceiling while she examined him. She made a soft slow exhale.

He asked her: "Is it still there?"

"It's still there, baby."

"It feels like it's going inside my body."

“Can I touch it?”

“Okay. Don’t get me going...”

He kept his eyes on the ceiling. Tate talked to the guy at Angelo’s. Charlie’s fingertips prickled through his pubic hair and got his stomach fluttering.

Tate said, “Meat lovers,’ right? You like meat?”

“Meat lovers,” Charlie agreed without looking around. Her fingertips went over his swollen testicles. “And tiramisu and some Brios, too.”

Tate said okay and relayed it to the guy at the pizzeria.

Jonny said to Charlie: “They feel like they’re going to explode.”

“One more week, Jonny. We’ll make em explode together.”

The sweet sound of her voice, her fingers patting his aching balls, the sex smell from her, her promise of sexual favor, her proximity all proved too much, and he groaned.

“Stop,” he said and regretted it. But if he let her play with his balls, all that would come of it was discomfort and dissatisfaction. Right now it would be possible for him to get up, wander to the toilet, knock the lid up and throw out all his stomach contents through his yawning mouth. The *squeeze* on his balls was enormous.

She asked him, “Are your balls really sore.”

He nodded. “Are they blue?”

“Not really. They look... *big*.”

“They ache so bad.”

“Jonny, I wish I could help you. I really do.”

“I know...”

“That cage is so small, Jonny, I have no idea how Tate got your willy in there.”

“It wasn’t easy,” he told her.

“I’ll bet,” she said, kissed his ear again, eased off the chair’s arm and left him.

Her bare feet padded the wood floor, took her across to the couch where she collapsed next to Tate and he hugged an arm around her. Jonny watched her in the small cosmetic mirror, having to reach and touch it downward so it would angle to see her. Tate sat naked, Charlie lay next to him wound in bedsheets.

She asked Tate, “Want to watch some TV while we wait for our pizza?”

Tate said he did, and they flicked the TV on and it wasn’t long before Charlie was introducing him to the old black and white episodes of The Twilight Zone. Jonny popped up a messenger window and fired off a message to Reza. His feet bounced under the desk, waiting for a reply. He hated reaching out to his tormentor like this, but maybe enough was enough.

THE MESSAGE he’d sent to Reza...

Jonny: I will do anything you want to get this cage off

It was almost ten minutes of agony before he got a response.

Reza: you’re doing it now

Jonny: please

Reza: you’re doing anything right now

Jonny: ?

The dancing dots showing waiting for Reza’s response showed the man’s irritation.

Reza: you're getting your cage off next week and right now is what you're doing to make it happen. isn't it fucking obvious?

Jonny: I'll do anything you want to get the cage off RIGHT NOW

Reza: you don't have anything I want

Jonny: percentage

Reza: percentage of what?

The apartment intercom buzzed. The pizza guy was here from Angelo's.

Jonny: the company

Reza: your company is nothing, your game is nothing. it's a joke. just suck it up

Jonny sighed, grunted, bumped a fist on the workstation desk. Over his shoulder Tate was on the couch canoodling with his wife right now, waiting for their pizza.

Jonny: let's make a deal

It was almost two minutes before Reza responded, Charlie and Tate giggling and being playful, play wrestling. Tate dared Charlie to answer the door for the pizza guy naked.

Finally...

Reza: yawn, stop annoying me...

Reza: shit you know what? I got the key here with me in Norway

Jonny: you do not

Reza: I absolutely do, you're wasting your time

Reza: kiss Charlie for me

He knew there would be no more responses from the landlord.

"No way, no way, no way," Charlie was saying. "You do it."

"Me do it? With my dick out? Who would want to see that?"

Charlie laughed. "Please! I want to see that..."

"I'm not doing that."

Charlie said, "But it's fine if I do it?"

"It'll be a guy."

"So?"

"It'd be funny to see his face."

"For you maybe."

Tate agreed with a smirk. "Yeah, for me."

"Why would you be looking at the guy's face?" Jonny said, scowling at them.

Charlie smiled. "Yeah, why would you be looking at the guy's face if I'm naked?"

"You got me. I'd be looking at your ass."

"You're bad," she said and beat his shoulder with a fist.

There was a knock at the door...

WHILE CHARLIE TITTERED with her hands over her mouth, hiding behind the couch and spying, Tate went up wearing only a towel and answered the door like that. While his wife got a big kick out of it, Jonny saw nothing funny, nor did the delivery guy. It was pretty anti-climactic but Charlie howled like it was the greatest prank she'd ever been a part of.

Jonny skipped dumb Angelo's pizza and worked while they ate and watched TV. It was hard to concentrate, but he enjoyed the challenge right now. Tate and Charlie grew silent and their movie ended. They didn't change the channel. They'd fallen asleep together.

Jonny worked for another hour without them moving.

But soon the lovers on the couch roused. Movement in his cosmetic mirror caught his eye, and he watched Charlie come awake, smiling. She lay with her head in Tate's lap, between his legs, her long body stretched out on the couch, Tate with his feet on the floor. The bed sheet wrapped her still, and covered parts of Tate as well. She kissed his stomach, and he played with her hair, his eyes heavy and drowsy.

He asked her: "You feel like doing something?"

Charlie nodded, kissed his stomach a little lower.

Now her arm moved, came out from the cover of the bedsheet and her hand slipped between them. Tate's head went back and Charlie lay his flaccid cock over her neck. Her hand disappeared again and Jonny assumed she was pushing Tate's balls, at least one of them, into her mouth and sucking on it. Tate's head went back, and he groaned.

Charlie used her mouth to play with and suck Tate's scrotum for a while. His cock lengthened, grew hard, rose off her neck; tapping it once in a while as they moved around a little.

Tate said, "Is there something you want to do?"

Charlie shrugged and Tate's cock bounced on her collar. She rolled to her back; Tate took his heavy manhood and tapped it over her mouth and Charlie laughed, pursed her lips and made noises against his skin.

Tate said, "Is there?"

Charlie took his cock overhand, ran her tongue along his underside, moved it out of the way so she could say, "Maybe."

"Tell me."

Jonny strained to hear, knowing she would whisper. His thighs had closed and flexed like iron again.

Charlie whispered, "Maybe I could ride it."

"You want to ride it?" Tate smiled.

Charlie made an embarrassed face, took his cock and covered her eyes like she could hide behind it. Tate extended both arms over the back of the couch, his cock over Charlie's face, too engorged now to drape it was straight as an arrow.

"Come on," Tate whispered in a low, husky voice, encouraging her.

Charlie rose with the sheets scooped around her and straddled Tate's lap. They kissed for a long while, Tate's hands feeling her back. Then the sound of rustling sheets and Jonny tilted the mirror to see Charlie tugging them away to bare their sexes. Tate's cock was erect and upright, pressing against the softness of one of her ass cheeks. She caressed its underside, moved it, angled it, eased forward so its tip nestled in her glistening pink stripe. Once it was seated, she put both hands on his shoulders and slowly sank herself on him, sliding it deep inside her. Tate's balls climbed and rolled in their sack at the feel of her hot tightness on him.

"Jesus," Jonny sighed and tightened his hood around his face.

He tried to look away, look at his code instead but all he could see in the small, round mirror was his wife's pale shoulders rising and falling as she rode her well-endowed lover right behind him.

Their sounds grew. Soft gasps, moans, Tate grunted, and growled.

"Oh fuck," he grunted, his cock squished in its silicon grip. He hunched over and almost fell out of his chair.

The sounds stopped.

When he looked up, he saw Charlie watching him over her shoulder. She had her legs over Tate's thighs and her pussy was spread by the man's erect width.

"Sorry, Jonny," she whispered.

He grimaced, turned away from them, hurting so bad between his legs.

There was a slick sound, and he was sure it was Tate withdrawing his sword from her fleshy sheath, then bare feet on the floor.

He looked to see Charlie taking Tate by both hands, naked, lifting him to stand, saying, "Come on, take me into the shower... Let's leave him alone..."

IT WAS CONSIDERATE; her taking Tate into the bathroom to fuck. But while it helped the discomfort he felt between his legs, it didn't remove it completely. He could hear the squeak of their feet in the tub, could hear what might be an elbow bump the tile wall a few times. He heard Charlie laugh. His imagination could fill in all the rest. What he imagined might be worse than what was really occurring—maybe they were just soaping each other up, making shampoo mohawks—but it was probably parallel. And wasn't the idea of them just in there naked under the water's spray and touching each other bad enough? His dick thought so, struggling with the silicon sleeve.

Regardless, the situation playing out on the couch or in the bathroom made it impossible to work. His screens had gone asleep while he sat here and tried to listen-without-listening to what transpired with his wife and the heavyweight champ just on the other side of the wall behind his computer.

The water turned off, taps squeaking and Jonny sat straight and rubbed his cheeks, massaged his temples. The doorknob clicked, and he started. There hadn't been enough time for them to dry... A lightning flash of consideration struck him—Charlie would ask him to come join them...

Charlie pranced out the door, headed for the bed. She was completely naked, her alabaster skin still wet. her gingery mane had been soaked and

ringlets of dark red hair bounced on her back. Three steps, breasts jumping, and she hurled herself on the bed with a giggle. Tate emerged now, naked as Jonny's wife. His hair was wet and slicked back from his handsome face; water ran rivulets over his muscle. Between his legs his cock stuck out straight and hard and furious looking, his huge glans like a small clenched fist. The thing couldn't be more erect, straight and out, pointing upward even though it was so large its weight wanted to succumb to gravity.

Charlie looked over her shoulder, seeing him emerging, and wagged her bottom at him; presenting as they called it in the animal kingdom. The lurid sight had Jonny bucking in his chair and leaning forward. His eyes bugged out of his head, wanting to see every detail of this but his heart and mind knew better.

So did Charlie. She said, "Jonny, is it okay to switch? I'm sorry, we can't do what we want in there. We need a bed..."

"Want m-me to go in the bathroom...?" His voice was thick, his tone nonsensical. His pulse raced at the sight of her baring herself like this to her hung lover so impressively engorged. Tate looked enormous right now.

"You don't have to," she said. "Should you?"

It's like she knew this was going to be bad and he might not want to watch. But that made him want to watch even more.

Charlie said to Tate, "Ho, wow, look how *hard* you are..."

"Is it going to be bad?" Jonny asked, his voice thinned to a quiet, sandy croak. He was sidestepping to the open bathroom door, his stomach cramping already.

Charlie didn't hear him, watching between Tate's legs as his fully hard monster barely bobbed with his steps to the bed. She bit her lower lip then let it slide away from her teeth as her smile grew.

Tate said, "You did that. Look what you did to me..." He flexed his stomach and hips and his cock flexed and lifted.

She laughed.

Tate murmured, “You and that mouth...”

“Did I do that?” she said slyly. Tate put a knee on the bed and caressed Charlie’s ass cheek. She made a purring sound and leaned to his touch. He patted her flesh lightly.

Backing into the bathroom, hunching, hands in his sweatshirt pouch, Jonny asked, “What are you guys going to do?”

Charlie said, “He’s going to show me how to take it all...”

“Take it all?”

“His whole thing,” Charlie said, looking at Tate’s cock, “all the way...”

Tate patted her ass cheek again, and she raised her eyes to meet his. She said, “All nine-point-two-five inches.”

Jonny said, “You don’t like that. You complain it hurts.”

Charlie said, “He’s going to show me how I’ll like it.”

Tate said, “You’re going to like it.”

“I believe you,” she said.

Jonny rested a hand on the doorknob, ready to close the door but unable. Whatever was going to happen he shouldn’t watch. It would crush him; crush his spirit, crush his heart, his ego, his cock, his balls...

Tate got both knees on the bed and walked close to her bent over rump, using both hands to caress her ass. One knee poking her inner thigh, he said, “Spread a little wider...”

“Like this?” She moved her knees outward and curled her ass upward, showing off her glistening slit.

“That’s perfect,” he said.

It was only one second, but Charlie’s eyes flitted to meet Jonny’s. In that moment he felt some connection, some understanding. If it’s okay with Reza, it’s okay with Tate. And she had humor in her eyes. This was fun. Tate was good to her. Tate didn’t punish. Tate was a reward. But in that quick eye-flash he also felt communication. Two things:

1) Charlie saying You probably shouldn’t watch this, Jonny

2) Charlie angled herself on the bed so if her husband watched he could see clearly what happened

He kept the door open and Tate prodded at her opening with his corpulent cock head as big as a ripe, bursting plum. Charlie's jaw levered open, her lips parting in a gasp, her face looking down her body to see this big man try to put his whole big thing all the way inside her.

Tate smoothed his hand over the small of her back, still stroking his tip against her. "Tilt your pelvis forward for me, Charlie."

"How?"

"Try to stick your perfect butt up a little higher, like you want your butt hole to point at the ceiling."

"Like this?—"

She grunted as he pushed the end of his cock past her opening and slid into her body. Her toes curled, and she moaned quietly, her head rocking like she might faint.

"Easy, easy," Tate said, sliding deeper. "Up, up, Charlie. Anus up, your belly button to the tops of your thighs..."

Charlie's eyes were closed, her face yawning in ecstasy—but her ears were working, hearing her lover. Her hips tilted, thighs flexing; her ass rolled higher—Tate's cock pushed halfway in—and her tummy expanded as she drew a deep belly breath.

"That's it," Tate said, hand going up and down from low back to tailbone, soothing her. "Does it feel okay?"

Charlie nodded. Saliva spilled over her bottom lip and she sucked it back up.

Tate's eyes cast up to the ceiling, open but unseeing, his concentration on his mind's eye. "I'm deep, Charlie, do you feel it?"

She nodded, brow furrowing.

"Keep your back arched. You feel that?"

She made a funny grunt.

“I’m touching your cervix.”

She cocked her head and made a look of discomfort. Jonny fell to the side and leaned on the doorway. His stomach felt like it turned over and got hung up in its cords and passages and was strangling itself right now.

Tate said, “Keep your back arched, keep it arched, that’s it...” He slid himself deeper until he was all the way in. Charlie’s eyebrows raised high into her hairline and her mouth hung open.

“Your uterus is tilted away, now I’m over your cervix, the tip of my cock is caressing it, but I’m past it, not pushing *into* it...”

Charlie made a silent gasp, brows still raised, eyes closed, paying attention to her own mind’s eye.

Jonny sank to his knees. His legs had turned to noodles, his balls into throbbing walnuts.

Tate said, “I won’t move. I don’t want to hurt you. You move how you want. I’m touching you where probably no man has touched you before. It’s a whole new G-spot.”

“It’s so big, it’s so big,” Charlie mouthed as her hands gripped bedding and her hips began to work.

Her cheek came to rest on the mattress, her hips humped in slow and careful increments against Tate. Tate had impaled her on that massive spear. His pubic bones were pressed into her creamy buttocks and his hands caressed her back while she worked herself against him.

“Oh gosh, it’s so deep, mm, so deep,” she moaned, hips moving with more energy, her tummy moving in and out. Tate moved one hand underneath to feel her ribs and stomach.

It went on for a long time and Jonny sank onto his heels, eyes never leaving the action, seeing his wife get the deepest pleasure she could and loving it. A little bounce began, Charlie’s hips jumping against his intrusion, setting a little jiggle through her ass cheeks. Her breaths came quicker, and she panted and sucked her lips. Jonny watched her ribs press in and out on

her sides as the pleasure grew more intense and he knew it would just be a matter of time before she had an orgasm.

Her head thrust face down in the mattress as she made a sound like she'd been thumped in the stomach. Her hands went outstretched ahead of her, and she ran herself back against Tate, stretched in an awkward looking downward dog. Tate gripped her hips and pushed himself deeply and she moaned a quavering sound into the bedding. A tremble began in her thighs, and her arms shook.

Her neck craned, her head twisted and Jonny would swear his wife wanted him to see her expression when she came. It looked like she was singing, joining in with a chorus only no sound emanated. Brows high, her jaw unlocked, her mouth in a wide open O shape with her chin jutted forward.

Something happened between his legs when she cried out. Charlie let out a gulping wail and her body bucked. She babbled nonsense for a moment, hid her face then showed it again.

“Ho smoke, ho smoke, oh, ah, oh...”

She shrieked as the height of her orgasm hit her and bared her teeth. That's when Jonny bucked and he swore a completely ruined orgasm drained and drooled from the end of his caged penis. It was a sad feeling of loss and emptying; whatever erotic nugget he could hold on to inside his core leaked out the end of his dick and he wanted it back because he didn't get to enjoy it at all. He'd give anything right now—his whole game if he had to—to touch his dick and hold his Charlie.

He slumped against the wall feeling the wet spreading through the crotch of his sweatpants, sure now he'd spewed impotent seed out of his rubber cage. His balls felt lighter, but despondent and regretful, like they wanted their contents back as well.

Charlie continued to wail and pull on the sheets with shaking, writhing fists, and Tate began a steady rhythmic bucking against her. It brought her

waning orgasm back to vivid life, and she met his gentle thrusts with her bouncing bottom. An undulating moan sang from her parted lips.

Just when he thought it was over it reached new depths of glorious hurt.

Charlie gasped in a tight squeaky voice: “Oh wait, oh no, ah...”

Her feet arched and tightened, and her knees bent, ankles squeezing along the sides of Tate’s muscular thighs. Her eyes opened wide and staring and she took a look of emergent dread. Something bad was happening. Her body tightened, cords and muscle standing out against her light frame; her hand shot between her legs to cover where she was skewered.

“Oh no, wait... stop...”

But Tate didn’t stop. His hands squeezed tighter at her sides and he pushed himself deep as he would go; the muscles of his thighs and glutes flexing; his erection inside Charlie most assuredly doing the same. Bright winking droplets spritzed up her backside and over Tate’s belly and Charlie’s rump. Charlie moaned again, this time the sound fearful and worried. Tate smiled, let his grip go.

Charlie eased forward; Jonny could see her arm shaking, her hand thrusting between her legs, jacking on her clit; her face twisted in silent, agonized ecstasy. Sprinkling eructation spattered Tate’s belly, high pressure excitement splashing around his huge intrusion inside her.

Charlie whimpered, “Oh what’s happening?—oh no...”

Tate rubbed the pad of his arced thumb over her anus in hard circles, cock still inside her; Charlie rubbed her clit; the tinkling still came. Wet droplets pattered the bedding with quiet taps.

“Oh no, oh, oh no,” Charlie continued whimpering, making embarrassed sounds in her throat, rolling forward, Tate’s erection popping out of her and wagging up and down. She thrust herself into the sheets where it was dry and brought her knees up. Her expression was bewildered, shocked.

Tate soothed her: “It’s good, Charlie, it’s good, you’re squirting...” He rested a hand on her knee.

“I am, I am,” she said, “what’s... why...?”

The hand on her knee curled inside her thigh and spread her legs. Charlie went with it, rolling onto her back but trying to keep her knees together. Both hands on her knees, Tate opened her up and lowered between her legs. She took him willingly, opening her arms to embrace him, taking his kiss as he slid that iron monster inside her once more.

The effect was immediate: Charlie gasped as though she came again, and her head rocked back; Tate kissed her neck and bit at her collar.

Nails ran red lines on Tate’s back and she hooked her ankles around his waist. Tate pounded her now until the headboard beat against the wall. It was Tate’s turn, and he was getting what he wanted now.

Jonny squeezed his cage overtop of his sweatpants wishing he hadn’t seeped out what was in his balls, wishing for that tension again; the tension brought hurt, the hurt reminded him why he worked.

Up and down, Tate’s round muscular rump drove his cock in and out of Charlie while she hollered in agonized joy underneath him; Jonny was sure she was still riding the wave of her hugest orgasm. Tate began a grunt as he got closer and when Charlie heard his sounds she recognized them, clutched her arms around his neck tight, clung to him.

“Yeah, yeah, yeah,” Tate chanted as it built. Charlie’s feet flexed, anticipating her enormous bull of a lover’s eruption inside her.

It happened then: Tate roared, arched his back, cabled muscles of his straightened arms bulging and gleaming. Charlie’s eyes were open, watching Tate as he came inside her, hands coming up and caressing his chest and stomach, admiring his hard masculine body. Her eyes gleamed, lost and wild and lusty...

IN THE AWFUL aftermath the two lovers lay in the wasteland battleground of the bed, twisted in sheets and soaked with sweat. Tate lay on his back, head on a pillow. They were diagonal across the bed, corner to corner, Charlie curled at his side with her head on his chest, his arm draped around to hug her against his muscle. She still breathed heavy and her eyes showed the wonder of what she just experienced.

Jonny breathed heavy as well. There was a certain relief in being drained. The feeling of impending explosion had expired, and his testicles felt safe once more though they still ached. At least they didn't throb with the electric pulse of a downed power line.

Charlie sighed, drew her knees up till they pressed Tate's hip; she tucked a hand between her thighs and lay it over her sex. She whispered, "What did you do to me?"

"Did you like it?" he asked her, touched his chin to the top of her head. Her hair framed her face in wet tangles still and it made her look so much younger; her eyes looked wide and innocent.

She said, "Yeah," a husky, high whisper; nodded her head. Then she added much quieter: "I tinkled everywhere."

Tate chuckled, hugged her with his arm, kissed her hairline. "We're really going to have to change these sheets now."

Charlie smiled and hid her face against his chest. With her lips squashed against him, she said, "They've got all kinds of stuff all over them."

"They sure do."

Tate's cock was still half-engorged, laying lazy on his thigh looking plump but flaccid. Charlie eyed it, smirking. She said, "Look at that thing."

Tate's eyes lowered, and he flexed his stomach.

Charlie held his cock, lifting it and cradling it in her palm as if she tested its weight.

In reflex, Jonny closed the door, but he sat in the way so he just pulled it against his knees; the door's sharp edge lined a satisfying crease of pain

across him. He couldn't help but watch even though his wife's actions were renewing the discomfort between his legs.

She held Tate's cock upright, and it sagged across her knuckles. She wagged it and made the end half bounce around. She smiled wider, said, "It's all sticky from my insides."

Tate laughed, stomach muscles flexing; his balls rolled in their sack.

Now Charlie, still admiring it, said, "If I were a boy this is exactly what I would want between my legs."

Tate said, "You would?"

"Don't you like it?"

"Of course I do."

"What you just did to me..." Her eyes went wistful, her voice trailing off.

"Wouldn't you want that every night?"

Charlie's eyes widened, trailed slowly toward Jonny, then darted back to Tate's cock. She ignored the question, saying now, "Look at the head on it. It looks like a big army helmet." Her hand stroked up the shaft to pause just under Tate's glans.

Tate laughed again, put an arm under his head to prop himself forward to watch what she did. He grew harder in her hand. Jonny watched from the shadows of the bathroom floor, trying to close himself off but still see.

Charlie said, "Look at this rim," and her thumb flicked the flared edge of the coronal ridge, watching it plop up and down as she did. "Yours is the most beautiful one I've ever seen."

Tate smiled. "Thanks, Charlie."

"Reza's is big, too, maybe bigger, but his is so scary it—"

"No, no," Tate said, losing his smile and scowling.

Charlie let his cock go, looked up to meet his eyes. Tate ran a sopping strand of hair from her cheek. "Don't say that. Don't talk about him. Don't even say his name, okay? This is *our* time together."

Charlie kept his gaze for a moment, silent, biting a little at her lip. Tate's expression softened from a scowl.

Charlie raised a knee up over his thigh till her leg touched his cock. She said, "You think you could make me tinkle again?"

AWAKE IN THE MORNING LIGHT, Jonny stared at the apartment ceiling and played back the highlights of the previous evening.

After Charlie and Tate fucked again, Charlie riding on top once more, they napped. Charlie did not tinkle, but they'd tried. Jonny worked some more, getting some coding done and working on the UX. The lovers roused. They were hungry. They ate leftover tiramisu and ordered in Chinese. Jonny ignored them, putting on his headphones till the food arrived. The three of them ate together at the kitchen table like the weirdest family that ever existed. Charlie tried to engage him though he was surly and sullen. Tate ignored him. Tate asked Charlie if she wanted to go out to a club and she said she did but they never made it. The two of them tried picking out clothing for her to wear, Charlie changing right in front of Tate, Tate's hungry eyes going all over every naked inch of her and Charlie liking it. Charlie strutted around with nothing on but high heels, leafing through her closet and Tate couldn't take it anymore. He took her down onto the bed and fucked her with her heels on. He did her from behind, they did it her on top, him on top, ankles over his shoulders... When they were done they collapsed, Tate's cock slipped out of her and she seeped his seed. She laughed and cupped her pussy and told him there was no way she could go dancing, anyway. Too sore. They cuddled, kissed, napped again. Jonny

worked with his hood still up. Some time before midnight they woke again and made love like spoons. It was slow and quiet and went on for a long time. They both came, but it was not the vocal theatrics of earlier in the day. Jonny worked till two in the morning, then shut his monitors down, stood at the foot of the bed and watched them sleeping before collapsing on the couch and sleeping in his clothes.

Now it was a little after eight in the morning and Charlie was up and stretching, smiling and bright-eyed like she'd got a great night's sleep...

SUNDAY MORNING, blue skies and sunshine beyond the window of their apartment that smelled like sweat, pussy, and semen. Jonny sat up to see Charlie flop over the bed and drum her hands on sleeping Tate's muscular mid-riff. His legs jumped up to protect himself and Charlie giggled. Their eyes met and Tate came awake, smiling and blinking at her fresh and beautiful morning demeanor; hair dry now, wild and crazy, tumbling over her creamy freckled skin. Her nipples were pointed into soft but aroused buds.

Tate held her by the elbows and she fell against him so they could kiss.

He asked her, "What do you want to do today?"

She thought about it a moment, sat up, looked over her shoulder at her husband sitting up on the couch. "I don't know," she said, "what do you want to do, Jonny?"

"Me?" He scratched his head and yawned. Visions of her and Tate at the museum yesterday came to him; the kiss in the Antiquities Museum, sharing ice cream cones, riding his shoulders. "I should work today."

"Again? You don't want to go out and do something? Look how nice it is out there..."

He looked over his shoulder, out at the bright blue sky and puffy white clouds. "You've got Tate," he said, "so I might as well take advantage of

my time.”

Tate said, “Let him stay, Charlie. We’ve got the day to ourselves. Let him work. I’ll take you out for breakfast, and we can go have some fun somewhere.”

Charlie still watched Jonny, but Tate took her arms again and got her to turn around.

“What do you want to do?” she asked him.

“I want to do whatever you want to do.”

“What about you? What things do you like to do?”

Jonny stood up and stretched, said, “Go lift weights then hit your face on stuff.”

Tate ignored him but Jonny saw a flash of hate in the guy’s eyes as he struggled to ignore the husband of the girl he was trying to woo. It made him smile a little. The pain in his testicles had subsided while he slept and there was a good chance if they got out of the apartment he could salvage the day and make some more progress on his game.

“We can find something we both want to do,” Tate said. He let her arms go, smiling hopefully, shuffled out of the bed and stood up naked. Charlie sat back on her heels and watched him go to the closet, fish through his bag and draw out a pair of folded glasses, walk across the foot of the bed to the kitchen. Jonny watched his wife as she waited to see her hunk return, half-smirk on her face, scratching at the nape of her neck under her mane of hair. Tate trotted down the steps, big dick slapping off his thighs, newspaper tucked under his arm. He sat on the couch and put his feet up on the table, unfolded the paper and opened it.

Jonny walked to his workstation and dropped his butt heavily in his leather chair. Tate opened the arms of the glasses and put them on, flipped through the paper with studious furrowed brow. He said, “How about a movie?”

“Okay,” she said and shrugged.

He flipped a few more pages, looking through his large, masculine set of Clark Kent glasses. “Oh hey,” he said now, looking up at her over the top of the frames, “how about a hockey game? There’s a minor league match at the Gardens.”

Now Charlie smiled, bare feet wagging under the covers. “Okay,” she said, “I’ve never been to a hockey game.”

“Matinee at the Marquis, Toros versus the Jets at the Gardens, but first I buy my baby a big, big breakfast.”

Charlie rose from bed now and came to the couch.

She said, “You wear glasses?”

Tate looked up over the top of the paper, paused a moment. “Just to read,” he said.

She set her bare backside on his thigh and said, “I think it’s sexy when a man wears glasses. You like to read?”

Jonny said, “Just the sports page. Maybe the comics if he’s taking a *real* long shit.”

Tate’s lip twitched, and his head flicked. It was taking a lot to hold back his rage toward Jonny and it was Charlie being in the room right now that was keeping him from stomping Jonny’s head to mush. For some reason it widened Jonny’s smile.

Charlie laughed at her husband’s joke and his heart swelled for her. She reached over the paper and slid Tate’s glasses off his face.

“What are you doing?” he said.

She took the glasses, reversed them, put them on her face. Still sitting naked in Tate’s lap, she turned at the waist, Tate’s black frame glasses looking huge on her small face, her eyes wide and blinking, looked at her husband and in a constricted, funny cartoon voice, said, “Take me to your leader.” In case he didn’t get it, she made grabby space alien hands at him and added, “beep-beep, boop-boop.”

Jonny threw his head back and laughed so hard at his wonderful Charlie tears came to his eyes. She laughed too, and he saw her smiling at him through warbled vision as she took the glasses off and folded them.

Tate liked it too though, and he took his glasses back and said, “You’re real funny, Charlie, make fun of a guy who wears glasses.” He tickled her middle, and she jumped instantly, kicking her legs. Then he gripped her waist, lifted her right off his thighs and tossed her to land on the couch, climbing over top of her and getting his mouth over hers. She sighed then moaned as they kissed and her arms circled his neck. Jonny’s heart sunk.

Tate’s hands were on her middle still, powerful fingers digging at her ribs and tummy making her squirm and laugh into his mouth.

Between guffaws she said, “Don’t tickle me, don’t tickle me...”

“You don’t like to be tickled?” Still tickling.

Between breaths she managed: “Who likes to be tickled?” Her legs kicked, but he had her pinned. Then more seriously: “Don’t, Tate, it hurts...”

“It hurts?” He stopped instantly.

“It hurts me downstairs.”

“Downstairs?”

“Between my legs. It makes me flex my tummy, then that makes me flex somewhere else.”

His hands smoothed her sides, and he took a serious expression.

She whispered, “You’ve been doing really bad things down there...”

He smirked then she smirked. Their faces came closer together and Charlie pooched her lips to be kissed. Tate wove his fingers between hers and raised her hands above her head. Jonny fidgeted with his sweatpants, feeling a discomfort beginning to squirm between his legs. He wondered how many times his wife was going to fuck this stud this weekend.

Between them, Tate’s cock slowly grew longer and fuller. It tapped on Charlie’s stomach while they kissed. Her hand came down and cradled and

caressed the underside.

“My pussy needs a break. Can we save this for later?”

Tate smiled, let her other hand go. “Yeah. I can’t wait.”

She still stroked his hardness. “Thank you.”

His eyes narrowed, and he gave a sly smile. “No shower. Let’s go out with our sex stink so everyone we meet knows we’ve been fucking all weekend.”

“Ew, gross,” she said and covered her mouth with both hands. Her knee came up and bounced his cock off its point. “Okay,” she said through her hands.

“Okay?” Tate said, brows high, smiling.

She nodded.

TRUE TO THEIR WORD, they dressed without showering. They even dared each other not to wear underwear and to Jonny’s surprise Charlie agreed. Jonny sat and watched the whole drama unfold, his body still as stone.

Tate wanted to brush his teeth, and he patted her bottom before going into the bathroom. Charlie smiled at Jonny and came to stand by his workstation. She’d dressed in sexy casual again; long legs in jeans, cowboy boots, a tight flannel shirt and a leather jacket. When she bent over to hug his head, he indeed could smell the sex off her. It was even in her hair.

“Come on to the hockey game with us, Jonny.”

“No, Charlie. It’s a perfect time for me to work.”

She set a butt cheek down on the arm of his work chair. “I’d like you to come. And we’re going to go see a movie, too...”

“I want to as well, but it’s better if I don’t.”

Now she rocked with him. He’d never felt so *below* her before. Even though she wanted to include him, he’d never felt such confidence in her.

Her time with Reza had shown her a whole new world—and now her time with Tate was coaxing her spirit out into the light. He should be happy for her but his heart just felt the threat of loneliness.

His hands came up with shaky creaking, the muscles weak and watery. He gripped her forearm with both hands and squeezed.

“Charlie...?”

She breathed against his ear for a moment. “Yeah...?”

“Don’t have sex with Tate when I’m not there. Please.”

She reared her head back so she could look in his eyes. Mouth open as if she would say something, she paused, sighed, bit her lower lip.

“You don’t want to agree to that?”

She said, “No, that’s okay. You’re right. I won’t. I don’t have to do that.”

“Really? You can still do it and all, but would you come back here?”

She gave him a small smile and nodded.

“We’ll come back here and do it.”

“Thank you.”

“But isn’t it better if you don’t see?”

He shook his head no.

“How’s your little guy doing?” She nudged her chin toward his crotch.

“Not good. Not good at all.”

“You better get so much work done while I’m at the hockey game. I don’t like having your dick in a cage.”

“Soon, baby, soon. I swear it.”

“I trust you,” she whispered.

Tate tossed his toothbrush in the cup with Charlie’s and Jonny’s, switched off the light and came out looking for Charlie. “You ready?”

Charlie jumped up and Tate grabbed her before she could go into the bathroom. He took her in his arms and kissed her.

“Minty fresh,” he said.

“Can I brush my teeth now, please?”

“I thought we wanted everyone to smell our sex smells...”

“I can’t brush my...” She got it now, him joking he wanted his cock on her breath. She smiled, batted his chest. Her hand drifted lower, cupped the bulge in the front of his jeans and they made low animal sounds at one another. Charlie realized what she did in front of her husband, shot him a sheepish look and let go of Tate’s bulge.

She disappeared in the bathroom, closed the door and brushed her teeth while Tate ignored Jonny who scowled at him the whole time, Tate sitting on the side of the bed and going through his phone.

Then Charlie was out, strutting long legs and clicking boots, smiling and waving at Jonny as she passed. Tate took her arm, and they crossed to the stairs, up to the kitchen.

Before she left, Tate holding the door open, she said to Jonny, “We’ll be home pretty late, maybe ten or eleven, okay, baby?”

“I’ll see you,” he said, wondering how he’d stop himself from following them this time.

They closed the door behind them.

Jonny pulled up his hood, turned on some music, shut down all his messenger windows, cracked his knuckles and got to fucking work...

WITHOUT FOOD, penis and its related urges caged, another man taking care of his wife, hood closed around his face, phone unplugged, methods of digital communiqué cut off, Jonny worked eleven hours straight of hyper-focus time and by nine-fifty-five he pushed himself away from the workstation, astonished.

“No way,” he whispered. “No fucking way.”

The coding was done.

Tomorrow, Shulamit and him could bolt it all together. Two weeks from now he would shop the demo. *How the hell did he do it?*

He looked between his legs, said to his penis, “Focus, that’s how, buddy, focus.”

Hot god damn dog. He stood, legs shaky from lack of use, back stiff. He hunched over and beat his fists on his knees. Two weeks from now this trap he’d got them stuck in would be dismantled. Not overnight, but strut by strut, bolt by bolt, he would take apart the framework cage-maze Reza had built around him and innocent Charlie.

A hunger hit him hard. His high-powered brain hungry for glucose after a marathon of psychic endeavor of the highest order. Fuck Reza. Fuck Tate. In a million years those two could never accomplish what he was able to do.

Up in the kitchen, he stood leaning on the open fridge door eating a slice of cold leftover Angelo's. Tonight it wasn't too bad at all. In fact, maybe two months from now he would be an Angelo's guy, too. Forty dollar pizzas would be nothing to him...

Time on the stove clock said it was 10:05. He'd really been at it nonstop for almost eleven hours. Time had flown, and so had his fingers. He'd accomplished days worth of work in a short time.

Where would Charlie be now? How long was a hockey game?

He was headed down to the family room to check the paper, see when the game started, when he heard them in the hall. Bodies collided against the apartment door, making it crack in its frame. He jumped, turned and looked.

Two people wrestled on the other side, their bodies sliding against it, jostling the doorknob. Keys jingled, dropped, more wrestling, the sound of a gasp...

Keys jingled again, cat head key fob scratching below the handle. The lock clacked, the door burst inward and Charlie and Tate stumbled in, embracing, kissing. Jonny stepped backward to the family room giving them space and avoiding being knocked down the steps.

Tate pinned her to the kitchen wall, her arms struggling, his hands clutching them. At first Jonny thought Tate was assaulting her, then realized they were both trying to get her leather jacket off.

Together they got the jacket off, except for one sleeve which still clung to Charlie's arm, the rest turned inside out. Both Charlie's hands clutched Tate's neck as they kissed, one hand still inside her sleeve. Pinned to the wall, against her back, Charlie's legs climbed Tate's waist, her cowboy boots hooking over one another under his rump. Tate pumped the crotch of his jeans against hers. Their mouths sucked on each other, their breaths coming hard and hungry.

"How was the game?" Jonny asked, but they didn't even hear him.

Tate backed up with Charlie clung to him, bashed against the fridge, lurched to the top of the stairs.

Jonny said, "Careful," seeing Tate's boots close to tumbling down the steps.

But Tate needed no help, stomping down the steps with Charlie hooked on him, kissing, biting, his palms cupping and caressing her denim bottom. At the side of the bed he tossed her off, and she bounced once on the mattress before he was on her again, both of them writhing on the still-dirty bedsheets.

Jonny stumbled further backward till he sat down on the red IKEA chair, ready to watch and have his stomach hurt. He still held a pizza crust, noticed it, threw it to the floor.

Tate clutched Charlie's shoulder, forced her to roll over onto her stomach, and she watched him over her shoulder while he did.

Now her hands went down underneath her, working on the button and zipper of her jeans. Tate was strong and too impatient, swollen hands both going down the back of her waistband and yanking hard enough the stitching tore with a high sound.

The jeans peeled back over her bare ass turned up to receive her lover, looking like a pale ripe peach. Tate kneeled, burst his own pants open and his huge erection wagged out, spitting a long strand of pre-come on to Charlie's ass. She hissed at its feel, her hands going out and grabbing sheets and twisting them up.

Pants still on, Tate shoved his huge cock into Charlie's shining, wet slit and sunk deep. She cried out and kicked her boots on the bed. His hard, thick body covered her, his denim rump rising and falling as he fucked her and Charlie wailed and gasped.

With a grip on her hair he turned her face up so he could kiss her. He growled, said, "I've wanted to fuck you all day."

"You feel so good," she said.

“You’re so wet for me.”

They fucked wild on the bed, fully clothed, jeans still on, grabbing hands and grunting like animals. Jonny groaned in delicious unwanted pain, brought his knees up and rested the soles of his feet on the seat.

Charlie was a slim, pretty stick under Tate’s big-frame brutish body and the idea that Tate’s huge, nine-point-two-five inch cock was going in and out of her—and that it brought his wife pleasure—was awful but it did something powerful to him.

One more week... One more week...

TATE FUCKED HER LIKE THAT—FACEDOWN, bare ass turned up, jeans under her cheeks—until she came with a crying shriek. Then he buried himself deep, and she wailed and kicked the toes of her cowboy boots into the mattress.

As it went on, she moaned and whimpered, Tate very deep but not thrusting, and she clenched her teeth on a mouthful of bedding. When their breathing slowed, he helped her up onto all fours, cock still buried, then pushed his own pants down his thighs.

Now he fucked her doggy-style, both of them still clothed, pants down to their knees, bare thighs slapping against bare haunches. Charlie still clutched bedsheets between her teeth, squeaking grunts coming with each thrust.

They were almost sideways to Jonny the way they fucked, and he got to see that big meat pole pushing and pulling between his wife’s thighs, her slippery pink lips clinging to him.

“Every night, Charlie,” Tate grunted, pounding her.

Charlie cried into her mouthful of bedding.

“Every night you can have this...”

The bedding fell from her mouth and a thin line of spit followed, spilling over her pouted lower lip.

Tate said, “You hear me? Every night, Charlie,”—he steadied his stroke now—“you don’t have to work, I take care of you, we can have fun, you could be fucking *safe*.”

She moaned, arched her back, whimpered, “I *am* safe.”

Tate curled over her back, took her cheeks between thumb and fingers and turned her to look at Jonny. “Safe? You’re not safe. What do you even see in him?”

“I love him...”

“You love him? Look at him...”

Charlie’s eyelashes fluttered, her narrow, lusty eyes meeting Jonny’s.

“Don’t, Tate,” Jonny said.

“Show her your cage, Jonny.”

“No.”

Charlie said, “You don’t have to, Jonny...”

“He’s doesn’t have a cock, Charlie. It looks like my thumb. All the guys laughed at him in the locker room.”

She panted and his thrusts grew quicker again.

“Feel that?” He bucked his size into her and she made a joyous cough. “That’s a man, Charlie. That’s what a man feels like.”

“I’m a man,” Jonny said, heart pounding with lust and rage.

Tate’s hips pounded and Charlie took it, closed her eyes, hair swinging while he fucked her hard from behind.

“He can’t please you... Not like I can... You need a man, a man who can take care of you...”

“I take care of her,” Jonny said, clenching his thighs together.

Charlie closed her eyes tighter, sucked her lips into her mouth and bit them. She heard every word Tate said but resisted it. Those words would bounce around inside her pretty head until she was poisoned.

“Just fuck her and shut up,” Jonny said, “Then get out of here. It’s almost midnight.”

Tate met his gaze and his face turned mean, the corners of his mouth bowing own. His grip on Charlie’s hips tightened, denting her flesh, and he fucked her even harder. She brought a knuckle up and clenched it between her teeth.

“Your husband’s a loser, Charlie, a loser. How much does he, mm, owe now?...?”

Charlie gasped and babbled.

“A hundred-fifty thou? Two-hundred? And he puts you on the line for it...?”

Jonny said, “It’s an investment,” just short of shouting.

“He’s putting you on the line...? You...? I owe money I strap on gloves and fight for it. Not my woman. *I* do. My woman would be protected. Your husband is using you.” His hips pumped fast and hard. A wet and slushy sound syncopated between them.

“No, I’m not using her. I need her...”

Tate hugged a big forearm around Charlie’s middle as he sat back, pulling her up to squat on his lap, cock still inside her. He scooted to the edge of the bed and put his feet on the floor. Charlie sunk onto him fully with her bodyweight, crying out at the deeper penetration. Tate shoved her pants further down with a thumb, sat back and opened her legs so Jonny could clearly see the way his wide cock spread Charlie’s pretty flower.

“Your husband doesn’t give a shit about you, only his game...”

His hands let her go and spread wide on the mattress behind him. With his knees bowed out, Charlie was able to get her feet on the floor. Her jeans rolled inside out but bunched just below her knees. Now with her thighs together Jonny could hardly see how Tate penetrated her. Her hands went to her chest, and she clutched her own breasts through her shirt, eyes closed

off, mouth open, hair swaying over her shoulders. She stood, knees bent, and Tate humped himself into her.

“He’s a loser, his game’s going to be nothing and you’re gonna be back to square one, in debt stuck with this guy who can’t take care of you, can’t provide for you... can’t even please you in bed with that little dick...”

Charlie moaned, bent lower and grabbed her own bare knees now, pretty hands clutched with her nails digging her soft freckled flesh.

“Reza tells guys before this is done, he’ll have your husband sucking his cock to get him wet before he—”

“There’s zero chance you dumb jock piece of shit, just come already and get the fuck out of here,” Jonny said.

Tate stood, eyes on Jonny, lifting Charlie by her waist. Her legs kicked as she struggled not to let her bodyweight sink on his cock now. He turned, lay her on the bed on her back, climbed over top of her. With her jeans still on, Charlie lifted her legs high, Tate pushed her knees up over one shoulder and bared her gaping pussy for Jonny to see. then he plunged his cock into her and she threw her head back and gave a cry.

“Come for me, Charlie,” he said.

“You come, I want... I want you to come...”

“Come, Charlie,” Tate said, low and slow, drawing his organ out and pushing it back, giving her long, tip to base strokes that had her pussy crackling.

“I came,” she gasped, “I came...”

Their mouths came together, wet sounds of smacking and suction as Tate pumped her so hard he had her boots knocking together over their heads.

As Tate began to grunt with each thrust, Charlie broke their kiss.

“Don’t come inside me...”

“Don’t...?”

She shook her head no, Tate slowed.

“Keep fucking me,” she gasped, “I want to see it, I want to see it come out...” She kicked at his back, giddy to fuck her.

Tate’s arm muscles bulged and flexed, holding himself over her, gleaming with sweat while he fucked Charlie. His thrusting tripled, getting the bed shaking, Charlie squawking, the headboard banging.

In preparation for his eruption, Charlie tugged her snap-button shirt and bared her breasts in their bra. Tate looked, saw where she wanted him to ejaculate, snorted like a bull and fucked her harder. Charlie hollered a long sound that warbled with the pounding she took. Then it was happening. Tate pulling out, clamoring to get by her side, jerking off his big cock over her, Charlie watching and holding her shirt open wide.

The first long line pulsed from him and flopped between her breasts and over her bra. She yelped and jumped, closed her eyes. Then he was spritzing her with quick, short pulses that got over her neck, her collar, up her cheeks and one line that went over her closed eye and onto her forehead. The whole time Tate roared and grunted, stroking his throbbing monster, humping it through his jacking hand.

WHEN IT WAS DONE Tate was exhausted, breathing heavy, slumping. He collapsed next to Charlie and lay with her.

For a while they were motionless but for their breathing, then Charlie brought a corner of her shirt up and silently wiped the semen off her face.

“Sorry,” Tate said.

“It’s all right,” she said.

“You okay?”

“Uh-huh,” she answered, looking up at the ceiling.

Jonny dug the heels of his palms into his eye sockets, hearing the echoes of what Tate said inside his skull. They were truths, and if those words echoed in his head, they echoed in Charlie’s, too. What Tate said was

the last thing he wanted Charlie to hear. They were like dark, deep secrets and for months he thought they were his alone—he was the only one who knew them. Now it was all on the table.

Charlie sat up now and struggled out of her tight Western shirt, head tilted forward. When she got it removed, she took bed sheets to wipe at her face again. Tate stroked her thigh.

While his heart ached and his body raced with dread, Jonny couldn't help watching how sexy his wife was. Long legs, jeans bunched around her boots, naked body but for her skimpy bra. Her beautiful, soft hair tumbled down her bare back and hid her creamy shoulders.

Tate watched her as well, laying on his side with his pants down to his knees, still-hard dick poking down into the bedsheets. He put a hand up to caress her back. Though Charlie didn't look at him, Tate had tilted his head to watch her face, both men in the room wanting to see what she would say next.

Jonny said, "It's late. I want you to go."

Charlie bit at her lower lip and averted her eyes from him. Tate still stroked her back, waiting to hear what Charlie would say.

Jonny's hands trembled, curled over the slope of the IKEA chair's arm rests. There was something building in him; this had been almost over, he was at the finish line, and just when everything seemed to be going right Tate the Executioner injected noxious chemicals into the lifeblood of his relationship with his wife. Right now that poison was coursing through their systems.

Jonny repeated, "It's time to go."

Without looking over, eyes still up at Charlie's cheek, Tate said, "It's only ten-thirty."

Charlie finally moved, hands coming up and scratching at her temples, running through her hair and gathering it behind her neck. She stared at the

floor. Right now she was realizing what a piece of shit her husband was. Right now she was seeing the bad that Jonny had done. She said, "It's late."

Tate repeated: "It's only ten-thirty."

"I'm tired," she said.

"You don't want to lay down with me? Come lay with me." He patted the mattress.

She said, "It's late. I'm done. I'm sore, too sore to do anything." She touched her pussy.

"We don't have to do anything," Tate said, and he was rubbing her back again.

"I just want to go to sleep."

"You think I should go?"

She nodded, her pouting mouth held firm but turned down in a sad crescent.

He said, "You sure you're okay?"

"Yeah."

"I'll go if you want me to."

Jonny said, "Jesus, she fucking told you. Just go."

Charlie's eyes darted up to look at him but bailed at the last moment and returned to the floor. She gathered her hands together in her lap.

Tate didn't move, his hand still on Charlie's back. Finally, he said, "It's late. I'll let you go to sleep."

Charlie nodded.

Tate went over, put his heels on the bed and arched his back, pulling up his jeans, taking great effort to shove his half-erect cock in his jeans then zipping them up with care.

He rolled over to the opposite side of the bed and put his feet down, stood up and began putting items into his athletic bag without saying anything. The room was silent while he worked, just the sound of his

fingernails zipping along the nylon as he shoved unfolded shirts and pants and underwear in there. He went to the bathroom to get his toothbrush.

“Hey,” Jonny whispered to Charlie.

She shook her head no and didn’t answer. His stomach turned over.

Tate was out now, bag packed, held in one hand, shirt back on and tucked in. His cock still humped out the front of his pants. He came to stand next to Charlie who still sat on the bed.

He put a hand on her shoulder, said, “Sorry if what I said was harsh. But you gotta wake up. You have to look around and see what you’re worth. Don’t waste your life.”

Charlie nodded but wouldn’t look up.

He said, “That beating I took, that Ukrainian got me in the face...? It was all worth it. You’re so worth it, Charlie. You’re worth more than anything on this world. I’d do anything for you. You hear me?”

She nodded again, looked up now at him. Her eyes were wet and shining in the low lamp light.

Tate smiled now. “There she is. Charlie, I had the best weekend of my life with you. I mean it...”

“Thank you,” she said.

“You think about what I said?”

She nodded again. “Thank you, too. It was amazing. I had a lot of fun.” She put her hands up for him to hold them and he did. She tilted her chin for a kiss and Tate gave her one. He cupped her neck, and they sucked on each other’s mouths for almost a minute. When he stopped, he ran his thumb over her cheekbone and smiled. She gave him one back though hers was weak and tired.

“I hope you’re okay.”

“I am.”

“Call me. Okay? Text me anytime. Call me anytime. I want to hear from you.”

“I will,” she said.

He took both her hands and squeezed them again, smiled just to get one out of her. She gave him one.

“Okay, I got to get going. You go to sleep. I guess I’ll see you tomorrow morning. I’m taking you to work.”

“Okay.”

He couldn’t leave her. He bent at the waist and cupped the back of her neck, kissed the very top of her head and smelled her hair. “All right, that’s it, I gotta go, I know,” he said finally.

Without even looking at Jonny, not even turning to give him a wicked scowl, he left, boots clomping up the steps, going into the kitchen, closing the door behind him with a careful click.

CHARLIE SAT ON THE BED, boots on the floor, pants hooped around her ankles, staring at nothing for a long while. She breathed soft and slow, sighed.

“What are you thinking?” he said at last, worried about her answer, wishing he hadn’t asked, but knowing he had to.

She shrugged, her face turned down and morose. Now her hand worked through her hair, finding a tangle and wincing, knowing it was caused by Tate’s semen. She worked it out with her fingers while she kicked her heels on the floor. When it was free, she raked her fingers through her hair and stood. She bent, grabbed her pants and pulled them up, shimmying them on cause they were tight. Zipped and buttoned she ran her hands over her bare tummy. This was where she would get her shirt on, pack a bag and go stay with Genesis. Or worse, tell him to leave.

Instead, she walked across to him, paused standing at his knees in jeans, boots, and bra and looking like the best thing ever existed.

She asked him: “Are you okay?”

“Am I okay? Me? No. I don’t know...”

Her mouth quirked to one side, and she sighed again. Now she put a knee down on the seat on the outside of his thigh, doing the same with the other and straddling his lap. Her tight denim butt rested on his knees.

Now she leaned forward and put her arms around him. His heart soared and his temples beat hard with the rhythm of its pulse.

“What’s that for?” he whispered. His hands went to her bare back, traced the soft feel of her cool skin.

“We made it,” she whispered.

“The weekend?”

She nodded her chin in his collar.

“We did,” he said, allowing himself to enjoy the moment for now.

“Was it all right?”

“For me? I made it. I made it, Charlie. Was it all right for you?”

“Yeah, it was good,” she sighed. “Thank you for not being too difficult.”

“I was a *little* difficult.”

“A little but you let it happen. Thank you.”

He paused, waiting to ask a question he wanted to pose but afraid of the answer. “Did you enjoy it?”

She took a few slow breaths, squeezed her arms on him. “I did.”

He nodded so she would feel it. “I don’t mind that you enjoyed it.”

“Good.”

“It’s better than Reza. Cause I know you enjoyed it.”

“See? You’re not selfish at all any more.”

“I was. Now I’m not.” He held her a little while longer but couldn’t avoid it. “Are we not going to talk about what he said?”

“Do you want to?”

The truth was no, he didn’t. But it was out there, she’d heard it, and not talking about it was like waiting for the other shoe to drop, the one where she said enough was enough. “You’re thinking about it?”

She nodded.

“What do you think?”

She shrugged. “I’m sorry he said those things, Jonny.”

“You are?”

“I like Tate. I really do.”

“You do?” He took her bare shoulders and guided her to sit up so he could look in her eyes.

She rolled them, mouth fidgeting. She said, “I thought he was nice, but he said all those mean things about you. What a jerk.”

“You think he’s a jerk?”

“He thinks he’s so great, but he’s just like the other ones.”

“The other guys?”

“Mean in their hearts. He’s not the meanest, but he’s got it in him.”

“He does, Charlie,” Jonny said.

“He’s got that amazing body and that big dick but he’s kind of a... *jerk.*”

“You don’t think he was nice to you?”

“Nice in the way guys are nice when they want something, sure.”

“Like an act?”

“Yeah, Mr. Nice Guy, whatever you want to do, Charlie... Until he knows you for a month and then it’s like, Did you make dinner, I’m going out tonight, where’s my socks?”

“Where’s his socks?”

“Or whatever,” she laughed. “You know what I’m saying. It’s an act. Trying to be what he thinks I want him to be.”

“No one tricks my Charlie.”

“You did. Tricked me right into a wedding dress.” She wiggled her ring finger at him, wedding band shining.

“I didn’t trick you at all.”

She smiled. “No. I wanted it. You make me feel safe.”

“Safe? No way I could beat up that Ukrainian dude.”

“You make me feel a different kind of safe. Safe in here,” she jerked a thumb between her breasts.

“Your heart.”

“Uh-huh.” She nodded.

They hugged again and feeling her breathing in his arms brought a tear to his eye.

Near his ear, she whispered, “Those mean things he said are mean to me. Doesn’t he get it?”

“No.”

She sat up again, patted his chest. “If you’re a loser, then I’m a loser. Doesn’t he see that? I’m not a loser, Jonny.”

“You’re not, Charlie.”

“I’m a winner. We’re both winners. We’re just young and we haven’t won yet. But we’re not losers.”

He smiled uneasily, said, “You don’t think I’m a loser?”

“No way, mister. I hitched my cart to your dreams cause I believe in you.”

“I believe in you, too. Hey... I’m done. The game is done. I’ll piece it together this week, but creation is done. I finished today while you went to the hockey game.”

Charlie smiled wide and warm. “See? Does that sound like a loser? You’re my winner, Jonny.” She cupped his cheeks and stared in his eyes.

One more doozy to go, he took a breath before asking: “Do you think I have a little dick?”

“It doesn’t matter, Jonny.”

“Sure it does.”

“This dick is my favorite dick in the whole world. I married it, didn’t I?” Her hand slipped between them and squeezed the head of his rubber cage through his pants.

He flinched and jumped. “You didn’t know there were bigger ones out there.”

“I still love it, Jonny. It suits me just fine, plus I love the guy it’s sticking out of.”

He breathed a chuckling exhale into her collar then bit her neck.

“Did all those guys laugh at your penis in the locker room?”

“Not really. A little.”

“That would be mean.”

“Guys can be mean,” he said. “Sometimes they think it’s just being funny.”

“Girls, too,” she said.

Their eyes met, and he allowed himself a smile. She gave him one in return. His eyes narrowed, and she saw he was thinking something sly.

She asked him, “What...?”

“He was saying those mean things you didn’t like while he was having sex with you...”

“Uh-huh...”

“You were mad at him, and you let him do that?” To show he wasn’t mad, he kissed her chin.

She scrunched her face up in embarrassment. “He’s *really* good at it.”

He laughed and hugged her hard and she rocked in his lap. She said, “Is that okay?”

“It’s okay,” he said, “and for some reason I like it.”

“You do?”

“I don’t know why, Charlie, but I do. You like it even if you don’t like him?”

“Jonny, that’s what I’ve been saying. You only realize it now? And, hey, you want to know something else weird...”

“Yeah?”

“I didn’t want to say it, but I think his glasses were fake.”

“What...? No...” He laughed at the idea.

“I put them on and it was like looking through a window.”

“He can see fine? He just wanted you to think he was smart?”

“I think so.”

“What a fucking loser,” Jonny laughed. Then in a mock dumb-jock voice, he said, “Look at me I’m so smart I read and stuff, I readed so much d’uh-I needed glasses.”

Charlie laughed until she couldn’t breathe, just shaking with her mouth open and making no sound.

When she recovered he said, “Do you like Tate or not?”

“He’s nice but I know he’s not that nice. “

“You let him stay to have sex...”

“It feels so good.”

“You’re so bad.”

She laughed, hid her face. “Why? Cause I like having sex?”

“You know that’s not why...”

She laughed again, let him see her. “He’s got a nice one, Jonny, and he knows how to use it.”

“Oh my God, you’re killing me.” He flexed his thighs and squeezed her.

“I wish to God, Jonny, on my heart of hearts, you weren’t wearing a cage right now. I would jump on you so hard.”

“One more week, Charlie.”

“I can’t wait, Jonny...”

He held her, smiling and rocking. “You know what?... I think I like your little star.”

“Do you?”

“I think I do,” he said, running the cushion of his middle finger around the curve of her buttock, trying to pinpoint her tattoo, his other hand pulling her waistband back.

Her eyes rolled up, thinking, smiling. “Careful,” she reminded him, “it’s a little sore still... that’s it, a little to the left...”

He ran his finger where she told him.

“That’s it there.”

He tapped it and she bit her lower lip.

“One more week,” he sighed.

“No, it’s not...”

He frowned, a nervous twinge clicking up his neck. “What do you mean?”

“Aren’t you supposed to be smart?”

“What...?”

“It’s Sunday night, Jonny. It’s only like four days and fifteen hours, or something.”

“Oh my God, you’re right.”

“It’s hardly any time at all. Enough time I can tease you, show you my bare butt and maybe flash you a few times so you’re on your knees by Friday night.”

“Don’t you dare, Charlie.”

She folded her arms around behind her, unclasped her bra. She pulled a cup down to show him a hardened brown bud.

“Don’t, Charlie, don’t,” he said, squirming underneath her as the cage squeezed on him, wishing he had the willpower to look away.

She closed it up, leaned to rub the tip of her nose against his. “You know you love it...”

“Maybe I do,” he admitted.

“I’m getting ready for bed, Jonny, and I think there’s space for two if you want to cuddle.”

He couldn’t answer. His face went tight and hard, lips pursed in the strangest reaction. He was so happy he almost cried. He nodded in quick hard dashes.

She smiled, slunk herself off him in reverse, running her nails along his legs. He watched her strut to the bathroom.

He chuckled and smiled, looked at the closed door.

His phone buzzed, and he pulled it from his pouch, checked it. Reza.

Reza: change those spunky sheets, Jonny, I'm in the air. I'll be home and hard in six hours tell Charlie to ice that little kitty cat

His arm whipped back, posed to throw. He gripped his phone so hard it made a quiet crack. The bathroom door opened and Charlie came out naked, covering up with a forearm barred across her breasts, a hand tucked over her kitty cat. She made a scrunchy face and said "Come on, get in bed, I still smell like sex..."

He nodded, his face grim. His eyes flitted to the corners of the apartment, wondering where Reza had cameras.

She worried she'd hurt his feelings. "What's wrong?"

He forced a smile. "Nothing, nothing at all." He chucked his phone onto the floor, took off his sweatshirt. "We can cuddle for five hours then I have to get back to work."

She gave him a look of admiration. "And Tate called you a loser..."

AFTERWORD

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